Humor as a Feeling of Life

(The Great Humor)

A Psychological Study

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Translated from the Danish

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By the Same Author

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I. Humor as a Total Feeling

1. No mental state is altogether simple. As far as observation can reach, leaving aside *[7]* everything due to the influence of reflection, it always finds a greater or lesser multiplicity of need or drive, sensation, pleasure and pain, representation — in short, of what in a word can be called psychical elements; and it also finds a looser or firmer connection among these elements. Every mental state is a totality within which a certain continuity asserts itself, so that a sharp distinction among the different elements always remains more or less artificial.

Continuity asserts itself also among the different mental states in their relation to one another. The states often pass imperceptibly into one another, and where the transition happens suddenly, with a jolt or a blow, it is just this suddenness that makes the following state have its character determined by its contrast to the preceding one, so that it cannot be understood without it. There is always something artificial in keeping the different mental states sharply apart.

When, nonetheless, by way of introduction to the inquiry to be undertaken here, I distinguish between single states and total states, I find the difference between them in this: the former are determined by a single experience, while the latter are determined by a series of experiences. However full a content a single state may have, this content — sensations, thoughts, drives, feelings — is still conditioned by its common relation to a single experience. In the coming-to-be of total states, on the other hand, several, perhaps many experiences have had a part. There are of course many transitional forms between *[8]* a single experience and a series of experiences. Altogether single is only the experience of a multiplicity given simultaneously, for example the sight of a group of people or things at rest. When it is a successive multiplicity that is experienced, as when one hears a melody or follows the outline of a figure, or when a historical event unfolds over a longer

time, the experience consists of a series of single experiences. It then depends on whether the single episodes, in their relation to the one who experiences them, appear in an inner connection; only then will a real total state be able to arise. Were there absolutely no connection among the experiences, there would in the end, so far as we can see, be no mental states whatsoever.

The arising of single states already presents difficulties enough for psychological research; but total states contain by the nature of the case still greater problems. Simple single states can perhaps be called forth experimentally, and in any case one need not extend one's consideration beyond certain relatively simple and surveyable relations. One can use analogies from physiology, indeed perhaps from mechanics. Total states, on the other hand, are harder to analyze. They demand a greater knowledge of the whole developmental history of the mental life of the person concerned, perhaps also of the time and the people to which he belongs, indeed even of the spiritual development of the past. A historical (comparative, sociological) method must be used beside the observing and analyzing method. No wonder that psychologists have by preference kept to single states, and have often thought that total states could without more ado be understood from them, just as mechanical wholes can be understood when one only knows the parts.

Before we go further, let us give some examples of single states.

In the midst of the mood that a fine spring morning has called forth, I suddenly receive sad news. Everything now gathers for me around the message; its content lays claim to all reflection; its intrusion into relations that are dear to me is drawn before me
[9] in broad strokes; the bright mood gives way to dejection and dull sinking; everything that otherwise gave life worth vanishes from consciousness. Attempts to think away what has happened, or to find means of averting its consequences, are checked by the insight into the inevitable. The organic feeling of life, my whole state, takes on the stamp of inhibition, of depression. No thought can come up if it does not concern what has happened. The day's work is done under compulsion, without inner assent. After a single moment's forgetfulness the dark reality stands before me again in its whole extent. And there may even stir a striving to immerse oneself fully in the dark reality and to keep all light out; indeed, one can feel pangs of conscience at having been able to think of other things at all.

Another example. A new idea dawns on a thinker. He sees the possibility of an

entirely new direction in research. With the force of intuition, which is all the greater the more a period of doubt, discouragement and unsuccessful attempts has gone before, views now open onto new regions, and scattered paths meet before his eye in a common goal. A sudden concentration has taken place; a synthetic intuition[1] has formed. Not only the life of thought, the whole mental life is set in strong motion. No interest other than the intellectual can assert itself, no other striving; and yet the highest enthusiasm is present. An experience of this kind was had by René Descartes on the 10th of November 1619, while he lay in winter quarters in Bavaria, when after long seeking it dawned on him which way he was to follow in his research, the main features of his future philosophical and mathematical work being revealed to him.[2] When the enthusiasm, the sudden single state, had spread itself out, there came the work of long years; indeed, only eighteen years later did his fundamental work see the light. — The history of art offers similar examples. Well known, thus, is Mozart's description of how motifs he had often hummed to himself involuntarily gathered into a whole of tones that stood before him all at once (gleich Alles zusammen), so that he could survey it as if it were a painting or a piece of *[10]* sculpture. Rousseau's conception of the problem of culture shows similar traits.

A third example. After long deliberation I have taken a decision in an important matter. My whole being, that is, all thought, feeling and striving, gathers on one point, in one wish, which is nevertheless more than a wish, since I already see myself in the act of carrying out the action, and since its effects, which I acknowledge as mine, are drawn before me in more or less clear outline. I seem to notice that something from within me, perhaps from my innermost, streams out into the imagined future in which the action is to take place. My whole self, such as it now is, finds vent in the decision, comes through it to breathe out.[3]

A last example I take from Ludvig Feilberg's rich collection of single states. Feilberg's strength and weakness is that he is all too taken up with single states; but he describes them with mastery. Total states he is inclined to look down on as less genuine. Nor do they let themselves be so easily caught in flight, and they cannot be described as vividly

[1] See my paper on *Begrebet Intuition* (Vid. Selsk. Oversigt 1914) p. 81. (Also *Henri Bergson's Filosofi* p. 24 f.).

[2] *Den nyere Filosofis Historie.*[2] I p. 205.

[3] Cf. on the psychology of decision my *Psykologi i Omrids paa Grundlag af Erfaring* VII B, 2 (sixth edition p. 409–411).

as, for example, the following little experience. "A small, freshly fallen green chestnut lay on the paving under Holberg's tree beside some fallen twigs, older fallen chestnuts and half-withered chestnut blossoms, which the wind had swept together. It was surprising to see how beautiful it was in these surroundings; it had not been so at all while it hung on the tree. On the contrary, the little prickly thing, which was a reminder that the time of blossoms was over, had then rather aroused displeasure. Here it was quite peculiarly cozy. One could not help noticing it."[4]

2. These examples of single states have deliberately not been chosen among the simplest. They have the distinguishing mark that in each of them a manifold content gathers around a relatively simple outer or inner experience. Even had we chosen quite
[11] simple single states, it would still have turned out that conditions owed to the person's earlier experiences are always presupposed. Thousands have seen green chestnuts lying in Fiolstræde without experiencing what Feilberg experienced, and the prize question that made the problem of culture dawn on Rousseau has been seen by many without working as it worked on him. Single states too can thus have a historical character. Whether individuals in experiments on physiological time react sensorially or motorially will, at least at the beginning, depend on their practice and habits. In small things as in great it turns out that our present cannot be understood without our past. But this holds in a quite special degree of total states, which are determined by a long series of different experiences. Each of these experiences has called forth its single state, and it is through these single states that a total state can come to be. The presupposition is that they do not vanish without a trace, but leave behind dispositions that can take part in the arising of later states. All recognition and all recollection, as well as all reflection, rests on this. Not least does this accumulation work in the domain of the life of feeling. Through the alternation of joy and sorrow, hope and fear, enthusiasm and dejection, new, lasting fundamental moods can work their way forward. In conflict with inherited dispositions there is shaped through the series of experiences what, in a more involuntary, nature-bound form, we call temperament, and, by more or less conscious striving and acting, call character. In my Psychology (V B, 5) I introduced the expression *real self* to denote what is thus partly the presupposition, partly the effect, of the influence of experiences on mental states.

[4] *Ludvig Feilberg: Samlede Skrifter.* I p. 172.

To forestall a misunderstanding that is all too frequent even among excellent psychologists, it must be expressly stressed that this real self need not be an object of consciousness for the individual himself. It need not give rise to any "representation of the self." That the word "I" is used relatively early means nothing; it is at first a mere name, a name of which the child later discovers to its great surprise that it is a name all people claim with the same right to have. There can be a ruling interest and striving — and with it a real self — without any representation of it being formed, — without its becoming an object. The real self can undergo even very far-reaching changes without the individual *[12]* becoming conscious of it. The changes show themselves immediately and involuntarily in his conduct and perhaps thereby become apparent to others, although the individual himself does not discover them.

Ludvig Feilberg even went so far as to want to abolish altogether words like "self" or "personality," except insofar as they could be used in a reproachful sense, namely of conceited self-consciousness, refined self-absorption, that circles in a demanding way about its own little world instead of forgetting itself in "Ligeløb." He was so taken up with the flowers he found in his psychological botanizing that he did not see how, in and through the series of single states, a mental order of nature can show itself, which forms precisely the basis of what psychology means by words like I, self or personality. — In his later writings, however, he had become clear about the misunderstandings to which his polemic against "personality" could give rise.

It is true enough that express consciousness of what stirs in us can be hazardous insofar as it leads beyond the immediate and involuntary, which is the fruitful natural ground of spiritual life. But just as instinct can lead the animal into the trap, so the involuntary unfolding of life can very easily turn to harm, and it can be necessary for self-preservation that we bethink ourselves which way can lead us to our goal. It will then often be necessary to push the involuntary urge aside. It is especially at such turning points that we become conscious of our real self, as we turn our attention to our inner being, to our central striving, and it can then mean a great advance that consciousness makes itself its object.

With regard to the real self, total states are more decisive than single states. These latter can vanish without far-reaching effects, without standing, either in their arising or through their influence, in close connection with what in us is the properly central.

Psychology does assume that all states and experiences deposit effects and contribute to the development of the inner order of nature, and so directly or indirectly, positively
[13] or negatively, work to produce total states.[5] But with this assumption what is set up is properly only a great ideal for psychological research, an ideal that must constantly be kept in view, but whose realization will always be incomplete. Moreover, it will not always be a single total state that comes to rule. Several total states can follow one another in the same person's life, perhaps even to the degree that the very concept of a real self can become problematic in the particular case. In very marked personalities, however, there will be a total state that gives everything else in the mental life its peculiar character. It need not be present uninterruptedly; but it constantly exerts its after-effects and in any case plays an indirect part. And in the moments decisive for the personality it will be the one that has the word. It is to it that the personality swings back when collection, concentration is needed. It expresses the inner man, whether or not this is accessible to others. In some natures, which have been called the "once-born" ("the singly born"), the whole of life will be borne by the same total state, even if moods and ripples arise that are not conditioned by it through and through, and even if, when action is called for under particular circumstances, emotions can arise that seem to have nothing to do with it. The ends a person sets himself are on the whole determined by the total state ruling in him, the prevailing disposition. But when work and struggle are needed for these ends, thought and emotion can be released, owing to obstacles that present
[14] themselves or means that must be procured, which in and of themselves do not belong to the total state. Love of mankind can thus lead to fighting resistance with courage and indignation; love of country can release warlike moods; intellectual or artistic enthusiasm can lead to bitterness against spiritual dullness and brutality. The famous criminologist Anselm v. Feuerbach laid particular weight on this apparent contrast between disposition and emotion as necessary for understanding criminal characters. (See Psychology VI E, 5).

[5] The so-called psychoanalytic school in psychiatry (Freud and his disciples) has lately laid great weight on the fact that experiences of far-reaching significance continually go on exerting their influence on the mind and can thereby become the cause of mental illnesses. Under hypnosis or in dreams the patient may come to betray such experiences, while otherwise he perhaps involuntarily or voluntarily seeks to repress them. In particular a certain group of mental illnesses (the "hysterical") are explained as effects of mental wounds (as traumatic neuroses), and it becomes the doctor's task to discover these wounds and to heal them by drawing them forth into clear consciousness and making them an object of understanding.

In the "twice-born" ("the doubly born") the ruling total state is acquired through a break or a crisis by which tendencies present beforehand are pushed back. Continuity is not so plainly evident here as in the once-born, although a deeper investigation can often show that the new and the old disposition have a common stamp despite the wholly different direction in which the development of the mental life takes place within them. While the development of the once-born consists in an unfolding, the mental life of the twice-born is conditioned by the overcoming of inner disharmonies.[6]

Examples of total states have already been indicated in what precedes, and I shall add only a few more. Reverence, wistfulness, resignation, faithfulness, the joy of knowledge are total states when they presuppose a series of experiences of life, experiences of a more or less composite and intensive kind. They are then different from a momentary flaring up and from instinctive striving, from decisions called forth by passing situations, as well as from moods and impulses that vanish as quickly as they come. But in their conflict with practical circumstances they can take such more elementary psychical functions into their service. In general it is ruling total states that underlie every attempt to characterize personalities, every statement of the qualities regarded as peculiar to a person.

Already in Plato there is an apt description of how the total state comes to be. In the *[15]* fourth book of the "Republic" (p. 429 D E) he compares the different experiences with the different layers of color that must be applied to a material before the particular color one wishes the material to have can be applied. "You know, surely, that when the dyers want to dye wool purple, they first select from the many colors one kind, namely the white, and then work it over with manifold preparations, so that it may take the purple in the best way, and only then do they dye. What is dyed in this way is fast, and no washing can rob it of its color!" The quality or total state whose condition Plato wants to state is courage, not in the sense of involuntary boldness, but in the sense of the energy to hold fast under all circumstances to the conviction of what is rightly to be feared and what not. It is the total state of firmness of character or of faithfulness that he wants to describe. He wants to point out the way education must go to be able to lead to such a state. Real life naturally does not go about it so systematically as he wants to proceed in preparing the qualities of character he wants to cultivate. In return, life's course can

[6]The two designations go back to Francis Newman (the Cardinal's humanist brother). The two types are often described, under various names, in recent psychology of religion. Cf. my *Religionsfilosofi*[2] p. 258–261 and *Mindre Arbejder.* Second series. p. 124 f.; 134 f.

lead to a richer multiplicity of qualities of character in different people. Fate "grounds" us with a series of strokes of color before the total state comes to be that conditions the peculiar tone of color of our character.

3. By different paths experiences can come into contact with one another, so that they can enter into connections, and under the influence of these new total states can be formed within the mental life.

It is customary to distinguish three kinds of elements, sides or qualities that reflection can distinguish in every mental state, namely cognition (sensation and representation), feeling of pleasure and pain, striving or willing. If we use this threefold division, which there is no reason to abandon,[7] there will be three groups of laws or tendencies that
[16] can be assumed to play a part in the arising of total states. Whether they also assert themselves in the arising of the very simplest single states is a very difficult question. For we may not assume without more ado that the divisions or distinctions that reflection can and must make when it makes the mental life an object of inquiry also hold for the primitive forms of the mental life. Psychological analysis offers no complete analogy to chemical analysis. A compound substance can be dissolved into parts that can exist each by itself, independently of the compound. But what we can distinguish in the psychical states actually before us are not parts that could have existence apart from the whole in which we think we discover them. There exists no pure knowing, feeling or willing, always only complexes of these psychical elements. And these complexes prove to be the more intimately joined the further back we go in the history of the mental life. So far as we know this history, for the individual person and for the race, it is a main feature that the later stages present marked differences that do not appear at earlier stages, and that we have no right to presuppose there. That threefold division therefore holds only for the later stages of the mental life, in the adult as opposed to the child, in man as opposed to the animal, in civilized people as opposed to barbarians and savages. A schematic and deductive treatment of psychology, which would combine the states that appear with the character of a whole out of the elements that can be distinguished within the more highly developed mental life, therefore leads to illusory results.[8]

[7] See my paper on *Begrebet Villie* (Mindre Arbejder. Third series).

[8] See more on this my *Psykologi* ch. 4 and *Den menneskelige Tanke* (1909) p. 9–19. — On the basis of comparative psychology *Edward Thorndike* has energetically urged this truth. "The old conception of human conscious life," he says *(Animal Intelligence.* New York 1911. p. 154), "is that it is built up of

As regards the elements of cognition, the association of representations is the most *[17]* important phenomenon. Most psychologists assume that at the ground of all connection of representations there lies a need or tendency to fill out representations that appear relatively isolated and to incorporate them into a whole. What has formerly been experienced in connection, but is now experienced only in isolation, is filled out to the earlier whole, and this can be further filled out and widened when new experiences show the possibility of still more comprehensive wholes. A tendency can moreover be traced to continue a series of representations once begun according to the same rule that has so far led from member to member, even if there are no immediate experiences of more members than those so far given. Such transitions from given representations to related representations will occur especially when the mind is lively and when more energy has been released by the given representations than can be used up in holding them fast; then the mind moves circling about them.

When, again, different series of representations are held together, new connections or formations of wholes can arise in that a member of the one series proves capable of being put in (substituted) in place of a member of the other series. A single series too can be altered so that a new whole is formed, namely when members within the series can be dropped out in such a way that the law of the series continues to hold for the remaining members. In these ways arise inferences, which are logical formations of wholes.[9]

In the course of such processes of representation the elements of feeling behave in different ways.[10] Often they are drawn, through connections of representations, over from their original causes or objects to others. A shifting of value thereby becomes possible, since what at first had value merely as means can acquire value as end, or what stood as end can in future come to stand as means to a more remote end. But it is also possible that the elements of feeling hinder or check connections of representations that, seen purely objectively or intellectually, would lie near at hand. A representation once tied to strong *[18]*

elementary sensations, — that very small fragments of consciousness (bits of consciousness) arise first, and that these are then gradually built up into complex tissues." In contrast to this he maintains that "development does not proceed from the small and simple to the large and complex, but from immediate connection to mediate connection, within which a host of isolated elements appear, — from pure experience or undifferentiated states to the arising of differences on the one hand, generalizations and abstractions on the other."

[9] See more on this *Den menneskelige Tanke.* p. 168–173.

[10] Cf. with regard to what follows the section on feeling (ch. VI) in my Psychology.

feeling is isolated by it, and if association is possible at all, only such representations will have a chance of asserting themselves as immediately or mediately favor the holding fast of the given representation. In addition, an immediate influence can undoubtedly be exerted by elements of feeling tied to one circle of representations on elements of feeling tied to another circle of representations. Where two circles of representations are simultaneous or in immediate succession, not only the representations themselves but also the elements of feeling tied to them can come into immediate contact. And here several possibilities present themselves. The contrast may be so strong that tension arises and the unity of consciousness is perhaps even threatened with dissolution. But it may also be that the one mood prepares the way for the other precisely by exhausting the force available in a certain direction, so that the opposite direction is favored as long as there is any force left at all. In that case the one mood favors the other by the effect of contrast. It may further be that the feeling strikes so deep a root in the mind that it does not cease even when the occasion that called it forth ceases, but spreads over the whole state and drives out the feelings tied to other experiences, if such have been able to assert themselves at all.

But besides these possibilities there is yet another, which is of special interest for the following inquiry. Elements of feeling tied to different experiences can enter into connections with one another, so that complexes of feeling arise. Experience shows, as will be developed more fully later in a special context, that there are two main forms of such totalities of feeling or total feelings. The connection of the different elements of feeling can have the character of a *fusion*, in that by virtue of the connection a new feeling arises with a quality different from that of the preceding feelings. Only by exploring the developmental history of the new feeling can one discover which elements have taken part in this formation; to immediate observation it stands as simple and undivided. Another kind of total feeling has the character of *organization*, in that the independence
[19] of the different elements of feeling is not abolished, but they order themselves among one another according to their relation to and significance for a ruling interest, a fundamental value, which can find expression in a guiding thought.

There are analogous forms of wholes within the other sides of the mental life. An analogy to fusion within the psychology of cognition is offered, for example, by the way in which to a series of sense impressions following one another very quickly there

corresponds only a single sensation, whereas with a slower succession a series of separate sensations would arise. In immediate recognition there takes place a fusion of the momentary sensation with the after-effect of earlier sensations of the same kind. Representations that have frequently appeared in immediate connection can come to form a single representation; so in the passage from discursive inquiry to intuitive knowledge. An analogy to the organization of a group of feelings is formed by sense perception, in which a multiplicity of contents of sensation are ordered in time and space, and the same holds of images of memory and fantasy. In the domain of the life of the will we have an analogy to fusion in instinct and drive with their immediate concentration, and an analogy to organization in the way in which the thought of an end to be realized determines the order of rank among the means to be used or the actions to be performed; they all belong to the decision, are enclosed by it, and make up an articulated whole within it.

All forms of wholes in the domains of cognition and feeling will in the end be conditioned and determined by the striving for persistence and development that asserts itself in every living being, that is, by a willing in the widest sense of this word. What is to live must appear as a more or less closed whole. Pleasure and pain are in the end only symptoms of whether this striving is furthered or checked; sense sensations serve to release reactions toward the surrounding world; and representations and connections of representations serve to hold fast and shape ends and means where involuntary need and ability do not suffice. Spinoza remains right in his assertion that we do not strive for, will or desire anything because we regard it as good, but we regard it as good because *[20]* we strive for, will and desire it.

It is therefore no accident that total states are formed. How far the formation of wholes advances in individual people, and in the individual person within a single period of life, will depend on the special inner and outer circumstances. The mental life hardly ever becomes fully totalized. Partly there will be single states that stand relatively isolated, partly different total states will be able to clash with one another. Therefore there is psychical work to be done as long as life lasts.

4. Total states may well have been able to form in human consciousness at all times. But they will appear more easily when experiences become richer and more manifold. Therefore they will be more prominent in recent times than in older times, and they will

be more marked, present more nuances and more individual differences than in earlier times, when life was led within a narrower horizon, when the very picture of the world was limited and surveyable, and when historical experience too did not open wider vistas and numerous possibilities to view. One must, however, take good care not to make the contrast in this respect greater than is justified. What asserts itself with full clarity when circumstances bring contrasts and differences with them may have been present in a more undifferentiated form at earlier stages, just as one can see in the embryo indications of the organs later fully developed. If the tendency to the formation of total states has its ground in the very nature and conditions of the mental life, it must be assumed to be present at all stages of the development of the mental life. It would be an important task for comparative psychological research to investigate this more closely.

Here it must not be overlooked that the appearance of total states is not necessarily accompanied by the ability to describe and analyze them. Complex states are often characterized by an awkward psychology by a single feature that is thought to include the whole within itself. And since the intellectual side of the mental life lies most clearly in view, primitive psychology will speak most of thought, reason and knowledge, which
[21] for it then mean not merely a single side of the mental life but comprise everything, including what to a more penetrating analysis stands as particular sides of the mental life. The personality and activity of Socrates, for example, become unintelligible if one does not hold fast that by the knowledge in which he saw the foundation of right action he meant "something strong, guiding and ruling," "strong enough to help man through life" (Plato's Protagoras p. 357 B C). A distinction between knowing and willing, between head and heart, asserted itself only later; in any case the ability to grasp and characterize relations of cleavage and conflict was lacking. Of total states, again, those that have arisen by fusion will be especially hard to describe, whereas the form of organization lets itself be analyzed more easily.

Total states will as a rule not have the firm and balanced character of single states. The contrasts that are overcome and joined in them can break forth anew. They correspond, after all, to several experiences, not to a single one, and the concentration therefore does not easily become complete. There is often a relation of tension among the different elements, which can lead to dissolution, or at least to transformation into new forms, perhaps through the separating out of elements that could not be reconciled with the

others. A person can perhaps preserve his inner coherence only by forgetting, so far as possible, a single particular experience, pushing it back into the unconscious. Lear violently pushed away the memory of his daughters' ingratitude so that it should not drive him mad. O, that way madness lies; let me shun that; no more of that! (King Lear III, 4, 21). It is not only real experiences that can cause cleavage or dissolution. Possibilities too play a great part, the more manifold the representations are, now enticing, now frightening, now both. "Only he," says Kierkegaard,[11] "who was formed by possibilities is formed according to his infinity." As long as life lasts, the possibilities that seriously present themselves to us also belong among our experiences, and they can be harder *[22]* to master than the firm and limited experiences we call the real ones. It is out of such possibilities that great poets create their dramas. But in all of us inner dramas can be played out, with knots and resolutions, with collisions and decisions, dramas perhaps not even suspected by those around us, but which can nevertheless leave their deep traces in the further development of our character.

The figures and fates the poets present to us also belong among our experiences. The very fact that I must admit that life holds something such as what is described, whether it be great or small, good or evil, can become of decisive significance for me. It is not necessary that I should myself have experienced something similar, provided it stands as something that can have its place in reality. It has been thought that the consciousness that we ourselves are not part of what we read or see, but sit in full safety as readers or spectators, is an essential element in aesthetic feeling. But at any rate not everyone has the calm consciousness of himself as reader or spectator alongside the apprehension of the poet's presentation. In my personal experience such a consciousness would make full absorption and enthrallment impossible. And since we learn to know ourselves not only through the way in which the real events of life affect us, but also through the way we are moved by the possibilities that our own fantasy or the poets' presentations lay before us, it is with full right that we speak here of experiences. It can nonetheless of course have its significance to hold fast the difference between experiences owed to possibilities and those owed to realities. The former undeniably contain more temptations to self-deception, to regarding oneself as a hero without being one, or to thinking too

[11] *Samlede Skrifter*. IV p. 422. — In *Begrebet Angst* (where the statement quoted is found) and in his posthumous papers Kierkegaard laid the greatest weight on the enticing power of frightening possibilities. They cause dizziness; they work by the mere consciousness that they exist.

little of oneself in fear, perhaps throwing oneself away altogether.

In accordance with this view I cannot distinguish as sharply as Alfr. Lehmann[12]
[23] between autopathic, sympathetic and aesthetic feelings, so that the last would be characterized by the calm consciousness of standing wholly outside what fantasy or art lets appear before us. There are undoubtedly states in which the differences between these three kinds of feeling have vanished, since our real or central self can consist precisely in, be made up of, the living fellow feeling with real or imagined personal beings, and only later returns to its isolated existence, so that this will nevertheless have undergone a change through the states of self-forgetfulness. Our real self can swing between self-forgetfulness and self-consciousness, and a swing in the direction of self-forgetfulness is often the most fruitful. Lehmann does in the end recognize transitions between the three kinds of feeling, but this recognition is not sufficient. The main question is whether he is right that the representation of myself as different from everything else and everyone else, that is, the representation of the self, has the significance and the omnipresence he ascribes to it. As already remarked above, there can be a real self without a representation of the self. It is another matter that in psychology, when it is asked on what we ground the right to speak of a self at all, we refer among other things to the real self in the sense in which we have taken this word above. —

The question whether it is a good thing that relations in the domain of the mental life become more unstable with advancing development shall not be discussed here. Great dangers and great goods often go together. The greater the fullness to be held together, the more energy is needed for concentration to become possible. It can become a question of to be or not to be that the possibility of concentration poses.

In this respect the two kinds of formation of wholes indicated in what precedes, to which I shall return in what follows, are not alike. In fusion the elements enter into a closer connection than in organization. In fusion a new quality arises, a new immediacy; the contributing elements have lost their independence and with it the ability to rebel. The dramatic character the inner life can take on by virtue of the mutual contrast of the elements presupposes that no fusion has taken place.

[24] It is in the investigation of total states that psychology has its highest and inescapable

[12] *Die Hauptgesetze des menschlichen Gefühlslebens.* Leipzig 1914. p. 312–316. — It is regrettable that this new, enlarged and altered edition of "Følelseslivets Hovedlove" is not available in Danish.

tasks. Psychologists like to busy themselves by preference with single states, and still more with the elements that can be separated out of them. The question then becomes whether total states, complex psychical phenomena, can without more ado be derived from the elementary viewpoints or laws that can be found by analysis or experiment. When this cannot be done, one often loses interest in total states and acts as if they did not exist, or leaves it to poets and preachers to occupy themselves with them. It seems clear, however, that here as everywhere we must proceed by two paths if we want to gain knowledge, namely not only try to push forward from the simple to the complex, but also, conversely, observe the complex phenomena in their peculiarity and in their historical connection, fix them by description, and possibly through analysis reach back to viewpoints won by the investigation of the more elementary phenomena of the mental life. Perhaps it will then turn out that the elementary is not so simple after all. It is a prejudice, which in many domains pokes its head out again and again, that "in the beginning" were the elements, and that they are, moreover, "the real thing." But in all the beginnings we can observe, it is states, not elements, that are before us, and states with a more or less definite stamp of wholeness. The processes through which total states come to be can best be studied at more advanced stages of development, where the conditions are better known and consciousness is more awake. And then it is not only total states that can be illuminated by analogy from single states, but also the reverse. Just as little as a total state can be conceived as a sum of single states, just as little can a single state be conceived as a sum of elements. The historical character of the mental life, its dependence on particular conditions of the time, appears by the nature of the case most in total states. The historical method must therefore, as already remarked, supplement the other psychological methods, and psychology must use what the history of culture and of literature can teach us.

It is an investigation of this kind that is the aim of this treatise. But since the total state to be investigated gets its chief peculiarity from the elements of feeling it contains, *[25]* we must first dwell a little on the life of feeling and see how what has been developed so far applies there.

5. By a *single feeling* I mean a mental single state in which the elements of feeling are predominant and decisive, and which is not only determined by a single experience but is also relatively simple in its nature. Such a single feeling is, for example, the agreeableness

of a color or a scent, the joy in a thought or a picture, the involuntary approval the sight of a brave action can call forth, the satisfaction of having oneself acted with skill. Joy and sorrow, hope and fear, anger and love can appear as single feelings.

Such single feelings can enter into connections from which *total feelings* can proceed. A total feeling presupposes experiences of different kinds that stand in mutual connection. An experience that is objectively single can, however, have such different effects through the different qualities it presents that subjectively it comes to stand as several different simultaneous experiences. Total feelings can be called forth in single states (see the examples given in § 1), but only when they have first developed as total states through a series of experiences. There is an analogy here to partial recognition, in which we know a composite object by a single part or quality, when we have earlier had sensations corresponding to the whole group of parts or qualities. (Cf. Psychology V B, 2).

Single feelings already have a different character in every individual, every people, every class and every time. But still greater differences appear in total feelings. —

I have already stressed the difference between single feeling and total feeling in my Psychology (VI B, C and E), though without using these designations. I find it first indicated in the literature in Plato at the place cited above, and, as will be discussed later, it asserts itself in a plain and characteristic way in the most eminent minds of the Renaissance. In recent times it was first described clearly by F. C. Sibbern (Psykologie
[26] 1856 p. 140. 380), who lays weight both on the sporadic appearance of feelings in states of transition and crises and on the possibility that there can arise what he calls a "mixed feeling," in which conflicting feelings have entered into so intimate a connection that they work together to form one single total feeling. This phenomenon I would rather call fusion, especially as "mixed feelings" in everyday speech is used roughly in the sense of discomfort. But there is another kind of total feeling, which has the character of organization in the sense in which we have used this word above. Different feelings can namely work together under the guidance of a single feeling that determines the value or the end in whose service they stand. This kind of total feeling was well described by Th. Ribot in his book "Essai sur les Passions" (1907), where the word "emotion" is used of single feeling, the word "passion" of total feeling. And Alexander Shand has depicted in a masterly way what I call organization, under the name of systematization, first in his paper "Character of the Emotions" (Mind 1896), later in his work "The Foundations of

Character" (1914).

We shall now consider more closely the two forms in which total feelings can appear.

6. Fusion is the most intimate connection different feelings can enter into, and there are many intermediate forms or stages before this degree is reached. The mind can surge back and forth as different emotions succeed one another. Socrates' disciples now laughed, now wept during the last conversation with their master. The situation was, after all, that his death was close at hand, but that they nevertheless still carried on their usual work of thought together with him. There was, says Plato (Phaedo p. 59 A), "a strange mood," a mixture of sorrow and joy. That tears and laughter alternated shows that within the mixture now the one, now the other element had the upper hand, and that it did not come to any unified, new feeling. There were plainly two different causes here, the thought of the master's departure and the philosophical conversation, each of which set its own feeling in motion. When the disciples later thought of their master, the different emotions may have been able to even out with each other, so that *[27]* the representation of the loss and the representation of the incomparable personality could work together to call forth a total feeling of wistful admiration; a fusion may have been able to be completed.

A fusion can often take place only in single, especially concentrated moments, while in other moments the single feelings alternate or clash with each other. Wistfulness, for example, is then not the ruling feeling; it gains mastery only under favorable conditions, while otherwise sorrow at the loss and joy at the worth of what is lost succeed each other. A person's character — the real self — does not come forth undivided in every single state at all. It is at the high points of our life that we are really ourselves, i.e., are ruled by the total feeling that has formed under the influence of our experiences. At other times partial, more or less peripheral selves rule. And the relation between the central and the peripheral can be very different in different natures. Often only a very close acquaintance can find the threads that connect the peripheral and partial with the central and total.

It is not always the case that a definite difference asserts itself for us from the outset between causes that affect us in different directions. Their effects on feeling can join from the very first, so that the total feeling arises immediately, without being prepared through oscillations between different, more or less opposed feelings. Thus a picture can at first sight awaken a total feeling whose elements can only be traced afterwards.

Examples of this are afforded by Velázquez's pictures of the dwarfs he met at the Spanish court. These little fellows stand out as comic through their unmistakable self-esteem in contrast to their smallness, but the comic is complicated by a melancholy expression in the eye, which introduces an element of sympathy into the beholder's mood, which can thereby become of the kind we shall be occupied with in what follows — humor, just as humor may perhaps have lain at the ground in the artist when he went to his work. Julius Lange remarks of Velázquez's portraits of dwarfs that, however strongly characterized the dwarf figures are, the master's noble sense of beauty nevertheless shows itself in
[28] his eye for the point where the misfortune of the body has done the soul wrong.[13] It cannot of course be decided with full certainty whether the two elements were joined into a total feeling in the artist's soul. As regards the beholder too there may perhaps be disagreement as to whether the total feeling arises immediately. It might be, after all, that the beholder first looked at the figure and then dwelt on the gaze. For my part it was so that I at once caught sight of the gaze as the center of the whole figure. Only afterwards did I spell my way through the different parts of the picture. I must add that I have not seen the originals.

The clearest and sharpest apprehension of contrasts we do of course get by observing them successively. All else being equal, successive difference works more strongly than simultaneous difference. (Psychology V A, 5). But William James[14] is hardly right when he goes a long step further and asserts that two terms or elements cannot be apprehended as different in simultaneous apprehension if we have not successively apprehended each of them by itself and thereby got the peculiar transitional feeling of difference (the transitional sensation of difference). No analysis of a phenomenon of consciousness, however complex, takes place, he maintains, unless some of its elements have undergone change. — To this I would first remark that there are several intermediate forms between immediate intuition and the analysis James speaks of. Even if a change takes place in one part of a perceived picture (for example by a single feature being looked at more closely or being lit more strongly from outside), the picture is not therefore dissolved. The effect is perhaps only that the picture is, as it were, sharpened in a single direction or acquires a new center of gravity. The intuition is articulated, jointed, but is not dissolved in its

[13] *Udvalgte Skrifter* II p. 142.
[14] *Principles of Psychology* I p. 495.

simultaneous embrace of the picture's content.[15] — Next, at any rate as regards the effect on feeling, it is not the apprehension of difference itself that is decisive, but precisely the circumstance that the different elements work together despite their difference. To *[29]* the complex influence there may very well correspond immediately a complex effect on feeling. And it may then be precisely wonder at this effect on feeling that makes us seek, by successive observation of the picture's single parts, that is, by analysis, to bring out the cooperating elements each by itself. The apprehension of difference proper then becomes secondary, but the effect on feeling is not for that reason secondary in relation to the effects on feeling of the single elements. — It must of course be admitted that it is hard to distinguish between simultaneity and very rapid succession. And the fact that we can gather our attention on a subject only for very short moments, that is, that attention vibrates, also points to successive apprehension setting in very quickly. —

As examples of fusion Sibbern names two groups of phenomena.

For both groups it holds that after a relation of tension between two feelings a total feeling arises, so that the two simpler feelings are no longer felt each by itself. In place of the feelings that clashed with each other or succeeded each other, a feeling of a new quality has appeared, which would nevertheless fall away if one of the joined contrasts fell away.

The one group of examples Sibbern describes as the feelings of subjective satisfaction. They are owed to the fulfillment of a need, the filling of a want, the relief of discomfort, the overcoming of resistance. The feeling in the suspenseful and the mysterious, in danger and in struggle, belongs here too.

Against the first-named examples of this group Alfr. Lehmann objects that since the need falls away on fulfillment, no fusion takes place here. Sibbern could have answered that every feeling has a tendency to persist after the original occasion has fallen away. It spreads by a kind of expansion over the following states and can thereby come to fuse with the elements of feeling of these states. (Psychology VI B, 2; E, 4). Having felt a need is not necessarily a purely past phenomenon. Linguists too teach, after all, that a perfectum absolutum besides the element of time also contains something else, namely *[30]*

[15] Cf. on articulating intuition as an intermediate form between intuition and judgment *Det psykologiske Grundlag for logiske Domme.* (Vid. Selsk. Skr. 6th series). p. 18–21. (More briefly in *Den menneskelige Tanke.* p. 46; 53–56).

the representation of the result, of "what survives, the permansive."[16] And Sibbern speaks expressly of the peculiar joy of *having escaped* from a danger or distress, or of *having* got through it. There is thus something one continues to have when a danger has been got through. So too he speaks (in the second part of Gabrielis' Letters) of "absorbed unblessedness" as different from unblessedness merely got through. —

The other group of Sibbern's examples contains feelings such as wistfulness, reverence, the feeling of the sublime. That they can have the character of fusion cannot be doubted. To this group also belong, as will appear later, many forms of humor.

7. The other form of connections of feeling appears when a series of experiences release feelings that do indeed stand in close mutual connection, but do not wholly lose their peculiarity each by itself; rather they form a whole whose inner order is determined by a single value, a guiding end as organizing force. Such an order can arise when a fundamental value asserts itself that for its full realization demands a series of means and paths, as well as a more or less conscious striving. In the clash of the fundamental value with the circumstances of reality a series of different feelings will then be released, which lie, so to speak, on the way to the real goal. There can be people whose whole life is determined by such a fundamental value and its relation to the reality within which it is to be carried through. For other people it is only certain domains of life, for example art or science or social life, where a fundamental value exists for them at all. For others again each period of life has its fundamental value, youth its own, later age its own; or it is perhaps only in a single period of life that one can speak of a fundamental value at all. Every serious relation to a cause, to a person, to an endeavor (art, science, care for others, social and political striving for freedom) will naturally give rise to an organization of the
[31] life of feeling, so that the single feelings get their definite place in the mental household according to their significance for the maintenance of that relation. The single feelings that the ordinary course of life brings — joy and sorrow, hope and fear, goodwill and anger — will be furthered or checked by the work in the service of the fundamental value, and this work itself will give occasion to the arising of a series of single feelings.

The connection into which the single feelings enter when an organization takes place around a ruling interest will bring about changes, nuances in the character of the single feelings. Partly the direction in which the whole striving goes will gain influence on the

[16] *Otto Jespersen: Tid og Tempus.* (Vid. Selsk. Oversigt 1914). p. 320 f.

kind and degree of the single feelings, partly their mutual interaction, when they meet in the course of the endeavors, will give them a peculiar character they would not get under other circumstances. Anger, for example, will have a different character when it has an egoistic source than when it is owed to the injury of an altruistic feeling, and again it appears differently when it is released together with or just after fear than when it is released together with or just after joy — such fear or joy as the work in the service of the fundamental value produces.

Alexander Shand, who in his above-mentioned work "Foundations of Character" has described in an excellent way the organization (or, as he calls it, systematization) of single feelings (emotions) into total feelings (sentiments), nevertheless seems to deny the influence that its entering into an organization must have on a single feeling's character. The disinterested character of a feeling depends, he says (p. 43–50), not on the feeling itself but on the cause that calls it forth, or on the system to which it belongs; anger and fear can be just as disinterested as pity and sympathy when the cause that calls them forth does not fall under the individual's own need of self-preservation and the systematization that the rule of that need brings about. This statement is not entirely clear, but it seems to mean that the feeling itself does not acquire a different character by serving different ends. The character of disinterested or selfish would then concern only the end, not the single feelings that the work for the end calls forth. But does not fear take on a different nuance when one is afraid for one's own person and when one is *[32]* afraid for the welfare of others or for a cause one is taken up with? Both kind and degree will surely be different. The very difference of the end will make different elements enter into the feeling of fear in the different cases; here too fusion or organization can take place, and a new timbre can thereby arise in the single feelings. There cannot be an altogether indifferent relation between the feeling itself and the connection in which it occurs. Manifold relations of contrast and of evening out will assert themselves here.

It is surely connected with Shand's view of this point that he does not properly recognize the first main form of total feeling discussed above. What he calls a feeling's "system" is the sum of the thoughts the feeling is tied to — the mood (feeling) and the tendencies that assert themselves with it — the organic processes tied to it — and the conduct or way of acting that follows from it. But these elements are not supposed to undergo any change by entering the "system"; the theory of full fusion into a qualitatively

new feeling would, according to Shand (p. 55), be unable to explain how a total feeling can appear in very different ways under different circumstances — the presence or absence of its objects, absorption in expectation or in memory. A fused feeling (compound emotion) would not appear in the same way; only "systematized" feelings (complex emotions, — emotions combining into a system) can have the plasticity that experience proves for certain feelings (p. 55; 172). Shand is right that practically there can be a great difference between the two kinds of total feeling; but that does not exclude that we have here two peculiar forms of total feeling, and that is what matters here. For the rest, each may have its advantages. Fusion makes a more concentrated mood and conduct possible, while the form of organization has room for greater variations in the single cases. The greater plasticity of organization can, however, very well be combined with the elements of the "system" mutually determining one another's nuance or timbre. Every element
[33] makes certain demands, but demands are also made on it. It stands in both a negative and a positive relation to the whole into which it enters. The anger that a father's care for his son's upbringing has called forth finds its limit in the end. In choleric fathers a struggle may perhaps be needed to keep the anger within this limit. In criminals there can sometimes stir (cf. § 2), while they carry out their act, a cruelty that is not conditioned by the proper end of their conduct. Likewise in soldiers in war. It is often fear that makes cruel, since it makes it impossible to stop once one has begun to lash out to make oneself safe. The elements that are organized can have a constant tendency to break out and stir unruled and unlimited by any goal except the one: to rage themselves out! But the timbre changes in the very moment they break out. The negation or limitation then falls away. —

Not all single feelings can enter as members into total feeling, in the one form or the other. If they could, human mental life would have a less chaotic and disharmonious character than it has. There are joy and sorrow, indignation and admiration, hope and fear, faith and doubt that do not enter as members into any firm mental connection.

At the ground of Ingemann's splendid poem "Der strømmer en Flod mod det evige Hav" ("A river streams toward the eternal sea") lies the optimistic thought that all the elements of the mental life can be harmonized. It is said of that river:

> Each sorrow it turns into wistful delight,
> each sigh into melting *song* — — —

> Even the stone that weighed like a mountain
> dissolves into golden grains.

Yes, this can happen. But it does not always happen. There are sighs that are not turned into song, and there are stones in which no gold is found. And since every total feeling has its dangers, in that the consequence can be closure, unreceptiveness to new experiences, it is perhaps good that not all mental chaos is harmonized.

Two great minds have spoken of how contrasts can maintain themselves in the mind and divide it without either fusion or organization taking place. They both use the same image to illuminate their experiences. Thus Carlyle says (Sartor Resartus II, 9): "In the *[34]* forecourt there is dancing to the guitar, but within there sounds now and then a soft lament." And Kierkegaard writes in his journals (Papirer IV p. 35): "I sit and listen to the tones within me, the music's glad beckoning and the organ's deep earnest."

The psychical process that in many leads involuntarily to harmonious connection is impossible in natures like these two men, and in them it is often only by a violent effort of will that a unity is brought about, the chaotic streams being forced into one bed, where one can nevertheless constantly notice the difference between the waters of the different springs.

8. The tendency to the arising of total feelings is connected (as already indicated in § 2) both with the innermost nature of the mental life and with the demands the struggle for existence makes. At all stages and in all forms of mental life a need and an ability assert themselves that aim at gathering together, at synthesis. There works here, as Kant expressed it, a hidden art in us, without which we would not have consciousness, but of which we only rarely become conscious. It is the task of general psychology to show this in detail; it was at any rate the task I set myself in my presentation of psychology published in the year 1882. The mental life consists in and under a constant work of gathering together and ordering a chaos. In the domain of the life of feeling too such work is done involuntarily, and the processes that lead to the formation of total feeling are interesting testimonies to it. There are perhaps, as we have seen, natures in whom different interests or tendencies of mood can lie side by side, almost independent, or so that they get the mastery by turns. But apart from the influence outer impressions can exert, a natural alternation will assert itself, a strong swing in the one direction giving rise to a need for a swing in the other direction, and herein it already appears that the

single elements are subject to the demands made by the maintenance of the whole mental household. But there will moreover for the most part be one interest, one value, which
[35] in the long run regulates the appearance of the other values and determines them more than it is determined by them. Which element it is that determines the timbre of the fusion or the fundamental value of the organization will not always be recognizable with certainty by the individual himself through self-observation, but it will appear from his conduct, the way in which he takes life and intervenes (or does not intervene) in life. It is, as I have stressed in my Psychology, often only in a deep-going deliberation, undertaken with full energy, in a definite situation that demands action, that it appears what our real self, our fundamental value, really is. But it may very well be that the real self that formerly ruled in us is changed in a decisive way in a deliberation that sets us before the realities of life, so that what we discover in such moments is precisely not what till then lay at our ground. When one immerses oneself in this consideration, one gets a small glimpse of what endless interaction goes on in the innermost of our being. Could a simple intuition help us once and for all to clarity here, it would be easier to live. But life would then in return lose its fullness and its tension.

When there thus lies in the very nature of the mental life, as experience shows it to us, a tendency, at once a need and an ability, toward collection and concentration, this agrees with the demands made by the circumstances of life. The measure of a living being's stage of development consists in good part in the degree to which it can appear as a whole over against its surroundings. The plant can do this in a higher degree than the stone, and the animal in a higher degree than the plant. Within the animal world the significance of the nervous system in the struggle for existence is connected with its making whole and closed action possible. The animals we call higher have a more concentrated nervous system than those we call lower. And to this physiological concentration there corresponds precisely the working of the mental life as synthesis. In a situation of action it can be a matter of gathering all experiences and memories, all mood and striving, and concentrating them in a single direction. When a total feeling has been formed, a mobilization of the forces of the mind in a definite direction has already taken place beforehand, and this can become of the greatest significance for the life of
[36] action — while on the other hand it can also lead to tragic conflicts if the mobilization has taken place in a direction other than the one in which action is to be taken. —

In connection with this consideration it is of great significance, as Alexander Shand shows, that every total feeling has a tendency to become the basis of an ethics. Concentration on a value brings with it the striving to procure everything required to hold fast and develop this value. And the judgments of good and evil will depend on whether this striving is furthered or checked. First and foremost it is a matter of the total feeling itself being preserved in its freedom and strength, for then the qualities ("virtues") that that striving demands will come to be involuntarily. If freshness and strength are lacking, ideals must be set up and duties laid down. Virtues, ideals and duties vary with the total feeling. Thus love or friendship as a total feeling demands faithfulness and honesty, parental love patience, self-control and wisdom, intellectual interest perseverance and impartiality, etc. Each total feeling has its conscience. The personal ethics thus developed stands in constant interaction with the ethics determined by social demands. (Foundations of Character p. 111–120; 172 f.).

This view of the ethical problem goes in the same direction as the one I long ago put forward in my Ethics published in 1887 (ch. III), and which I still hold. I have shown in particular that there is a group of ethical concepts that all ethical systems use, although they place them in different orders of rank according to the fundamental value they build on. Such concepts are the concepts goods, virtues, duties and rights (Ethics VIII, 1). Every ethical view, no matter what total feeling it presupposes, finds application for these concepts in a definite mutual order. These concepts can therefore be said to make up the content of a formal ethics, which must be capable of being presented connectedly on the basis of a comparative investigation of the different ethical systems. I have spoken of this more closely in "Den menneskelige Tanke" (p. 350–359).

Since one can in fact build on different fundamental values, there is here a limit to the rationality of ethics, a limit given by the ultimate presupposition of every ethical system. The social or sociological ethics that builds on the persistence of society as its *[37]* fundamental value, whose content is the formulation of social demands, and which often regards itself as the proper, right ethics, is only one of the many psychologically and historically possible ethical systems.

While I have come to this view through an epistemological investigation of the rational justification of ethics (cf. Ethics III, 2, 13), Shand has come to it by a purely psychological path, as he saw that such "systematizations" of the life of feeling as he

investigated had involuntarily to become the basis of the ethical judgments passed by the people in whom "systematization" had taken place in one direction or another.[17]

9. As already remarked earlier, total feelings may well have formed at all times. But they do not stand out equally strongly at all times, and circumstances are not always equally favorable to them. As long as life unfolds within a limited frame that stands as unchangeable, the life of feeling will have a relatively simple character. There will be a common stamp, determined by community within family, tribe and state. Whatever seeks beyond this frame, all endeavors for which it is too narrow, all contrasts that threaten to burst it, are checked and pushed back. The arising of significant total feelings presupposes not only a great fullness of experiences and views of great horizons, but also an independence in the individual that makes it possible for special, perhaps unique crystallizations to take place of the feelings called forth under the influence of manifold experiences.

If we keep to the cultural periods most important for us, the ancient and the modern, we cannot expect to find many characteristic examples of total feeling in the first. Antiquity was ruled by the fundamental presupposition of unchangeableness as the expression of the innermost nature of existence and also as the mark of the highest value. The
[38] changeable stood for Greek thought in the end as illusion, and a worthless illusion at that. Even in the richest presentation of human striving that antiquity has given us, the one in Plato's "Symposium," even there this striving, with all the unrest and all the enthusiasm it brings, stands as belonging to a lower sphere in comparison with unchangeable being, which is the highest object of thought.[18] Now feelings of pleasure and pain presuppose precisely change, and more or less strong and sudden change, and they reach their most intensive forms where great contrasts meet or follow one another. Pleasure and pain are not least tied to transitions and crises in which opposed endeavors fight for mastery in individuals and in the relations of individuals to one another. The fight is in the end over what is to be the fundamental value and thereby assign all other values their place. Man is drawn to opposite sides, and that there is a unity in his being shows itself in such a conflict only by the strife and the division being felt as pain. Pain and sorrow, remorse and doubt presuppose an inner unity; it is precisely the dividedness that is felt

[17] In a paper on *La Morale et la Science Henri Poincaré* (Dernières Pensées 1913) has expressed a view of the scientific standing of ethics similar to the one set forth above.

[18] See on this my paper on Plato's Symposium in *Mindre Arbejder*. Third series. p. 88–93.

as pain. Suffering is the last bond that holds the mental life together. "Nothing joyful," Sibbern makes his Gabrielis say, "nothing joyful did I have that could give my existence continuity; so pain and despair became what held my existence together and kept me from giving my soul up to being torn asunder." That is why in pain and sorrow one learns to know oneself so well. Could one of the opposed terms be cast away and forgotten, the suffering would fall away in the same moment. It is faithfulness to oneself and to the values one has learned to know that makes one hold out in the purgatory of suffering, or else a great hope brings it about that one does not, despite everything, end in giving oneself up.

The chorus in the Greek tragedy does follow the hero's suffering and sorrow, but it always returns to the wish for a life not placed in so hard a strife, and to the resolve not to forget the limitation of mortals. And this line of thought expressed the basic principle of the ancient view of life. Plato was well aware that life was both comedy and *[39]* tragedy, and that they belonged naturally together. But this thought did not become of decisive significance for him. Perhaps Socrates holds a special position here. This will be investigated more closely later.

With all the reservation that must be made in considerations of this kind, one may say that it belongs to modern times to be fully understanding toward the manifoldness and the wealth of contrast of life. The first psychological descriptions that bear witness to such an understanding appeared at about the same time in Giordano Bruno's wonderful work "De gl' heroici furori" and in Shakespeare's tragedies.

What Bruno calls heroic passion is conditioned by the composite character of the higher mental life. Only in the stupid, who cannot see beyond what is immediately before them and have no comprehensive experience, do not know the manifoldness of existence — only in them can feeling and need have a single and simple character. In those who have rich and many-sided experience, the life of feeling is composed of pleasure and pain, sweetness and bitterness, and this in such a way that these opposed elements mutually determine each other. Ignorance is the mother of enjoyment in the animal paradise, and he who increases his knowledge increases his pain. But the heroic soul feels pleasure in the very pain, because this is a sign that it yearns toward an infinite and exalted object, which must and can be the goal of ever renewed striving. The heroic soul would rather sink in the struggle, or at least feel its lack and imperfection over against the great goal,

than reach perfection by setting itself a lower goal.

Comparison with Plato's "Symposium" shows the difference between ancient and modern thought. Plato wants to lead beyond constant yearning, beyond the world of change in which alone there can be talk of striving. The emotions are to be replaced by intellectual clarity, and the mind is to come to rest in the unchangeable. But for Bruno the play of contrasts and the tension it brings are precisely the expression of true reality, because it is the richness of life and the infinity of the world that bring the constant changes and the great contrasts. Just as little as the outer universe had any limit for him,
[40] just as little could the world of ideas and values have a limit. The great fundamental thought for which he became a martyr penetrated his innermost soul and determined his view of life. — The total feeling Bruno has described sprang from the need for knowledge and from the experiences of life conditioned by everything that either furthers or checks the satisfaction of this need. It was the fortunes of advancing, independent thought that conditioned what he got out of life. His most intensive spiritual feeling of life he had where he saw the barriers the old picture of the world had set for spirit and thought give way to greater horizons. As will be shown later (see ch. IX), this kind of total feeling is the most frequent among great philosophers.

As regards Shakespeare, there will often be occasion later to bring him forward in connection with the total feeling this treatise is especially to be occupied with. Here it need only be pointed out that his characters, as well as the fates he depicts, are not built on quite single motives, but, where he reaches highest, are each like a whole orchestra in which many motives, contrasts, resolutions and harmonies sound together into a mighty totality. He has thereby become a treasure trove for psychology in a higher degree than any other poet.

10. The difference between single feeling and total feeling shows itself in a rather interesting way in the history of the word humor, and it is necessary to dwell a little on this in order to understand the special meaning of the word in which it is to be taken in the following inquiry.[19]

The meaning of the word is at first physical: moisture, wetness, fluid. Then it is used in the old physiology of the fluids in the body that determine the nature of the temperament.

[19]Besides my own studies I have here had much use of a paper (Addison's Humour, its matter and its form) by the young literary scholar *Mary Suddard*, who died early, in her *Studies and Essays* (1912).

The well-known four old temperaments each corresponded to the predominance of its fluid. From physiology the word passed over into psychology to denote a certain mental state, and the psychological usage then shows in its turn a series of transitions that *[41]* bear witness to changes in the life of feeling in modern times, or at least to a clearer apprehension of the phenomena of the life of feeling. It is of course not the name that matters. All too often psychologists still believe they can explain to us what a certain name for a feeling or another mental phenomenon (attention, will, egoism, religion, etc.) "really" means. The decisive thing is to get a feeling described and characterized. Then one can afterwards see about finding the name for it that is most suitable, naturally with every possible regard for traditional usage.

As regards the word humor, it can be seen plainly how the physiological usage determined the psychological.[20] Such expressions of character in which one thought one could trace in particular the effect of a single one of the body's "fluids" were called "humorous" in England. One thought here in particular of qualities like stubborn one-sidedness or capriciousness or eccentricity. This usage appears in two younger contemporaries of Shakespeare. Robert Burton (Anatomy of Melancholy. 1621. I, 3, 1, 2) describes people who are "humorous" thus: now they laugh from the bottom of their hearts, now they weep without outward cause, now they sigh and are sad and pensive, now they wrap themselves in unreasonable fancies. Ben Jonson gives in the prologue to his comedy "Every man out of his humour" the following explanation: "When a single quality rules in a person to such a degree that it makes all his thoughts and powers go one and the same way, such a person must be said to bear the stamp of humor (to be a humour)." The word "humourist" is used by Ben Jonson of one who is "humorous" (Act I, Sc. 3). Jonson puts forward his explanation of the word as a protest against the abuse by which every fool or fop called himself "humorous." He wanted to limit the meaning to the predominance of a marked, temperamental quality.

When Duke Frederick in "As you like it" is said to be "humorous," the quality thought *[42]* of must, from the context, be stubbornness. When Hamlet, at the news of the players' arrival, promises among other things that "the humorous man" shall be allowed to play out his part in peace, what is probably thought of is what we would call a character

[20]The transition from the physiological to the psychological meaning seems to have taken place in France at the beginning of the 16th century. According to *Kr. Nyrop (Grammaire Historique de la Langue Française.* IV. 1913. p. 228) the psychological meaning is cited by Henri Etienne as a novelty.

actor, particularly a performer of striking, extravagant characters. Dowden thinks (in his edition of Hamlet, the note to II, 2, 340) of characters like Jaques and Mercutio.

Whether by the word humorous one thought mainly of fickleness[21] or of one-sidedness, it means the rule of a single feeling. It has not yet acquired the meaning of a composite feeling arising through the clash of opposed elements, which is prepared in the course of the eighteenth century and definitely established in the nineteenth.[22]

It is Shakespeare's art that has in good part prepared the way for this new meaning and for the understanding of the peculiar mental phenomenon that lies at its ground. Outwardly this understanding appears in the brilliant way he worked the clownery of the older stage into the whole of a great tragic action. The opposed currents of life unite
[43] in Shakespeare's art into a mighty river. Jest and earnest, laughter and tears, loftiness and lowness — everything makes its contribution to the total mood the works leave behind, and which was probably present in the poet himself as the fruit of his experience of life. He could not have solved his artistic task if he had not in his life solved the corresponding practical tasks. The poet need not of course have experienced himself the contrasts he depicts. But he must have seen them as possibilities. In the characters and fates he observed, in the moods and impulses he experienced in himself, in the events that befell him, there must have been drawn for him intimations, lines of cleavage, possibilities, over against which it could become serious work to maintain the strength and harmony of the mind. What was reached through this work he then shaped into a world of figures and fates that stands for spectator or reader as one of the greatest pictures of life ever given.

Only from a deep understanding of human nature in its manifold forms and of human

[21] *Holberg* presupposes in "the Fickle Woman" a sudden shifting of moods, without the preceding one having any influence on the character of the following. This must presumably be understood to mean that Lucretia is put into a mood by the slightest occasion, and that the mood thus aroused comes to color the whole state. In an interesting way *Johanne Louise Heiberg (Et Liv genoplevet i Erindringen*[3] II p. 27–31) has maintained the necessity of a mimic motivation of the transition from one "mind" to another and has pointed to the small indications of such transitions that the text offers on closer examination. — By Burton's description Lucretia would have to be called "humorous": "sometimes profoundly laughing, and then again weeping without a cause" (Anatomy of Melancholy I, 3, 1, 2). — A patient suffering from successive double consciousness, observed by *Morton Prince*, who after her recovery herself described her illness *(B. C. A.: My Life as a Dissociated Personality.* Boston 1909), could suddenly and without outward occasion take on an entirely different character, which showed itself in expressions, bearing, speech, etc., and in such a way that the one state had no memory of the other.

[22] See more on this below §§ 47–50.

life in its changing fortunes can one dwell on the paltry, the low, the absurd in such a way that it is seen, despite everything, as an element in the whole, and only on such a basis can jest have free play, although the great earnest forms the ultimate basis.

In humor — in the special meaning in which we are concerned with it here — there is expressed at once a large view of life and an honest experience of life's pettinesses and misfortunes. The total feeling can here too appear either as the consequence of fusion or as the consequence of organization. In the one case the contrasts are bound, present only potentially; in the other they come forward more freely, but are joined by their common relation to a fundamental value.

Shakespeare's humor is, as Dowden has said, an expression of his faithfulness to reality. He has not lost his faith in the great because life offers so much lowness and so much suffering; nor, in his certainty of the worth of the great, has he lost his sense for the small and the painful.

The great Spanish poet whose "Don Quixote" came out at the same time as Shakespeare's "Hamlet" is regarded by some as the master of all humorous poetry, because his jest is always earnest, and his earnest always comes forward in the form of jest.[23] In his *[44]* presentation of the knight-errant and his fight with windmills, with a Sancho Panza as squire and chorus, Cervantes always has understanding and fellow feeling for the good heart and the sincere will, although it is only after the collapse of illusions that these qualities properly come forward in his hero.

The elements indicated here in what I shall call *the great humor* are to be illuminated more closely in the following sections, in their different nuances and their different mutual relations. The earnest that lies behind the jest can be owed to sympathy and understanding, or to wistfulness and longing, or to magnanimity and superiority. We shall come to dwell somewhat more closely on these types. —

There is also a *little humor*, the most popular form, which is one with more or less good-natured jest. Good nature can have many degrees, through which humor can pass over into irony, satire or scorn. It is often this little humor that is thought of when the word humor or humorist is named. It is a single feeling, not a total feeling. It is a single experience that is taken up for treatment in a light, jesting form, as a rule with an undercurrent of understanding and sympathy, and in such a way that the jester may

[23] Thus *C. H. Weisse: Kleine Schriften zur Aesthetik* 1867.

very well draw his own person and his own conduct in among his subjects. — Usage also permits speaking of humor as the ability to call forth laughter, quite apart from the disposition that lies behind it. That is the tiny little humor.

The little humor can become a mere form that can be used from the most different motives. It does not have the deep foundation of the great humor, which is a view of life, or rather a disposition toward life, a total state to which all experiences and endeavors have made their contribution. The little humor can be used by scorn and ill will as a mere form; the earnest hidden in the jest is then feigned. The ironist too, as will appear later, can use the little humor. Often there can lie behind it a need to play, and through play to free oneself from what weighs on the mind. In the single case it can be hard to
[45] decide whether it is the little or the great humor one has before one, and in the first case, in whose service it stands. In what follows the little humor will come up only by way of exception, since it is essentially humor as a view of life or type of life, a stage of life, that is the subject of this treatise.[24]

11. At the outset the misunderstanding must be averted that the intention is to prove the sole justification of a particular view of life. That would be an impossible thing. To that extent what is often said, in season and out of season (especially out of season), is right: that there is no disputing about views of life. By a view of life is meant not a theory or a conception that one merely *has*, but a standpoint on which one stands, or a life one actually *lives*. It is not a sight one sees, but an eye that sees. One need not be conscious of one's view of life. For philosophy, especially for psychology, views of life can only be objects of description and investigation. Philosophy's relation to views of life is not exhausted by the remark that they are different or conflicting. It has the task of positively analyzing them, testing their consistency and finding their origin and their course of development. There is here for philosophy not only a psychological, but also an epistemological and an ethical investigation to carry through. It is important that philosophy should not push this task away from itself. Not only does it thereby narrow

[24]To test which meaning of the word humor would nowadays lie nearest to men versed in literature, I asked three colleagues, each of whom from his side was occupied with literary research, to tell me quite on the spur of the moment what representation the word most nearly awakened in them. The first answer went mainly in the direction of the little humor; the second took humor as a sense of the comic on the basis of sympathy and understanding; the third characterized humor as a view of life conditioned by life in time being seen with eternity as its background. All three forms, and more besides, I shall come to discuss in what follows. The first answer gave the popular meaning of the word, the second the later English usage, the third took humor in the sense of Romanticism and of Kierkegaard.

its domain, but when views of life are not taken up for objective treatment, they easily creep forward by detours and back ways and exert an influence that can be all the greater the more unconsciously it goes on. Philosophy always has the Socratic "Know thyself!" as its motto. And to know oneself means to be conscious of one's presuppositions, of *[46]* one's standpoint, to as high a degree as is at all possible.

The task of the present treatise is to investigate the psychological possibility of a stage of life founded on the great humor. When psychology occupies itself with the more concrete and complicated states of the mental life, it must be clear that it is dealing with types, individual forms, peculiar mental formations of wholes. The general viewpoints or hypotheses at its command can be used, in their interplay, to throw light on such formations; but it will be impossible to prove the necessity of these formations arising and persisting at all. One can only investigate the conditions of a mental whole when it is actually there. Such an investigation can furnish useful and often highly necessary correctives to the inclination to apply schemes set up once and for all to the domain of real mental life. —

It is perhaps not superfluous either to remark that the present treatise is psychological, not aesthetic. The concept of humor does of course play a part in the history of aesthetics, and good examples can be taken from poetic literature to illuminate it. But such examples are to be used in this treatise only where there is likelihood that it is experience of life that lies at the ground of the literary presentation. Already Henry Home, who in his "Elements of Criticism" (1762) ch. XII proceeds from the older meaning of humor discussed above, distinguishes between writers who use the humorous form and those who are "humorists in character," and whose works therefore involuntarily take on the stamp of humor. "Swift and Fontaine were," he says, "humorists in character, and their writings are full of humor. Addison was not a humorist in character, and yet there reigns in his prose writings so fine a humor."[25] A recent French literary scholar has remarked that while in "classical" works one can avoid thinking of the author, the "humorous" works necessarily betray the author's temperament and character. (Baldensperger: Leçon d'ouverture). *[47]* This can hold only where humor is something other and more than a form. Literature springs from life, and if the stage of life called the great humor has any significance, it

[25] Mary Suddard too comes to this view of Addison in her above-mentioned paper. Humor was for him essentially a form of presentation, in part a means of safety. — Whether Swift is rightly to be called a humorist, in the narrower sense, will be discussed later.

is not because it has found expression in literature, but the reverse: it gives literature heightened worth that a significant stage of life has been able to find expression through it. And it is possible to come to know this stage of life by other paths than occupation with literature. —

In what follows we shall come to give contributions to the history of the great humor. Conceptually it was first characterized by German aestheticians at the beginning of the nineteenth century, and here Solger is to be named first (in his dialogue "Erwin," 1815, and his posthumous writings). For Solger there appears in humor at once the feeling of the glory of existence and of its imperfection, by which an inner connection between the tragic and the comic is conditioned, so that nothing stands as valuable without its being able to become comic through its limitation, nothing as comic without being recognized in its worth! (Erwin. New ed. 1911. p. 350–354).

Before Solger, Jean Paul is to be named (Vorschule der Aesthetik. 1804), later especially Zeising (Aesthetische Forschungen. 1855), Lazarus (Leben der Seele. 1855), George Eliot (Essays 1883) and Th. Lipps: Komik und Humor (1898).

In Danish literature the concept of humor has been finely developed on its aesthetic side by Sibbern and Wilkens in their works on aesthetics. But in this inquiry I shall keep especially to Kierkegaard's treatment of the subject, in my eyes a contribution of the highest rank. Of his relation to Solger there will be talk later. Kierkegaard describes humor (in the sense of the great humor) as one of his "stages" (Uvidenskabelig Efterskrift. 1846. — Samlede Skrifter VII). It has been my wish to carry further what Kierkegaard indicated in a few strokes, but also to show the unjustifiedness of the barriers he, from his presuppositions, sets to the significance of this stage, as regards extent, as regards content and as regards energy.

II. Laughter and Humor

12. In connection with the older meaning of the word humor, Henry Home already pointed out that a character is called "humorous" only when it worked comically. In the later meaning of the word too it has something to do with laughter, or at any rate with the smile. Let us begin the inquiry into humor by considering its relation to laughter. *[48]*

Laughter can be investigated from two sides. One can ask about the nature of the outer experiences that awaken laughter, and one can ask about the inner mood that finds expression in laughter. As a rule most weight has been laid on the first question, and it is especially this that theories of the ludicrous seek to answer. But for our inquiry the second question is of the greatest significance. By way of introduction, however, we must touch on the first, especially as the two questions cannot in the end be kept apart.

Two theories have appeared here in recent times that might seem to stand in sharp contrast to each other. — The one lays weight on this: that when something is ludicrous, it is because it first appears with a certain trustworthiness, self-evidence, importance, superiority, but then suddenly reveals itself in its nothingness and its impotence. There is thereby called forth in the one before whom it appears first a feeling of security or admiration or enthrallment and tension, and then suddenly a disappointment or a gloating, or at least a relief and a release of the tension. What at first stood so self-assured and imposing now all at once takes on the opposite character. The ludicrous, on this view, rests on an effect of contrast in a downward direction. In short, vigorous strokes this theory was already put forward by Thomas Hobbes. In my Psychology (VI E, 9) I *[49]* joined it, only with a special stress on the different character laughter takes on according to the fundamental mood of the one who laughs. James Sully (Essay on Laughter. 1902) calls this theory the degradation theory. — The other theory lays weight on the ludicrous always presenting an absurdity, a discrepancy, a self-contradiction. In Danish literature

it was put forward by Kierkegaard. Sully calls it the incongruity theory.

Both Sully and Ribot (Psychologie des Sentiments p. 344) think that the two theories each fit their own group of cases, and that it is impossible to find a formula that can fit both groups. Undoubtedly each of the two theories stresses important viewpoints. And they both lead to an understanding of the significance of laughter in life, for example to an understanding of how laughter could be conceived as a criterion of truth (test of truth), as Shaftesbury and Henry Home have done. Through the purgatory of laughter everything artificial and hung on from outside is separated from a subject; it comes to appear in its whole nakedness, whereby either its worthlessness or the worth it perhaps has despite everything can appear all the more strongly. Holberg conceived his activity as a comic poet as an endeavor to separate the shadow from the body.

In reality, however, the two theories are not opposed to each other. The incongruity theory is evidently a particular form of the degradation theory. Contradiction is, after all, a special form of contrast. To be revealed in one's inner discrepancy and self-contradiction is, after all, a "degradation." Purely logically the self-contradictory = 0. But psychologically the discovery of self-contradiction works as a contrast in a downward direction. What appeared as something reasonable and reliable now shows itself in its nothingness. This produces the shock that is the condition for the release of laughter. Among all cases of the ludicrous there is on this point an analogy grounded in a common condition. The kind and degree of the tension can be very different. A puffed-up person who is suddenly exposed as empty and thoughtless, like a blown-up bladder that is pricked, naturally stands before us in a different way from a profound thinker who, absorbed in
[50] his subject, commits an error of calculation or of thought on a subordinate point, even if this subordinate point was a necessary link in the train of thought. One can of course formulate such contrasts as contradictions: fullness–emptiness; profundity–stupidity. But the contradiction is here at the same time contrast, and only thereby does the phenomenon become ludicrous. When Sancho Panza eagerly clings to the edge of a ditch, which in the dark he takes for the brink of an abyss, this can of course well be formulated as a contradiction, an "incongruity." Sancho's great terror undeniably does not fit the situation. But it is not the absurdity in itself that works comically; it is its contrast to the minimum of reason we always presuppose. If we see a person in mortal terror, we trust provisionally that there is reason for it. We take everything provisionally at face

value; and when the terror is suddenly removed, there is a possibility of laughter. Before the resolution there was also a possibility of tears; the tragic and the comic can lie close to each other. Laughter presupposes that those who laugh are still safe and secure on the side of reason and power, even after the "degradation" has set in. There must be something that is not dissolved by the downward contrast — at any rate the standpoint on which the one who laughs finds himself. With the tragic the relations are more involved, as we shall see later.

The feeling of the ludicrous is a marked example of a feeling of relation, i.e., a feeling that is not only, like all feeling, conditioned by its relation to other feelings, but is determined in its innermost being by the experience that calls it forth consisting in a contrast. In the feeling of laughter this contrast is downward; in the feeling of the sublime it is upward. In laughter we feel ourselves great over against the small; before the sublime we feel ourselves small over against the great.

The contrast that plays a part here need not be a contrast between two definitely formed states of consciousness. A contrast can be contained in one and the same experience, which suddenly asserts itself for us without any succession being observable. An example of this from another domain has already been discussed above, namely the mood Velázquez's pictures of dwarfs call forth. When — to take an often-used example — the sight of a little child in a man's hat works comically, the contrast is not between *[51]* child's head and man's hat, but between the child with its usual head covering and the child with the man's hat, and the representation of the usual head covering need not come forward expressly at all; it can work as a tacit, habitual presupposition. Effects of contrast can very well arise in relation to something that is not itself above the threshold of consciousness. There are quiet, secure expectations so ingrown that they can form the condition for an effect of contrast, a condition we perhaps first notice when we wonder at the phenomenon of contrast and seek to explain it to ourselves. It is here as when we wonder that something stands before us as familiar, and then investigate where and when we have seen or heard it.

13. Laughter is like the breath that blows away a speck of fluff. The relation between breath and fluff can be very different. A whole scale can be set up here.

a. In childish laughter, "the frolicsome high spirits and delight in nothing," there need be no fluff at all, no outer occasion. Overflowing vitality and feeling of life lead

to a playful and jesting attitude toward everything. Laughter is here the involuntary utterance of the healthy and vigorous mind. There is neither any consciousness of inner security and superiority over circumstances nor of an outer occasion. This element of involuntariness never wholly vanishes from laughter as long as laughter is possible at all.[26] All laughter presupposes firm ground under one's feet, however limited or illusory this ground may perhaps prove to be on a purely objective view.

b. Closest akin to this spontaneous laughter is the one owed to the lightening of a
[52] pressure or the release from a danger that has threatened the outer or the inner life. Here there is express consciousness of the fluff, of the ground of the laughter.

At a steamer's departure a lady stands on the quay with a little boy to take leave of people going away. She holds the boy out over the bulwark and raises and lowers him as a greeting to those departing, calling out: "Gustav says goodbye, goodbye, goodbye!" She drops him in the water. General consternation and despair. But a sailor jumps in and gets hold of the boy, and while he is still down in the water, he lifts the boy up and calls: "Gustav says how-do-you-do, how-do-you-do, how-do-you-do!" A liberating and jubilant wave of laughter replaced the tension and the fear. There lay at its ground as well a certain gloating over the foolish mother's conduct and a sympathetic joy that a human life had been saved. Thereby this example also belongs under the two following types.

c. A still greater part than in the laughter of release is played by the object of laughter where laughter is the expression of scorn. The object here means a resistance that seemed or thought itself to be overwhelming, but which is overcome and falls to the ground. While in spontaneous laughter the object has no significance, and while in the laughter of release it is something one moves away from and perhaps soon forgets, in scorn the object plays a positive part. There is a need to hold fast the representation, or perhaps even the sight, of the object in order fully to enjoy one's own feeling of power. Here a reaction asserts itself not only against one's own preceding tension but also against the object itself. Contempt finds vent against it again and again. The fluff has here become a

[26] *Sully* (*Essay on Laughter* p. 289–293; 427–432) is anxious for the future of healthy, spontaneous laughter on account of pessimism, fatigue and cynicism. The reservoir which in the past supplied the stream of national gaiety, has certainly fallen and threatens even to dry up. The merriment of Old England developed after the common struggle against Rome and against Spain. But now class oppositions come to the fore. — Perhaps the struggles of a new time could have a regenerating effect by releasing and gathering the forces.

mountain one has overthrown.

d. In humor, the fourth type of the feeling of laughter, the object plays, as in scorn, an essential part, only the relation to it is not antipathetic but more or less sympathetic. Here again different forms can be distinguished, different kinds of humor, whose difference rests on the significance the object has.

α. Where the superiority over an opponent is great and deeply grounded, the work of overcoming the resistance will stand as play, and there will be no need to dwell on it again and again. Real superiority rests in itself, and its self-esteem does not take on *[53]* the character of contempt toward other things and other people. The need to feel scorn or contempt and to give them expression is precisely a sign that one is dependent on the outer object and can feel oneself rightly only in contrast to it. Even if no positive sympathy is felt for it, it can very well be recognized in its peculiar worth, and the smile or the laughter can then be conditioned by understanding. A bridge can be built between the one who laughs and the object of laughter.

β. Since real superiority commands more energy than is needed to overcome the resistance and secure its own persistence, there is here the possibility of a magnanimity that not only understands the object but seeks to shield and protect it, all the while its paltriness and impotence assert themselves. Magnanimity bears with a smile not only its own burden but the burdens of others, adding its strength to the slight strength that called forth the smile. The recognition of the worth of the paltry and impotent is here more positive than where bare superiority rules. There is here an inner bond, not merely an outer bridge, between subject and object.

γ. It is not only superiority that can rest in itself. Where the mind is taken up with something valuable that is an object of memory or hope, the inner life can be so rich that outer objects and circumstances stand as paltry and insignificant over against it, without therefore being misjudged in their peculiar worth. Humor can have wistfulness or longing as its basis. Wistfulness is directed toward the past, longing toward the future. Against both, new events strive in vain to gain power; but they are not therefore scorned or regarded with indifference. By virtue of the expansion of feeling (cf. § 6) the individual's own mood can come to take the interests and strivings of others under its influence, especially when these others are themselves referred to the worlds of memory or of hope. Wistfulness and longing do not repel, but can lead to a deep understanding of everything

that misses and longs.

δ. Humor takes on a peculiar character when an understanding of the great laws of life and existence forms the background. This understanding need not be strictly scientific.
[54] A person who uses his reflection and has comprehensive experience will naturally reach the conviction that there is a great order of things on which all events, even those that cut most deeply into human weal and woe, are dependent. And this conviction will furnish a background, a horizon, in relation to which what occupies people's interest can stand as paltry and vanishing. Superiority is here conditioned by understanding. But precisely because the paltry and vanishing, just as well as the great, belongs within the lawful connection of existence, precisely for that reason it can be regarded in its peculiarity and with the sympathy of understanding.

ε. The relation between subject and object in the domain of laughter becomes most intimate when the subject harbors a positive sympathy for the object. Before the smile or the laughter there can be given a bond that does not break because the object is seen in its paltriness or its self-contradiction. Such a bond exists between parents and children, between brothers and sisters, between friends, and everywhere that love of mankind and a sense for human mental life rule. The superiority is here the superiority of love, and the love is the magnanimous love (Ethics IX, 1; XII, 2) that is akin to justice. The understanding is here the understanding of sympathy (while the preceding form of humor could be characterized as the sympathy of understanding). The stronger the bond, the more freely smile and laughter will be able to stir. The forces that could otherwise repel — wit and the comic sense — can here come to bear witness to the firmness of the bond and perhaps tie it more firmly. To this kind of humor Thackeray's and George Eliot's definition of humor as the unity of wit and sympathy (wit and love) applies.

All these forms of humor can appear as momentary states (emotions or ripples) or as more lasting states (moods) or as the expression of the real self (disposition). This last form is what in this treatise I call the great humor.

In my Psychology (VI E, 9) I took account only of the form of humor that can be designated as the unity of wit and love. James Sully (Essay on Laughter. p. 306) objected
[55] to my description of humor that living sympathy will prevent laughter. This cannot be denied. But whether it happens depends not only on the degree of sympathy but also on the degree and kind of the contrast that is present. There can, after all, be contrasts so

sharp and bitter that they cause wounds that cannot be healed. An overwhelming fate can rule, over against which all the power that can be summoned is impotence. To this possibility I return in a special inquiry that is of decisive significance for my whole view, namely the inquiry into the relation between humor and the tragic (ch. V).

For the time being it follows from the characterization given of the different types of laughter that what a person laughs at depends on what kind of person he is. A person's character reveals itself through his relation to the ludicrous. Good observers have seen this at all times. It will not be without interest to cite some statements on it.

Plato demanded that what one found ludicrous should be determined not by what the senses show us but by what thought sets highest (Republic V, p. 452 D).

Thomas Hobbes says (Leviathan cap. 6): "Much laughter is a sign of a small mind (pusillanimitas). It is proper to a great mind, on the other hand, to bring help and to free others from contempt, and to compare itself only with the greatest men."

"All my life," says Lichtenberg (Vermischte Schriften, I p. 173), "I have found that a person's character cannot be better known than by a jest he takes amiss."

Goethe says (in his "Maximen und Reflexionen"): "People make their character known by nothing more clearly than by what they find ludicrous. The sensual person often laughs where there is nothing to laugh at. Whatever then makes an impression on him, his inner pleasure shows itself. The man of understanding finds almost everything ludicrous, the man of reason almost nothing." — And in one of his epigrams he says (which confirms Lichtenberg's statement and is of significance for the psychology and ethics of humor): "He who cannot make fun of himself surely does not himself belong among the best."

Carlyle says (Sartor Resartus I, 4): "No man who has once heartily and wholly laughed can be altogether irreclaimably bad. How much lies in laughter: the cipher-key wherewith *[56]* we decipher the whole man!… The man who cannot laugh is not only fit for treasons, stratagems and spoils; but his whole life is already a treason and a stratagem."

14. In what precedes, humor has been described as a single member of the whole series of forms of laughter. And for the most part humor is treated under the psychology of laughter; so too in the presentation of psychology I have given. But it differs from the other forms of laughter by its basis, by having in a higher degree than they the character of a total feeling. More than the other forms it presupposes experience of life

and reflection, a purgatory in which the contrasts of life and the conflicting forces of existence have exerted their influence on the innermost core of the mental life. The great and the small, the exalted and the low, the bright and the dark, everything has left its trace, and reflection has bethought itself of the general laws of life.

Whether the basis is the superiority that excludes contempt, or the magnanimity that bears the burdens of others as a natural thing, or the wistfulness that is the fruit of rich but painful experiences, or the longing directed toward a great goal, or the understanding that sees everything ordered into a great connection, or the sympathy that feels the pulse of life in the least as in the greatest — there is a possibility of a smile or laughter at everything that in reality or in appearance comes forward as contrary to what occupies the mind. The contradictions, disharmonies, disappointments and sorrows of life fade before the basis and the background that determine the effect of the single experiences. A main thing for the form of laughter that has the character of humor is that the relation to life is positive, or that the one who laughs or smiles at any rate takes himself along here. Before the great measure that is applied, the sharp contrast between the great and the small vanishes in the end. In the great humor we ourselves, with our whole personality and our whole striving, belong to what finds its justification in the poet's words

> "the least of things defends
> its place in the wreath of life."

[57] An example of this side of the stage of humor can be taken from Kaalund's poem "Naturens Graad" ("Nature's Weeping"). Nature longed for her children, who had now shut themselves up in the great cities. They then streamed out to her into the open. But the great mother was indignant to see these dressed-up gentlemen and ladies, and her indignation found vent in a thundershower that drove them back to the city in wild flight and amid all kinds of calamities. But the poet confesses: "I myself was there, I rolled in a cab!"

There is in the great humor a double movement. It is the expression of a self-assertion that builds on self-understanding. The saying about mastery showing itself in limitation holds here in the fullest sense. For only he can assert himself who knows clearly where he stands — what he is capable of and what not — what he is worth upward and downward. The quality Aristotle called megalopsychia, and which consisted in being conscious of one's own real worth, expresses right self-assertion from the positive side.

The barriers then follow of themselves, being determined from within, not from without. They lie quite simply where the consciousness of one's own worth stops. When the Romantics in their day tried to set up Tieck as Goethe's equal, Goethe declared that it was as if he wanted to compare himself with Shakespeare. Goethe was clear about his limit upward and downward. His saying that he who cannot make fun of himself surely does not belong among the best can be used as a motto for the great humor. Making fun of oneself is not one with scorning oneself. The humorist scorns himself as little as he scorns others. He holds himself as well as them up against the great background life has set before him, and the relation to it determines both the place he assigns himself and the place he assigns them. Everywhere he seeks the kernel among the shells. And since the shells do not always betray the kernel, he will be inclined to think that it is our ignorance or our lack of sympathetic understanding (or of the sympathy of understanding) that makes us often think we find shells without kernels. Not all nuts, after all, can be cracked so that one can get to see what is inside them. As Goethe wrote in a young student's album: "Our Lord created the nuts, but he did not crack them." There may well be need for humor toward those who think they have cracked all the world's nuts, although in *[58]* reality they have cracked only their own teeth. The great humor will be bound up with constant seeking, and it stands in contrast to all dogmatic wisdom, whether this comes forward in the name of sound common sense, of science or of religion.

It was in the time of Romanticism that people came to see that in a disposition like the one described there lay the possibility of a type of life, that is, of something that was other and more than a special form of aesthetic feeling. The justification of this still needs to be maintained and grounded. Hermann Lotze, for instance, denied that humor could be recognized as a comprehensive mood of life. In his eyes it can only be a certain kind of comic mood, and a kind that has its danger at that, since it easily works dissolvingly toward everything exalted. (Geschichte der Aesthetik in Deutschland, p. 389). And although Kierkegaard describes the great humor with sympathy and understanding, for him it cannot designate a highest stage; that he reserves for the religious way of taking life.

There is therefore every reason for a closer investigation of this subject.

III. Irony and Humor

[59]

15. Whether one regards humor merely as a peculiar kind of feeling of laughter or as a type of life, there is no contrast to it so characteristic as scorn. But there are several intermediate forms between these two extremes, and we shall consider some of the most important here.

Scorn presupposes, as we have seen, a relation of contrast that is not present in purely involuntary laughter. Scorn is antipathetically taken up with its object; it brings with it a need to occupy itself with it again and again in order to bring out and paint its impotence, its insignificance, its stupidity or its baseness. It is a decidedly reactive feeling, although Nietzsche thought that it was precisely suited to high superiority. Well-grounded superiority leads, as stated above, to humor rather than to scorn; it rests in itself to such a degree, taken up with its rich self-unfolding, that no need can arise for side glances or downward glances, and where it stands in relation to other beings, it has at any rate no ground for antipathy. It is a sign of insecurity and of a lack of absorption in the unfolding of life when it is necessary again and again to dwell on the paltriness of others. It was the tragic thing in Nietzsche that his constant need to utter his antipathies did not give him the rest and strength to develop positively what nevertheless lay nearest his heart, the great power and self-affirmation of life. Again and again he breaks off the working out of his main work to let scorn and antipathy have the word. The work then was never finished either. But the contradiction appears most glaringly in him when the feeling of distance (das Pathos der Distanz) toward the great mass is to be an essential element in the disposition of great men. He did not see the sharp conflict that exists between the pessimism that "the pathos of distance" necessarily presupposes (since *[60]* "the great mass" is only to be able to be means, hindrances or copies!) and the absolute

optimism his gospel was to proclaim.[27]

In great satirists one can study this relation, and in no one better than in Swift. His absorption in and enthrallment by what he rejected and fought comes out so glaringly that the whole figure has often been darkened by it for posterity, just as Swift's own mind was darkened by it. He constantly seeks new expressions for the contempt he felt for the mass of men and their doings, as he thought he had come to know it in his participation (or attempt at participation) in political life. He revels in images and allegories that could express this feeling. He has his Gulliver travel to Lilliput so as to be able to ridicule the culture of Europeans in this people of Tom Thumbs. And when Gulliver then comes to the giant people of Brobdingnag, there is occasion, through the account Gulliver gives there of life in Europe, to depict Europeans as "the most pernicious race of little odious vermin that nature ever suffered to crawl upon the surface of the earth" (Gulliver's Travels. Part II. Chap. 6). The high point is reached, however, later, in the description of the people called the "Houyhnhnms," an ideal people, which of course does not have human shape but the shape of horses. In this land there lives, besides the main people, a hideous, bestial, base-minded race that has human shape and lives a human life. In these "Yahoos" disgust at the human has found its most violent expression.

The great satirist has found in these depictions of lowness and baseness an expression not only of his moral indignation but also of wounded self-esteem, of inner sufferings and of tragic circumstances of life. It is, to use Leslie Stephen's expression in his book on Swift (p. 184), a wounded soul that speaks to us, not merely a prophet chastising wretchedness.

Perhaps every prophet has a wounded soul. But on posterity he will nevertheless work most by his ability to make the great and the true prevail. It is, after all, only the
[61] prophetic figures of modern times whose inner life we know. In the old times there was no sense for individual psychology, and in any case it was only insofar as the prophet, in indignation and enthusiasm, unfolded the powers of a great mind that he made an impression on the nearest posterity, from which the picture we have of his figure stems. When he had then gone over into being one of the great exemplars of the race, the purely individual features easily fall away, especially those owed to the conflict between inner, conflicting drives and tendencies. Had they been wholly taken up with inner strife, they

[27] See my characterization of Nietzsche in *Moderne Filosofer*.

would hardly have been fit to be an example for others, but would have had enough to do with themselves. It is a great, often insoluble task to find the psychical connection between the mighty polemic and what went on in the prophet's soul.

16. The ironic form can belong among the means of satire. It then comes forward with apparent acknowledgment and earnest, although its real endeavor is to attack and annihilate. An indirect form of attack then takes the place of the direct. Irony is here only a means; it does not designate a particular type of life. It is what one could call *the little irony*, while *the great irony* is not merely a form and a means but a stage of life. The difference will consist among other things in this: while with irony as a form or figure of speech it must be aimed at that the others understand that it is irony, that the earnest is not earnestly meant, it is otherwise with the great irony. But before we investigate it, we must dwell somewhat on the history of the concept of irony.

In Greek usage and Greek thought this concept underwent remarkable changes, which have been shown in an interesting way by Ribbeck (Über den Begriff des εἴρων. Rheinisches Museum. N. F. XXXI p. 386).

The word appears first in Aristophanes' "Clouds" as a term of abuse, the ironist being placed here alongside the liar and the braggart. For the Greeks, who both presupposed and demanded that the inner should be expressed in the outer, irony, in which the inner stands in contrast to the outer as jest to earnest, had to be a bad thing. When Socrates was called an ironist, it was an expression of people's ill will and exasperation at the way he lured those he talked with onto slippery ground by apparently acknowledging them *[62]* and going along with their opinions. It is, as Ribbeck says, an irony of fate that precisely the most truth-loving of all Athenians should be classed with liars and braggarts. But precisely the personality of Socrates, as Plato depicted it, also brought about a change in the conception of the concept of irony. In Aristotle the ironist is set in contrast to the braggart, although, like him, he designates a defect in contrast to the truthful man (Eth. Nic. IV, 13). The ironist's behavior is explained by his reluctance to make a show. But it is not yet stressed here that the great difference between the ironist on the one side and the hypocrite and the braggart on the other consists in this: while the braggart makes the outer appearance his end, because he precisely wants to make himself greater than he is, and while the hypocrite uses the outer appearance as a means to attain selfish ends, for the ironist the appearance is a means to keep his inner life undisturbed, or perhaps

even, by going along with the presuppositions of others, to get them to gain in clarity. It is in this way that we now conceive Socrates' irony, guided by the indication Plato has given in the depiction of his master. In a single place Aristotle gives a hint in this direction, when he says of the man who has a great soul (ὁ μεγαλόψυχος), and who not only thinks himself worth something but really is worth it, that he behaves ironically toward the multitude. (Eth. Nic. IV, 9). He has, after all, something within him that he cannot communicate without more ado.

Later Greeks again stood as strangers to the contrast between the inner and the outer that showed itself in Socratic irony. The Epicureans conceived irony as an expression of arrogance and braggartry,[28] and Cicero's teacher, the Epicurean Zeno, even called Socrates an Attic buffoon (scurra Atticus).[29] —

Socratic irony is great irony, if Socrates' stage is exhausted by the concept of irony at all, which will be considered more closely later. In the great irony the polemical relation to the surroundings falls away. There can, as already indicated, be two tasks solved by
[63] this irony. Irony can be the refuge of a mind that wants to withdraw from its relation to the outer, to other people, to the given forms of life, guided by the need to assert itself and work at the unfolding of its inner life, a need that must naturally become the stronger the richer the content that is working its way forward in the personality. A great inner fullness can make isolation necessary, and by going along outwardly with and acknowledging the given forms of life, people's opinions and customs and the ruling authorities, one saves all one's strength for inner work and inner growth. But irony can serve not only self-assertion. It can also, and at the same time, be a method, a pedagogical means to make possible the understanding of other personalities, an understanding that is in turn the condition for help, education and collaboration. Through apparently going along with the presuppositions and assumptions of others, through acknowledging the place and the standpoint on which they stand, one more easily gets them to open up, to unfold the consequences of their thoughts, and with that the cooperation in which all real help and all true education consists has already been made possible. While satire pushes its object away, or holds it fast only to push it away again and again, irony can be a way by which it becomes possible to penetrate into the object and set up a community

[28] *Theophrasti Characteres et Philodemi de vitiis liber decimus.* ed. Ussing. p. 4. 57. 175.
[29] Cicero: *De natura deorum.* I, 34.

with it. Even where irony serves self-assertion, it is not a repelling but a withdrawal, a way of keeping the sanctuary of the mind free from the intrusion of the surrounding world.

When the ironist arouses anger by his conduct, it may be because people do not like anyone wanting to educate them, to lead them beyond that in which they securely rested. As soon as they discover that this was the end of the apparent acknowledgment of their standpoint, their self-esteem is wounded. But the reason may also be that people do not like to see anyone withdraw from community with them. It causes insecurity, merely that there is someone who will not join in. One wants a common confession. Not only in the domain of religion is there dogmatism. If I am right, how can another then have a right to go other ways than I? And especially when I do not even know what other ways he goes, I perhaps begin to feel uneasy.

In both its forms, both as self-assertion and as education, the kind of irony described *[64]* here, after hints in the historical Socrates[30] but in a further working out, marks a great turning point in the life of the spirit. It is the first form in which the principle of personality, the understanding of and respect for individual human personality,[31] one's own and that of others, breaks through. And Socrates stands here as the pioneer. In his irony, so far as one can see, both the forms named asserted themselves.

Kierkegaard in his brilliant youthful work (Om Begrebet Ironi, med særligt Hensyn til Sokrates. 1841) constructed an absolute irony, by which he meant an irony of a purely negative kind. It was the little irony he made absolute, instead of making it great. He regarded irony merely as dissolving, as devoid of every positive content. He denies it both inner fullness and the sympathetic element. The jest hidden in ironic earnest is supposed to be directed at everything between heaven and earth. Everything is dissolved into nothing — with the exception of the selfish. The ironist takes everything as vanity — except himself. (Skrifter XIII p. 332). Socrates dissolves Greek spiritual life (ib. p. 338) without putting anything whatever in its place. But — Kierkegaard thinks — this was justified in Socrates, for the time of Greek culture was essentially over. In modern times, on the other hand, such an irony (as it appears, for example, in Fr. Schlegel) is, he thinks, altogether unjustified: for now "subjectivity" (the principle of personality) has triumphed.

[30] See more below § 44.

[31] On this principle in its more special elaboration see my Helsingfors lectures, published under the title *Personlighetsprincipen i Filosofin.* Stockholm 1911.

It has carried through its demands in state and church, in social and religious life, and it constantly reveals itself through these forms.

Kierkegaard proceeds in the youthful work mentioned from the speculative theology of his time, developed under Hegel's influence, which was represented among us by Heiberg and Martensen, to whom he also refers. He was thereby led, at this stage of his development, to misjudge the positive character of Socratic irony. Even later (1846) he
[65] calls the ironist (Papirer VII, 1. p. 27) a buffoon. It recalls the Epicureans' scurra Atticus. For the rest, he corrected his view in later writings, as will be shown later.

Not only Socrates but also Fr. Schlegel Kierkegaard did wrong in his youthful work. The circumstances are supposed, according to Kierkegaard (and Hegel), to have been entirely different when Schlegel appeared than in Socrates' time. "Subjectivity" had now, after all, triumphed in state and church! — To this it must be said that when Schlegel appeared it was hardly unnecessary to maintain the right that the free life of the spirit has over against the traditions crystallized in institutions and dogmas. There is something here, after all, that cannot be settled once and for all. There is an eternal strife between freedom and norm. Externality, triviality and spiritlessness are precisely often at home in the forms for which the earlier fresh upsurge of the life of the spirit laid the foundation. One rests content with celebrating the great, spirit-filled beginnings and thinks oneself, despite all stagnation, akin to them. There seems, especially in Germany at the beginning of the nineteenth century, when Schlegel appeared, to have been much of this kind to combat. Thus Lotze remarks in his "Geschichte der Aesthetik in Deutschland" (p. 371): "the mood then prevailing in the German people could, in aesthetic respect, rather be called empty than rich. In sluggish tradition and narrow-hearted custom, receptivity for the beautiful had been lost to such a degree that it could stand as the task first and foremost to restore the unprejudiced life of impulse by rising against countless barriers and testing and disputing countless prejudices." One of the best men of the time, the great idealist Fichte, even declared in a letter that the time was characterized by "absolute putrefaction of all ideas." The time when Fichte and Schlegel appeared hardly had any advantage over the time when Socrates appeared. On the contrary, Socrates' appearance was bound up with one of the highest cultural periods of world history.

And despite all the objections that can be made to Fr. Schlegel as a person and as a writer, there was in him a real need for freedom and honesty as the first condition of a

worthy life. It was this that won him friendships with men like Fichte and Schleiermacher. And instead of merely relying, with Kierkegaard, on an analysis of Schlegel's novel "Lucinde," one ought to hear how Schlegel himself gave an account of his concept of irony *[66]* in his essays in the periodical "Athenäum."[32]

It is, according to Schlegel, the impossibility of complete self-communication that asserts itself in irony. The most precious thing man possesses, inner satisfaction itself, has in the end its root in something obscure, which is nevertheless what bears the whole, and which would lose its force the moment one tried to dissolve it into pure understanding. In irony there appears the consciousness of an eternal mobility (Agilität), an infinite chaos that can never be wholly systematized. Only apparently can the personality be exhausted in a single relation or in a single work. There is in every personality, as in each of Leibniz's monads, a universe, an infinite fullness that makes it both possible and necessary to transport oneself, not only with understanding and fantasy but with one's whole soul, into the most different domains, although none of them can wholly suffice.

These statements show that Schlegel himself conceived his standpoint as positive, and that he was right in this. But it also appears probable that such a standpoint could not be definitive. It was still too chaotic. There was a fullness that pressed forward, but it stood as arbitrary which part of this fullness one took up in particular, and the arbitrary play, the capricious shifting, evidently had a great attraction in itself. And Fr. Schlegel was unable to give shape to what pressed forward. He lacked the energy of Socrates and the Socratics to work in the free field of personality, where all good plants grow. His sense for the great and the infinite was paired with a lack of ability for steady and faithful work and for becoming, through it, master of the chaotic content. Therefore he ended in dilettantism.[33]

There came in him a reaction against the capricious shifting, and a need stirred for definite forms of the life of the spirit. He was thereby led to Catholicism. Already in the "Athenäum" he longed for the Orient. "Zunächst rede ich nur mit denen, die schon nach *[67]* dem Orient sehen" (III, 1). It was from the first "the eternal Orient" he sought; but then he thought he found it in the mighty crystallization of the old Church.

[32] I have already remarked this in *Den nyere Filosofis Historie,* II note 38. — The statements of Schlegel cited in what follows are found in *Athenäum* (1800). I,2 and III, 1.

[33] Cf. *Dilthey's* fine characterization of Fr. Schlegel in his *Leben Schleiermachers.* Second book. Ch. 4. 12. 14.

17. Shakespeare too some have wanted to make an ironist. A. W. Schlegel (Fr. Schlegel's brother) constructed a Shakespearean irony, which was supposed to show itself partly in the characterization of the single persons in his dramas, namely in the way great and small motives clash in them, partly in the action of the drama as a whole, through the impartiality with which the course of fate is depicted. Characters are depicted in their whole nakedness, not in the garb of enthusiastic admiration, and fate is exposed in its whole reality without the poet's heart being moved by it.[34]

Against this one of the finest recent Shakespeare scholars[35] rightly objects that Shakespeare's impartiality toward persons and fates does not mean indifference and remoteness, but springs precisely from his interest in his subjects, from the firm will to let each of their sides come into its own; his enthusiasm is not weakened by the barriers to which human actions and fates are subject.

There is an artistic irony that is closely connected with the great task of art, that of giving concrete and individual pictures of characters and fates, not abstractions and utopias. Everything in art must be subject to the law that springs from this task. Life is so rich, and works its way forward both within the single personality and within the race from so many sides, that a limitation, a polishing, must take place if everything is to come into its own. Both as regards the individual characters and as regards the events in which they are placed, a negative element necessarily asserts itself, in that the single trait or the single event is subordinated to the whole connection and is not allowed to unfold
[68] in the way it could if it had been the only one. In addition, the artist's task is to give the feelings and images that rule him such an expression and such a form that his work can acquire worth and win recognition also beyond the circle that most nearly surrounds him and perhaps fully shares his feelings and is familiar with his images. Therefore what moves within the poet must be shaped into clear and definite forms, have the marked character of objectivity.[36]

But it would not be right to lay the main weight on the negative, limited element in artistic shaping. The essential thing is, on the one side, the glowing mass that is to be formed, and, on the other, the plastic figures that come forth through the shaping. The struggle, the often bitter struggle, and the work, the often hard work, lie between these

[34] *Vorlesungen über dramatische Kunst und Literatur*[4]. II. p. 197–199.
[35] *Dowden: Shakespeare. His Mind and Art.*[5] (1880). p. 345.
[36] Interesting remarks on this point in *Yrjo Hirn: Konstens Ursprung.* Stockholm 1902 p. 95–102.

two positive elements and are probably most often known only to the single artist himself. The artistic ability is the ability to individualize what presses forward involuntarily in feeling and fantasy. In art as everywhere the individualized and fully marked proceeds from a more indefinite basis, an unorganized fullness. The difference between the artist and the rest of us consists essentially in the ability to transpose what is obscurely imagined and felt into individual figures and events. And this ability means something positive, not merely a limitation. When the work is finished, the casting successful, there is no contrast between the involuntary fullness and the shaped figures; the former has come fully into its own in the latter.

18. The kind of irony that has the character of a positive going along with the presuppositions of others stands close to humor. There is a subterranean connection between the humorist and his object, as there is in pedagogical irony. The difference between irony and humor has often been expressed thus: in irony there is jest behind earnest, in humor earnest behind jest. Earnest is everywhere conditioned by the relation to a value: earnest sets an end and sets the will in motion in the direction of this end. In irony one apparently goes along with values and endeavors, but the ironist makes *[69]* this movement only to keep his inner self free, or — in pedagogical irony — to release psychical energy in the one who acknowledges certain values and ends. That there is jest behind the earnest need only mean that the ironist has his earnest in other directions than those around him. Therefore irony can be an outer form for humor, so that we get the following scheme (where the sign < means "means" or "expression of"):

(Earnest < Jest) = Irony < Humor = (Jest < Earnest), or more simply

Earnest < Jest < Earnest.

The jest in which the humorist hides his earnest consists, then, precisely in the use of irony. Or more simply: behind the jest that in irony is hidden in earnest there lies earnest hidden again.[37] In this way the great irony, as a form of self-assertion or of educating care, passes over into humor.

[37] In a corresponding way the little humor can enter the service of irony, so that we get the scheme: Jest < Earnest < Jest. The earnest that in irony is the outer form for jest is then expressed humorously, i.e., clothed in jest. Formally, psychical processes like those indicated here could always be carried further: Earnest < Jest < Earnest < Jest … But where a definite type of life, a real self, has developed, there will in the end be values and ends that cannot be taken in jest by the individual himself.

One might ask why earnest should be expressed in jest at all. Fr. Schlegel (of whom Novalis rightly said that he was really a humorist, not an ironist) has already given the answer. The answer is that there can be so intimate and so comprehensive a spiritual content of life that every positive form becomes unsatisfying, incommensurable. And this will be the case especially where experience of life has set us face to face with great contrasts whose sting we have felt. The value in whose service earnest stands will prove to stand in contrast to other values and thereby points beyond itself. Here, as in artistic shaping, a negative element comes forward. Even the highest values must be shaped and
[70] limited through their relation to other values. This experience makes the humorist prefer to speak jestingly and indirectly; he thereby guards his inner tasks, reserves for himself the continued work on them. Then there is in addition the relation of value to reality, and with it a new series of tasks. Reality can, as experience shows, conflict with our values, or be altogether indifferent toward them. We need not therefore give up the faith in the validity of values that shows itself in continued work to realize them; but we become more reserved in confessing, and the jesting or indirect form then offers itself naturally. By using it we do not shut ourselves up absolutely; the experienced and knowing will be able to read earnest out of the text of the jest. The jest itself, however, is not merely a refuge, a way out. Through it the mind proves its superiority over the contradictions and contrasts it has to struggle with in its intimate holding fast to what makes life worth living. This feature comes out in all the different forms of humor (to which we shall return in the next chapter).

Of greatest significance here is the contrast between the world of values and the world of reality.

If one takes a purely empirical standpoint, the world of reality stands as far more comprehensive than the world of values. The valuable is only a part, perhaps a vanishingly small part, of the world of reality. This came forward in grand style when the old picture of the world, with its cozy surveyability within a closing frame, was dissolved, and it dawned on consciousness that it is impossible to fix limits for the world. Angels could now no longer ascend and descend from the heaven of values to the earth of reality, and no absolute center can any longer be shown, either as regards value or as regards reality. Like a little oasis the realm of values now stands in contrast to the great desert of reality. Or let me use another image, taken from an entry in a diary.

"It is cold and raw today. A sharp wind sweeps through the leafless trees. But this same wind produces in the Aeolian harp on the house I live in tones full of mood, a long, deep, soothing sound. So the realm of values can reveal itself in the midst of the raw, cold world of reality."

There are two elements here, which both images indicate. The oasis lies within the *[71]* desert itself; the same wind that causes the dreariness also calls forth the comforting sound. Value, then, is both a contrast to reality and a part of it. Through this doubleness a mood of life like humor becomes possible — a disposition that does not lose its sense for the valuable and its faith in its validity because not everything can be derived and explained from it, or because everything else in the world seems indifferent toward it. Humor will fasten on this: that it is by virtue of the same laws that something valuable exists in the world and that the indifferent or hostile reality comes to be. The wind shakes the trees, but sounds through the Aeolian harp. It stands as a victory that in some places in the world there has nevertheless been a breakthrough of something great and good, even if it is a pure fantasy that everything should be arranged so that such breakthroughs could be possible. A humorous mood can come forth before the representation of the overwhelming power of the enormous masses, which nevertheless cannot prevent the sound of values from being heard. For it is only the materially or quantitatively great that appears in the masses of the world; in the world of thought, and of values in general, there expresses itself a greatness of another kind, a greatness of inwardness, with which all extension in space and time is incommensurable. A feeling of defiance can arise when the contrasts come forward in their sharpest form; but the more the mind immerses itself in the values themselves and in the causal series within the world of reality that produce values, the more the great humor will come to rule. And it is, after all, also such a disposition that is the basis of energetic work to produce and hold fast values.

A special occasion for humor toward the course of things in the world arises from the experience that the valuable is often produced by causes that seemed to work in an entirely different direction, so that they, to speak mythologically, against their will or without their will come to accomplish what stands for us as beautiful and good. It is the same thing that, when human feelings and actions are in question, is called the shifting of value. (Cf. Psychology VI C; Ethics XIII, 4). Natural forms and natural scenes that appeal to our aesthetic feeling have nevertheless not developed in order to produce *[72]*

aesthetic values, but according to definite causal laws. Human forms of society and culture to which we ascribe ethical value may nevertheless have developed under the influence of the blind need for self-preservation, nourishment and propagation. It is often manifold and very diverse motives that bring about the great and valuable results in history. This holds in small things, in people's good advice and friendly helping hand,[38] as it holds in decisions of world history. What came into the world as a mere means, perhaps an enforced means, later acquired value for itself and could be set up as an end. Thus, for example, the great conquerors have often worked in the service of humanity by leading beyond national and confessional boundaries, although their own end was the satisfaction of lust for power and ambition. And even where it was an end valuable in itself that was set, it often proved to be only a means, a station on the way to a greater goal.

One may grieve that to the great ends there do not always correspond great and noble means, but that it is often very elementary or even purely egoistic causes that lead to the realization of the great values. But one can also see it as significant that even such causes come to serve the valuable in the world. It is then not the values that are degraded by being realized through elementary causes, but conversely the causes that are ennobled by the laws according to which they work containing the possibility of the arising of valuable wholes. There is room, then, for smiles as well as for tears, and both moods can unite into humor, with different timbre according to the relation between the two single feelings.

A little diary entry can be used here too, partly as example, partly as symbol. It arose from an observation made on the steam ferry across the Great Belt. — "I stood looking at
[73] the gulls that followed the ship, and admired their quick and daring turns, the perfectly formed movements, the graceful curves their flight described. I enjoyed the splendid sight of the white-gray birds in the radiant sunshine. And then I came to think of the cause of all this glory — what it was that made the whole sight possible: the need for nourishment, the striving for food, the struggle for sustenance!" — So far as I remember, the sight did not lose its luster through this reflection; but the mood became somewhat more composite. Perhaps the first joy was nevertheless pushed aside for a moment, but

[38] Cf., for example, the complex of motives that (in *George Eliot's The Mill on the Floss.* Book I. Chap. 3) led Mr. Riley to advise Mr. Tulliver to put his son in a particular boarding school. It is a piece of psychology that cannot be summarized.

then returned strengthened.

With all ideal values shifts of value play an important part. As regards art, Yrjo Hirn has shown in a very interesting presentation how a whole series of practical ("utilitarian") factors furthered the development of the different art forms and led to the growth of the sense of beauty. Such factors are: the need to exert magical influence or erotic enchantment, to spur on to war or work, and not least to communicate one's thoughts to others.[39] Something corresponding holds, as I have shown in my Ethics, for ethical ideas and feelings. —

The great humor sees life both as great and as small, both as favorable to value and as hostile to value, both as tragic and as comic. Solger was the first to describe humor in detail as the unity of comic and tragic feeling, of irony and enthusiasm. He is somewhat wavering in his use of the concepts irony and humor. Most clearly he describes humor in his dialogue "Erwin" thus: "The tragic and the comic here still lie undivided side by side… Everything in humor is in one stream, and everywhere, as in the ordinary world, the contrasts pass over into one another. Nothing in humor is ludicrous and comic that does not have an element of dignity or cannot awaken wistfulness — nothing is exalted and tragic that could not, in its shaping in the low world of time, sink down into the insignificant or the ludicrous." (Erwin. Berlin 1907. p. 354). Only in longing can the thought of the highest, as raised above vanity, dwell; but the humorist must regard this longing as worth far more than the limited form in which fantasy is able to shape the *[74]* highest (Erwin. p. 358).

This Solgerian standpoint Kierkegaard does not let come into its own in his treatise on "Begrebet Ironi." He looked at it with theological-Hegelian eyes. In the work mentioned (and in notes contemporary with it) Kierkegaard conceived the relation between irony and humor as one of opposites. Irony is supposed to be egoistic, and to be placed in constant struggle against the world. Humor, on the other hand, is supposed to be freed from the world; it stands as the expression of a religious earnestness of life and of the consciousness of belonging within a great whole. Irony is supposed to be aristocratic and polemical, but humor is reconciled with the world and rests in a faith that is held fast despite all absurdities. (Skrifter XIII p. 35–119.)

Later, on the other hand, after the definitive break with speculative theology, Kierkegaard

[39] *Konstens Ursprung* p. 173–294.

no longer regards humor as a religious stage. It now stands for him as the last human stage before the religious stage — as the expression of the limit of the highest purely human. It is characterized more closely as essentially conditioned by wistfully smiling recollection. It is directed backward, or rather, time no longer plays any part for it. Religion, on the other hand, looks forward. At the religious stage life is, from first to last, in small things and great, determined by the representation of God, in relation to which everything else loses its worth, so that the highest becomes self-annihilation before God.[40] — A test of this definitive view of humor of Kierkegaard's will be undertaken below, in the chapter on the tragic and humor.

[40]The writings belonging here are: *Studier paa Livets Vej* and *Uvidenskabelig Efterskrift.* — Cf. on Kierkegaard's stage of humor *Danske Filosofer.* p. 160–162.

IV. Main Forms of Humor

19. The single feelings that later, in union, produce a total feeling can come from very *[75]* different sides. Here especially, as on so many other points, the relation between self-assertion and devotion is of significance. Humor thus takes on a different timbre when it develops on the basis of superiority and loftiness of mind, or on the basis of wistfulness and longing, than when its essential elements are sympathy and understanding. Moreover, within these different forms it again depends on what has been experienced of sorrow and joy, of want and enjoyment — what experience and reflection have opened the eye to — how great a wonder life has called forth — what disappointments it has caused — and what understanding has been won from the whole. Here, as on so many other points, the sporadic character of the mental life at its earlier stages of development, so strongly stressed by Sibbern, appears. Now when both the basis of the experiences and the experiences themselves are different, there must naturally occur an extraordinary number of forms of humor. There will moreover be a great difference in how easily and quickly the fusion or the organization takes place. Often there will be hard crises to go through, inner strife to fight out, before it reaches a certain firmness and closedness in one of the main forms of humor. Such periods of fermentation belong among the psychological experiences Sibbern has described best.[41]

However prominent the sporadic character of the mental life is, it is still a more *[76]* prominent peculiarity of it that every psychical element has a tendency to enter into

[41] *Danske Filosofer* p. 101. — *Sibbern* first arrived at his idea of sporadic development by the psychological path. Later he found analogous relations in nature and in the circumstances of society, so that that idea could enter as an essential member into his view of the world. Since he very often uses development within embryonic life as an example, I assume that he was influenced by the French embryologist *Serres,* who (1829), in contrast to the development from center to periphery assumed by Harvey, Wolf and Haller, maintained that embryonic development proceeds "par des noyaux latéraux qui se soudent ensuite," something he showed in particular for the formation of bone. *Cuvier: Histoire des Progrès des Sciences Naturelles.* Bruxelles 1837–38. II p. 431–434.

connection with other elements so that a whole can be formed. It is Kant's immortal merit — greater than the one he himself laid most weight on — that he maintained the need and ability for gathering activity as the innermost peculiarity of all mental life. This need and ability he found in sense perception and in the association of representations, and especially in the special forms that scientific research presupposes. He also found in it the explanation of the human spirit's constant yearning to reach out beyond the domain of experience and science, since it could not, after all, from the first know its own limits. With this way of looking at things Kant set the science of the mind its proper task.[42]

What is to express the peculiarity of the mental life in all domains must naturally be of a formal kind. What Kant called "the hidden art in man's interior" is not bound to any definite content, precisely because it sets its stamp on all content taken up into the soul. Kant himself applied his concept of synthesis predominantly to the domain of the life of thought. But if he is right in his view, something corresponding must also hold for the other sides of the mental life. There must thus be a certain tendency, a need and an ability, to gather the joys and sorrows of life into a total feeling, which one might perhaps call a synthetic feeling, just as in the domain of the will there must be a tendency to gather all endeavors into one great striving.

What are called, often somewhat pretentiously, psychological laws state the different forms and conditions of the gathering activity. As regards the special formations of
[77] wholes, one cannot, as already remarked earlier, expect that they could be derived from the knowledge we have of the sporadic utterances of sensation, representation, pleasure and pain, involuntary striving, drive and wish. There are so many possibilities of cooperation and counteraction, of strife and union, of connections of very different degree and kind, that we are referred to studying the wholes after they have actually formed, and then afterwards finding how the sporadic development may have led to such results. We are placed here, in the psychological domain, in a way similar to our position before all formations of wholes in nature.[43]

The great humor, as I am trying here to describe it, has a quite peculiar possibility of being a concluding total feeling. We still lack thorough psychological investigations

[42] *Den nyere Filosofis Historie.* II. p. 27–29; 42–46. — Cf. above § 2 and § 8.

[43] Cf. on this: *Den menneskelige Tanke* p. 218–237; 338–345. In a special paper I hope to illuminate this point more closely from an epistemological viewpoint.

of the different possible total feelings that might tend to take on a concluding character for a period of life, or perhaps for a whole life. The description and analysis of a single total feeling cannot furnish proof that it should be the most significant or the noblest. I shall only draw attention to what I called the great humor and investigate the conditions it has for being a concluding total feeling. It comes to be through the experience of the contrasts of life, through the clash of single feelings, with the cooperation of reflection and of striving for ends held fast with energy and faithfulness through the years. And it has the possibility of keeping receptivity open to what new experiences may bring.

The psychological possibility of such a total feeling, the dangers that threaten it, and the conditions to which it is subject will be investigated in the following sections of this treatise. For the present we go more closely into some of the main forms already mentioned (see § 13) in which the great humor can appear.

20. The limiting phenomena appear here in such cases where it is superiority or loftiness of mind that forms the basis. Against such a basis even very strong and penetrating *[78]* experiences can glance off without lasting effect. They do not shake the firm center of the mental life and therefore release neither scorn nor fear. But precisely because of the inner firmness there is a possibility of a jesting attitude toward experiences, the unfavorable as well as the favorable, as well as of sympathy with people. The more freely a person stands in his own self-assertion, the more he masters it, the more he can take part in the struggle of others for self-assertion. There is a secure feeling of power present here that brings no need to make superiority felt toward the small, but can precisely give rise to the need to find an outlet for energy through helping work. True superiority does not need to compare itself with those who stand lower, but presupposes precisely that one has won a thorough self-assessment through comparison with the greatest. Often the way goes through struggle and conflict. As long as no resistance is felt, no hindrance stops, no expectation is disappointed, no thorough total feeling will form. The strength is not put to a decisive test. As with all experience, it holds here too that nothing but positive instances permits no secure inference. Just as logic demands that we inform ourselves not only about the cases in which a phenomenon occurs but also about those in which it does not occur, so too experience of life is won only when one works not only with the current but also against the current. Only thereby is the ground color obtained that according to Plato was necessary for the proper color of character to become fast. Even

where the development of personality proceeds continuously, reliability and firmness come into it only when it has been tested through disappointment and want, and when it has learned to hold a great goal fast despite the hindrances it meets and despite the distance at which attainment lies. A storm, says La Rochefoucauld, makes a bonfire blaze more strongly, while it puts out a candle. If a feeling can maintain itself although its object is far away and no sensuous presence or vivid image supports it, it will become all the more intimate and strike root all the more deeply. A great sorrow can release energy
[79] that would otherwise not come into play. It already takes energy to grieve, to endure and live through the tension between the feeling of the worth of what is lost and the certainty that it is now really lost. The easiest way to be freed from this tension would be to push one of the terms out, either to forget what is lost or to imagine that what is lost has no worth. It takes superiority and loftiness of mind not to seize either of these ways out. Or rather it is the other way round: through the courage that seizes neither of these ways out, the way goes forward to superiority and loftiness of mind.

Stoic loftiness of mind did not go this way to the end.[44] It was dearly bought with fear of the involuntary movements of the mind. Every bond that ties us to someone or something brings the possibility of being drawn into joys and sorrows that come independently of our will. Therefore, the Stoics maintained, if one wants to keep one's spiritual freedom and balance, one must keep to what is in our power and regard nothing as good or evil except insofar as it furthers or checks our self-mastery. The Stoic stands at the play of life as a cool spectator who attentively follows the course of the play but takes good care not to let himself be carried away by it. Above all he fears coming "to sigh within himself." The inner sanctuary is to be kept wholly untouched by what happens in the world.

For Stoicism, therefore, more than for any other direction in the Greek conception of life, humor is a foreign feeling. Stoicism seeks precisely to push out and exclude the elements by whose connection humor could arise. It shuts the contrasts of life out instead of working its way through them. Humor is possible only when self-assertion need not be so anxious and convulsive that it cuts itself off from being gripped by what is experienced in the course of life. Humor presupposes that so much energy can be released and put

[44] Cf. on Stoicism *Mindre Arbejder.* First series (the paper on pagan seekers after truth) and Third series (the papers on Epictetus and Marcus Aurelius).

at the disposal of self-assertion that one can take the blows the world gives, and be a witness to the stupidity and sluggishness that spread in the world, without being shaken in one's inner confidence and firmness — indeed, even so that one has a smile to spare for it.

When one has learned that the highest happiness consists in striving and work, one *[80]* will find the most natural explanation of all moral evil in its springing from inertia, from a lack of ability to develop beyond the stage on which one has come to stand or rest. What is lacking is a sufficiently strong influence and impulse to release the bound forces. From such a viewpoint the struggle between good and evil presents itself differently than when one, with the theologians, derives evil from an incomprehensible fall that was supposed at one stroke to have brought the highest sin, defiance of the clearly known good and right, into the world. And when one then also has the experience that precisely the struggle against evil can release ideal forces to combat it, call forth great and beautiful endeavors that would otherwise not have arisen, the feeling toward life and existence becomes more composite. It may recall the mood that in an old Easter hymn leads to the outcry O, felix culpa! No formula and no dogma suffices here, here where the greatest contrasts, dependent on each other, are united in what one might call a cosmic feeling of life. Nowhere does it show itself more than here that our deepest and most comprehensive experiences of life can be expressed only in the symbolic form of poetry.

21. Where there is superiority and loftiness of mind, there is a firm ground, and the question becomes how great a mobility and receptivity is possible despite this firmness. Where humor has developed with wistfulness and longing as its basis, the question becomes the opposite, namely whether despite the mobility and receptivity there can be the firmness that no total feeling can do without.

Wistfulness looks back, lives in memory. Longing looks forward, lives in hope and in yearning. There is an element of sorrow in both, in the one because a value has gone out of life, in the other because the distance from the goal is so great. But there is joy in both, because one lives and breathes in something that has value, whether it belongs to the past or to the future. It has rightly been maintained[45] that the real, hostile opposite of joy is not *[81]* sorrow but loathing and disgust. Joy and sorrow can very well enter into a fusion and an organization. Wistfulness and longing too can go together; one can long back to the past

[45] *Alexander Shand:* Foundations of Character. p. 395.

when it becomes really alive in memory, and there can be wistfulness in longing when the thought of how distant and difficult the goal is predominates. The presupposition of both these feelings is that there is sufficient psychical energy to live not only in what is sensuously present but in a certain independence of it. In dull and depressed times there can stir, as a last flaring up of psychical energy, a longing, perhaps a wistful longing, for the time when one could still long.[46] These feelings lose this significance as an expression of psychical energy where the relation to the present falls away entirely, and past and future stand in no connection whatever with the present. Life then becomes a life of dream or fantasy. Romantic humor took on this character in a high degree. According to Steffens the best thing in the time he lived in was the sense for the old, vanished times.[47] Every view of life that has its ideal in the past has a great danger to struggle with here.

It was by awakening a great and living expectation, an intimate longing, that original Christianity worked so strongly in its first period. Only such moods as can directly or indirectly be derived from this great longing bear the name of Christian with historical right. This longing was directed toward a great goal; therefore it showed itself so violently and so intimately. But it was not directed toward any distant goal. In the very nearest future, which the people of original Christianity could hope to live to see, a great breakthrough of heavenly forces was expected, which was to bring about an entirely new, ideal order of things ("the kingdom of heaven" in its definite, historical meaning). Longing here became a force of world history. And there is perhaps no better proof of the significance of longing than this: that even after that expectation had paled and its goal had been pushed out into the blue, into the indefinite — which happened when the
[82] Church had settled down comfortably in the present — even then the moods it called forth, and the representations to which it gave occasion, work as essential elements in the entirely new religion that modern Christianity in fact is.[48] —

Where memory or expectation of great things rules, much of what could otherwise have stood as important, far-reaching and fateful will now call forth only a smile. What moves the half-experienced so that balance is lost fades now before the mind's absorption in the great. And when it nevertheless tries to exert its power over the mind, the smile is drawn forth — not the bitter smile of satire or scorn, or the hidden smile of irony, but the

[46] Cf. the chapter on "Sehnsucht" in *Holzapfel's Panideal* (Leipzig 1901).
[47] See *Danske Filosofer* p. 43.
[48] Cf. the section "Urkristendom og moderne Kristendom" in my *Religionsfilosofi* (IV. C).

quiet and bright smile of humor. There is, after all, access to a world far greater than the one the new experiences belong to. Yet that world is not jealous of this one. It has room open for it, though perhaps not the prominent place the new experiences would in and of themselves claim.

Where the relation to the present is wholly lacking, or is only negative, wistfulness and longing do not give rise to humor. Thus it has probably been rightly remarked of Shelley that he lacked humor.[49] His overflowing life of mood found vent in mighty or ethereal fantasies that expressed his indignation or his longing, and that bear the stamp of pure light or pure darkness, but do not let the light be broken in any prism. The whole real world stood for him, in its finitude and limitation, as a misunderstanding, an illusion.

The basis for humor is often found, rather than in people of fantasy, in people whose life has passed in practical occupations and amid manifold changes that have brought experience and understanding with them. Deeds and fates need not be in the grand style to open the mind to the secrets of life. George Eliot speaks in a letter of "the poetry and pathos, the tragedy and comedy, that may be hidden in a human soul that looks *[83]* out through dull gray eyes and speaks in a voice of quite ordinary tone." One may meet people of this type on one's way, but uses the opportunity all too seldom to get to know them more closely. One of the minor characters in Mrs. Gyllembourg's "To Tidsaldre" ("Two Ages") is a fine example. It is said here of the skipper's widow Madam Lyng: "She had been through much in life and was one of those never sufficiently appreciated people in whom goodness and gentleness of heart take the place of upbringing and cultivation, and whom the memory of their own sufferings and wrongs teaches fineness in social intercourse in spite of any outward position in life." — This characterization contains essential conditions for humor, even if this quality is not directly ascribed to the good woman. It is especially the "fineness" that must be noticed. It is the ability to take a considerate and understanding attitude toward what life brings, without the outward differences it presents being able to impress. Much can here be taken with a smile that in the untried would awaken unrest, pain or scorn. Sorrow has had, so to speak, a vaccinating force. Thereby the plain woman could be so much to the story's unhappy heroine and take her fate in her hand. If she was not in reality a humorist, it

[49] Browning: *Essay on Shelley.* London 1903. p. 60–64. — *A. C. Bradley: Shelley's View of Poetry.* (Oxford Lectures on Poetry. London. 1909. p. 163–167.)

was because her disposition first and foremost deposited itself in action (see ch. VII), not branching out into moods. —

Wistfulness and longing can lead not only to outer events and the conduct of others being taken with humor; our own faults too we can take in the same way, especially when we can see them as the faults of our virtues, as members or parts of our own personality. When others then attack, we may perhaps (like Viggo Stuckenberg in "Bekendelse," toward a friend's attempts at conversion) maintain the positive worth of our sins, because without them we would not be what we are. We need not therefore underestimate the purgatory of remorse. Our personality as it now is, with its wistfulness and its longing, has presumably gone precisely through this purgatory; but in memory the single action fades into a member of the whole development of the personality, perhaps even into a
[84] felix culpa, and in the longing forward there is not time to dwell on what no longer has practical significance.

22. The types of humor depicted in what precedes stand nearer to self-assertion than to devotion. Superiority and loftiness of mind, wistfulness and longing can nevertheless form the basis for a jesting with one's own and others' conduct and fate that is bound up with a positive valuing of their acting and suffering. In contrast to the course of development that leads from the original need for self-preservation in the direction of egoism (Psychology VI C, 1), these types are the results of a development that has excluded captivity in the own isolated self and its interests. And it is by virtue of great energy that this liberation has been reached in the school of experience of life. There can then be formed one total feeling toward the contrasts and changes of life that is not conditioned merely by these having intervened in the person's own isolated existence.

This liberation from the contrast between one's own and another's fate becomes still more complete where humor develops on the basis of sympathy (in the sense of immediate joy with and sorrow with). Here there is from the very first a connection between the person and what sets his feeling in motion. Set against the feeling of unity or wholeness that here once and for all joins subject and object, much that would otherwise stand as an object of scorn and ill will can be taken in a jesting way, because it is not for a moment forgotten that behind it there lies a value that perhaps even shows itself indirectly in the ludicrous itself. It is here too the deep basis that makes humor possible. The contrast to scorn is here the greatest possible, and yet the possibility of jest does not

vanish; it is precisely this that makes humor a total feeling.

As I have shown in my Ethics (IX, 1), it would be wrong to set sympathy without more ado in contrast to self-assertion. Devotion can be a continuation of self-assertion. It need not be a purely passive state, but can be the expression of a force able to embrace something other and more than what self-preservation requires. Here the great saying about love can hold, that it bears all things, endures all things, overcomes all things. *[85]* Loftiness of mind need not bear the stamp of love, but in love, as it can be, there is loftiness of mind. It is love of this kind that can be the basis of the great humor. It may have developed by different paths: through a shifting of motive from self-assertion — through development on the basis of a natural instinct — or in the school of sorrow and pain.[50]

The active, energetic character of the sympathy presupposed here will also show itself in this: that the larger circle of values and interests to which the person attaches himself in sympathy opens the possibility of sorrows and cares he would otherwise have been free of. The person could have got through life more easily if he had not widened the circle of what could set his feeling in motion.

One must think here not only of the relation to other people but also of the relation to life or existence as a whole. There can be a fellow feeling that extends to nature, to all life that unfolds and strives forward. A person can attach his interest to something that reaches far beyond the domain of individual life, and whose advance or decline determines the worth he ascribes to reality as it is. The humor that forms on this basis becomes a cosmic feeling of life, a fundamental mood raised above the contrast between optimism and pessimism, since it does not close its eyes to disharmonies and misfortunes, but does not, over the suffering in the world and the downfall of so much that is great and beautiful, lose the feeling of unity with the stream of value that constantly makes its way despite all hindrances. It is properly only at this point that humor becomes a view of life.

23. This last consideration leads over to a presupposition that is in a higher or lower degree common to all the forms of humor depicted in what precedes. In the description of these types weight has been laid especially on what I call the *basis*, i.e., the life of feeling *[86]*

[50] In *King Lear* IV, 6, 225 Gloster says to Edgar: Now, good sir, what are you? — And Edgar answers: A most poor man, made tame to fortune's blows; who, by the art of known and feeling sorrows, am pregnant to good pity.

that forms the presupposition. But the intellectual presuppositions cannot be excluded from the description, whether these presuppositions are owed merely to the person's personal experiences or also to the scientific insight into the course and laws of nature and history that he has been able to win. When these intellectual presuppositions come forward with special weight, they form a *background* that works together with the basis to determine the timbre of the whole type. The background is intellectual and objective, the basis emotional and subjective. The background exerts a more indirect influence than the basis, just as air and light gain influence on life only when it already exists in germ. On the same objective background the most different standpoints or views of life can unfold, according to the different basis that is present. Background and basis will not be altogether independent of each other. It may depend on the basis how firm and comprehensive a background develops, and the intellectual background can on the other hand check or further the development of the basis.

Whatever it may be that we can feel ourselves bound to, were it the greatest and most comprehensive that could be thought, it is nevertheless part of the great swell of existence. However far we go back into our innermost, and however high we rise in our thoughts, we still do not get beyond the great, lawful connection that proves to rule in all the regions of existence. When this insight has once been won, it will afterwards color all our experiences. The desire and ability for bold striving forward are not necessarily checked by it. Experience teaches us that without great ends and great hope nothing great is accomplished. Without them life stands still or sinks into passive vegetating. But we also know that even the greatest ends are only members of the series of values, which can just as little be thought of as concluded as the series of causes. The goal that is last for us, which forms the horizon of value at which our sight stops, is perhaps nevertheless the beginning of a new series of values. But it is in limitation that mastery shows itself, and even if the trees cannot grow up into heaven, their growth can nevertheless be straight and beautiful.

[87] Barrier and resistance meet not only the great striving; they appear also where strength barely suffices to keep one's head up. Suffering finds its way also to those who lead the quiet life and do not challenge fate. As it rains on the just and the unjust, so pain strikes both the quiet and the striving. But just as the great humor does not lose its smile because earnest striving must clash with barriers, so its smile is not lost either because

suffering also intrudes on the path of quiet happiness. The disharmonies of life fade in the end before the great force with which life is carried on. The humorist does not flee to the desert because not all dreams of blossoms ripen.

The consequence of the reckoning with life that the great humor presupposes can be a new youth. Humor does not come naturally to first youth. Youth lets its strength stream out without thinking of the limits, which can, after all, be known at first hand only through one's own experience. It is impatient and indignant at every stop and every resistance. The new youth presupposes that one has formed firm plans for the use of one's strength — that one has made clear to oneself that one lives in a finite world — but that one nevertheless, with cheerful courage — perhaps with what Sibbern called a cheerful irony of life — always takes up life anew. For the fact too that life constantly offers repetitions one finds a place in one's view of life. The same energy that, despite all barriers, holds fast the values of life one has won is also able to preserve freshness and inwardness despite the dulling and leveling tendency of repetition.

V. The Tragic and Humor

24. As already remarked above, no total feeling can be proved to mark a complete conclusion of the life of feeling. As long as new experiences come, there will also be a possibility of change in the fundamental mood in which what has been experienced has deposited its effects. A complete formation of a whole, whether as fusion or as organization, is an ideal. Complete conclusion can just as little be reached in the domain of the life of feeling as in that of the life of thought. We stand in the midst of a development within which there is constantly the possibility of unexpected experiences. *[88]*

The great humor can therefore not be proclaimed as a mood of life concluding once and for all. Yet it has many conditions for approaching this ideal. Its peculiarity is that the opposed experiences and moods of life can come into their own in it. It presupposes that the mind has been open to all sides of life and has not, in blindness or cowardice, avoided what did not please. It knows both times when one must live despite a deficit and times when one lives out of a fullness that seems inexhaustible; but it comes out of these oscillations with a surplus that makes superiority over the course of fate possible, a surplus that is not, like the child's, merely a gift of nature, but is in good part self-acquired, is saved-up work. What has been done and suffered in the past one works together with the new that comes. The different experiences do not stand on the same level. It is the most earnest experiences of life about which all other experiences of life gather without being able to break them, but gather precisely so that by contrast with them they appear as jest. In the certainty of the validity of values one can smile at reality's attempt to be everything. One can smile at the constant shifts of value, at having got something *[89]* entirely different out of life than one had thought. Wilhelm Meister's "Lehrjahre" ends, after all, with the young man being compared with Saul, the son of Kish, who went out to look for his father's asses and ended by being anointed king and counted among

the prophets. Perhaps one has also had the experience that the outer forms of life we build up so laboriously as a defense for it, as a bed for its stream, became precisely only hindrances to its free course. In short, the world has been overcome in earnest and can therefore now be overcome in jest.

Humor strives to unite the tragedy of life with its comedy. The two elements are united in it, now so that they are joined into one, now so that they make up an ordered whole. When language formed the expression "tragicomedy," it thereby designated especially the preponderance of the comic, and therefore the word does not fit humor, where the jest moves on the ground of earnest. The word has moreover a decidedly scornful or belittling meaning. Or perhaps Frater Taciturnus is right, and the word designates something one can neither laugh nor weep over, because it is neither comic nor tragic. The word "comitragic" would fit humor better.[51]

Kierkegaard maintained that tragic art needs a historical background more than comedy.[52] Insofar as this is right, it must presumably come from this: that earnest first fully asserts itself when we stand before reality in its whole severity, while the comic can better romp in an invented world. But in great comedy the background of reality cannot be lacking; it concerns life, after all, just as tragedy does. Bergson has even assigned the comic a quite special significance for reality by stressing its social character and its social function.[53] Kierkegaard's statement[54] must in any case not be understood as if individual
[90] and private life, life in the narrow circle, did not have its tragedies. It is the merit of the so-called realistic literature to have maintained this through definite examples.[55] Every suffering can take on this character where it befalls a significant personality.

I cite an example from real life that can be said to mark an intermediate form between the tragic and humor.

The young Swiss woman Adèle Kamm lay chained to her sickbed by an incurable illness and was thereby prevented from working for the ends she had set herself. She felt with anguish that she was shut out from life. But through resignation she reached a new

[51] *Kierkegaard: Samlede Skrifter.* VI p. 392.
[52] *Samlede Skrifter.* VI p. 402 f.
[53] *Henri Bergson's Filosofi*, p. 46–51.
[54] When Kierkegaard refers to Lessing, it must be noted that *Lessing* (*Hamburgische Dramaturgie.* N. 87–92), in contrast to Diderot and Hurd, maintains that in comedy as well as in tragedy the characters are to be individually marked, whether they are taken from history or not.
[55] Cf. *Etik.* XXX, 3.

joy of life. Since she could not "realize her ideal," she said, she would "idealize her reality." She had the idea of organizing a correspondence among young girls who, like her, were chained to a hopeless sickbed and thereby excluded from taking part in ordinary life. The organization became very extensive and reached beyond all confessional barriers. Since the healthy can never properly understand the sick, this fellowship became of great significance. The young patients communicated their moods and experiences to one another and exchanged their thoughts on what kept them up. They thereby supported one another in their struggle still to get something out of life. The feeling of loneliness vanished, and Adèle Kamm now felt herself to be one who took part in the great struggle between good and evil. Thus she kept herself "joyeuse dans l'affliction." "Happiness," she said, "is more precious when it is mixed with despair; peace is more complete when it follows the storm, light more radiant after darkness." Relying on her own experiences, she amused herself sometimes by teasing doctors and clergymen when they came with their prescriptions.[56]

The tragic in suffering is that it hinders the work for what at first seems bound to bring unity and meaning into life. The comic can come forth in that suffering can nevertheless show its impotence before a new spiritual upsurge that it has itself indirectly called forth. And a second time the comic lies in others' vain attempts to treat soul and body by traditional formulas.

That there is pain and suffering in the world is a fact to which no earnest view of life *[91]*
closes its eyes. It is a fact that sets us before great problems. Is there any meaning in there being suffering? Even very pious people can deny that there is such a meaning, and declare that when they believe in God, it is in the certainty that he cannot be the cause of evil.[57] It is, to use philosophical language, the contrast between value and reality that comes forward here, and in particular the difficulty that not all reality can be understood from value. The realm of reality is far more comprehensive than that of values. Only the most elementary values, those immediately tied to the persistence of individuals and

[56] *Paul Seippel: Adèle Kamm.* Lausanne 1912.

[57] See, for example, *Souvenirs de Marie Flournoy-Burnier.* Genève 1910. (Not available in bookshops). Painful experiences let this highly gifted and deeply religious woman find her only comfort in the thought that all suffering was owed to nature, which God had not created. With a consistency more possible for a Calvinist than for a Lutheran, she maintains: "Si Dieu était véritablement dans le monde, il serait partout le vainqueur." — She did not know that other theists had reached the same conviction, personalities as different as Plato, Holberg, Rousseau, Voltaire, Stuart Mill and William James.

races — and hardly even these — can be understood purely biologically. And yet, things being as they are, pain marks a higher stage of development when compared with a state that is painless only because it is limited. Pain is often tied to the transition from one form of life to another, and it can be a symptom that full harmony among the tendencies of life, or between life and its surroundings, has not yet been reached. That it should be absolutely necessary for such states of transition and crisis to be bound up with pain cannot be proved. It must be taken as a blind fact. But as circumstances now are, suffering is a sign of life, a testimony that the struggle between value and reality, or rather between valuable reality and valueless reality, is still going on. One could escape much suffering by lowering one's level and reducing one's demands on life to a minimum.

It is this actual connection that the great humor looks in the face. It does not engage
[92] in speculations to justify the sufferings in the world, just as little as it acknowledges theological explanations of the fact of suffering. But it takes this fact up into its view of life, into its reckoning of moods. It is no small work to fit the bitter and the dark too into one's picture of existence as a whole; but this work can still leave strength over, so that the small and absurd can be met with the smile it deserves.

25. The great humor is an art of living. It leads beyond all aesthetic play by its clear insight at once into the disharmonies of life and into the values of life. It does not dwell, like art in the narrower sense, on single pictures of life. Poetry and the visual arts can only give examples of how things may go in life, but cannot decide whether these examples mean rule or exception. This holds both when idylls are depicted and when tragedies are depicted. Of course one can, through investigations of the subjects an artist chooses, as well as of the way he treats them, come to know his own mood of life. Here is art's open place, where it is most intimately connected with life. There is an art of living behind poetry and the visual arts, an art of living in which the experiences of life are gathered in a practical intuition. It means no scientific reckoning, although the scientific knowledge available may be woven into it. The great humor points beyond every limited experience that would determine the whole life of feeling, as well as beyond every picture fantasy is able to form. Over against such limitations it uses jest as a liberating means. But it is not itself jest. When the downfall of something valuable is experienced — even if what went under had until then stood as the highest value — the great humor finds new confirmation that no single value can comprise all value. By and in its very downfall the

single value points beyond itself.

When Goethe stood dismissive toward the concept of humor, it was surely because he was offended by romantic poets' burlesque and arbitrary play with everything, a play they themselves perhaps regarded as an expression of humor; but it was not the great humor that lay at its ground. Goethe thought that humor had no hold or law in itself *[93]* and therefore easily, sooner or later, degenerated into melancholy or ill humor. (Letter to Zelter. 30 October 1808). He even declares that one for whom life is bitter earnest cannot be a humorist; the humorist is, he thinks, more taken up with his own mood than with his object. (Unterhaltungen mit Kanzler von Müller. 6 June 1824).[58] — What Goethe is speaking of can evidently not be humor as a total feeling, wrought through experiences of an active and passive kind.

In contrast to the concept of humor Goethe presupposes stands Solger's and Kierkegaard's concept of humor as a view of life or mood of life developed with earnest as its basis and understanding as its background, which does not let the exalted be taken from it because it is connected with the low and paltry, but is able to unite the smile at the latter with enthusiasm for the former. Kierkegaard expressed his view in a very clear way by giving humor a place in the series of "stages" after the ethical stage and before the religious. It was for him the culmination of paganism that it had the strength of spirit to see the comic and the tragic joined into unity. Humor was for him the last stage of life before faith. Naturally he thought only of what has been called the great humor in what precedes, not of what he designated as the immature humor, which is only devil-may-care, an aesthetic refinement that skips over the ethical.[59]

There is an "aesthetic" way of taking life that does not have the character of great humor. One then places oneself outside life as a pure beholder and spectator, perhaps as a passionate spectator, since it can become a passion to look at things without entering into personal relation to them and without heeding whether they cut into the weal and woe of other personal beings. One perhaps feels precisely a need to withdraw from every practical relation to things in order to live in fantasy. This kind of aesthetic feeling is akin to intellectual interest, only it aims more at living in images, while the intellectual *[94]* need seeks concepts and laws. The question is whether such an aesthetic-intellectual

[58] Yet Goethe admired Sterne. He found his humor inimitable. But he adds: "Not every humor frees the soul." (Sprüche in Prosa).

[59] *Skrifter*, VI, p. 393, 405, 414. — VII, p. 249 f.

interest can fill the whole life of the personality without narrowing and drying it up. Goethe's protest against what he understood by humor is motivated by this question. In both scientific and artistic activity it is only a part of the personality that is at work. But how do thought and fantasy relate to the joy and sorrow, the enthusiasm and indignation, the exaltation and dejection that are awakened by one's own personal fate or by the experiences one has of the fortunes of the interests that make life worth living? Here a comprehensive synthesis is demanded, the synthesis of the personality itself, within which the intellectual and aesthetic syntheses are to find their place.[60] The total feeling that becomes ruling in a person, even in the greatest scientist or artist, is determined quite as much by what was experienced outside the particular intellectual or aesthetic sphere as by what was experienced within it.[61] Experiences of a more individual kind will help to determine the ruling total feeling, and besides, both science and art have their open places where they point back to other sides of personal life and take their place within it as a whole. It is the human being, not merely the scientist or the artist, who finds expression in the type of life or the stage. The great humor is one of the possible types of life (stages, syntheses of personality).

It is not in itself necessary that there be a great distance between the human being and the scientist or artist. In the greatest they can stand close to each other. But this closeness is not a matter of course and can presuppose great work. It is in a certain sense human, "all too human," to arrange things so that intellectual work becomes something by itself, which one pushes aside when one has shut the door of one's study in order to take part in life and take what it brings. But when that door is shut, the new work remains of weaving the work and its fruits into life as a whole. Otherwise it easily becomes a pitiful
[95] type of life that comes to correspond to an intellectual work perhaps significant in itself. One does not escape having a standpoint, but it may be a standpoint to match.

Some psychologists think that the feeling of pleasure in the tragic necessarily presupposes that one does not forget that the whole is not earnest. One is conscious that one is not part of it, but sits securely in one's seat in the stalls and watches what goes on on the stage. In a picture by the French painter Vibert, "Le Récit du Missionaire," one sees a missionary showing his scars and telling of what he has suffered for his faith; some

[60] Cf. my paper *Aandelig Kultur.* (Mindre Arbejder. Third series).
[61] In ch. IX we shall return to this point.

fine and distinguished clergymen listen with great interest to his story; the whole is evidently for them an aesthetic enjoyment that captivates them while they sit softly and comfortably on their sofa. One does not get the impression that the captivation concerns their whole mind. A complete and conscious feeling of security must exclude the tragic effect. A clear representation that the whole is not earnest will prevent the living into the course of the action, the participation and suspense without which neither catastrophe nor resolution acquires any significance. Even when we immerse ourselves in memory in our own earlier misfortunes and dangers, we must (in this Spinoza is evidently right)[62] live through them anew as if they were present, so that the release in memory can then call forth a feeling of pleasure.

In any case — for the great humor we are describing here, what occupies the mind is earnest. If it is a play, it does not take place on "the boards that mean the world," but in the real world itself, the stage on which we ourselves play along, whether we will or not, and where we can neither survey the course of the play nor know its end.

26. Every total feeling can be threatened with dissolution, either by essential elements falling away or by new experiences demanding greater energy or changed organization. The great humor too must often fight for its life. The bright and energetic harmony can, for example, be threatened by the clammy fogs of hypochondria, which are called forth by inner organic dispositions or outer depressing experiences. A depressed mood favors or summons all representations of imperfection, misfortune, paltriness, inadequacy. *[96]* Nothing in us or outside us seems to have worth. Even if a world of thought is otherwise at our disposal, in the hypochondriac state it is as if it had never existed, or as if it were an illusion that we lived in and for it. A gray monotony rules, and the fruitful contrast between the great we looked up to and the small we smiled at, this contrast that is the condition of humor, is blurred. Now it is the great that cannot be made present, now it is the small that cannot be seen in its worth. The tasks and events of daily life stand as indifferent, gray, vexatious, obstructive. Even if the thought of the great has not vanished, the small things are nevertheless not brought into relation to it, neither in the comic or tragic relation of contrast nor in the intimate relation of sympathy and understanding, let alone in all these different relations at once. Should a gleam of light fall into this fog, it still brings no joy.

[62] *Ethica* III, 19; 47 Schol.

At its height hypochondria becomes the acedia, the inaccessibility to vigorous spiritual life, that in the Middle Ages was counted among the deadly sins. Dante placed the acediosi in hell, where they stir in the mire, and has them say (Inferno VII, 121–124):

> Sullen were we
> where the sun shone mildly on the meadows,
> for sloth smoldered in our soul;
> now we must hang dismally in the mire!

The old mystics and saints knew this state well and regarded it as the devil's work. Even though they otherwise wished for suffering so as to show their courage and faith through it, this kind of suffering was nevertheless only evil, because it was unfruitful; it did not bring them, as they expressed it in their mystical-erotic language, "to give birth." It makes action impossible.[63] Boccaccio describes it in his commentary on Dante thus: "Such a person is unable to take any initiative, and if he is forced to it, he can still
[97] accomplish nothing. His life flows away as if he were not living it; his thoughts grow ever darker and darker; he shuns the company of others… First he feels indifference, then reluctance, and at last disgust at everything good and beautiful."[64]

Not only can no initiative be taken in such states, but such states are so painful precisely because of their indefinite character, since no definite cause appears that one could try to take hold of. And it can go with the hypochondriac, if in his good times he is a humorist, as it went with Harlequin, who asked a doctor's advice for his melancholy and got the advice — to go and see Harlequin. The jest that has helped many a time to get round a sharp point does not help now, for the good reason that it cannot make headway against the current. The hypochondriac could perhaps be cured if he could get a free moment in which his hypochondria itself could be taken humorously — seen as a dark shadow in the landscape of life, which fades when one sees it from the height, but overwhelms when one is down in the midst of it. But the presupposition for this is that the height is clear, and — that one can keep to the height. —

This everyday example does not even point to the greatest shadows. They appear only when the tragic threatens to tear the connection of life apart forever. How does the

[63] *Joly: Psychologie des Saints.* Paris 1898, p. 187 f. — *Vie de Ste. Terèse, écrite par elle-même.* Chap. XXX.
[64] Quoted after *A. Herrlin: Renaissancens Etik,* p. 50. (Printed as manuscript).

great humor stand before this possibility? Can the tragic in life not become a testimony to its impotence? — Before we take up this earnest question, we shall see how the greatest of all tragic poets stands before it.

27. Shakespeare's mind was open to all sides of life, to all the contrasts it holds, and he knew how to give his experiences expression in individual figures and fates. If we have not ourselves had occasion to have experiences, we can come to stand before them in him. He knew, as Spinoza knew, that nature is rich enough to let the most different and conflicting individuals and fates come forth. As Cordelia and Goneril have the same parents, so goodness and wickedness spring from the laws to which existence is once and for all subject. And fortune and misfortune go their way through the world according *[98]* to the same laws. Wickedness can become so great that one is tempted to lose faith in goodness, and misfortune can seem so overwhelming that everything seems to be in dissolution. There can be occasion to cry out with Cordelia, when she hears of her sisters' conduct toward the old father: Let pity not be believed! (King Lear IV, 3, 30), and with Kent and Edgar when the old mad king comes carrying Cordelia's body: Is this the promis'd end, or image of that horror? (King Lear V, 3, 203). That Shakespeare's heart is in all this is felt through the whole mood and through single moving words. His depictions are like crystallizations that have formed under the influence of the deep movement his experiences caused in his mind. We stand here at art's open place, where from the historically given poetic work we come to see into the poet's own mental life, as it was tuned by what befell him or by what he saw in his circle. Shakespeare scholars think that in the period of his life in which his mightiest tragedies appeared, and which became the high point of his production, shattering events took place for him or in his circle. It went with him as with Dante: he had been in hell.[65] Of what kind these events were one can perhaps form a representation through the two main tragic motives that appear in his work.[66] The one motive is the relation of beautiful and noble natures to a harsh surrounding world. The other is the relation of violent and demonic natures to a surrounding world they seek to bend to their will. If the characterization of Shakespeare's personality that A. C. Bradley has given in his paper "Shakespeare the

[65]The women of Verona pointed at Dante when he went by and said: "There goes he who has been in hell." The Danish translator of *Vita nuova*, Joh. Dam, adds: "This was not irony; he had been in hell, and everyone knew it."

[66]*A. C. Bradley: Oxford Lectures on Poetry*, p. 305.

man" (Oxford Lectures on Poetry) is right, he himself belonged to the open and fine natures whom the blows of the world strike so easily, and who are also strongly affected by what they experience of collision and dark fate around them. But he did not succumb
[99] to the overwhelming, and perhaps his art was his best help here. He was at any rate able in his presentation to let the characters, the evil as well as the good, unfold in their natural consequences, and to let the fates, the unhappy as well as the happy, go their quiet and great way. He was not prevented from revealing to us again and again how the small hangs together with the great, the grotesque with the tragic, the ludicrous with the exalted. Nor has he concealed that the tragic can come forth not only through the collision of character with the world but also, as in "Hamlet," can spring from conflicts in the inner world of the mind between contending forces. Above all, the horrors he looked in the face, or whose possibility his fantasy showed him, did not prevent him from showing us the nobility of the intimate and deep mind in misfortune and downfall itself. As has been said:[67] what happens to a being like Cordelia is not the decisive thing; the decisive thing is that she exists! Philosophically we could express this thus: Shakespeare does not lose his faith that there is value in the world, despite the fact that the valuable so often goes under.

In Shakespeare's last great work, "The Tempest," the feeling of peace and wistfulness gain the upper hand. The tragic is softened and the comic vanishes. But still at the very end, when Prospero thinks he has overcome all evil, so that he gives himself up calmly to festive visions, quite forgetting the human beast Caliban and his conspiracy, he is shaken through by the suddenly emerging thought of the disharmonies that still remain. He has not been able to make the human beast into a human being. And like the festive visions that had to be driven off so suddenly, the whole world we know, with its harmonies and its disharmonies, will one day dissolve into a chaos! But from the thought of tenacious wickedness and of the fleetingness of the glorious his soul is then saved through magnanimity toward those who had acted wickedly against him.

Note. In several places in this treatise, in agreement with various Shakespeare scholars, it has been assumed that from the great poet's works one must be able to infer back to what he
[100] himself had experienced or seen at nearer or greater range. *Georg Brandes* also proceeds from this assumption in his book on Shakespeare, whose chief merit, for the rest, lies in its fine analyses

[67] *A. C. Bradley: Shakespearian Tragedy*, p. 324.

of the content of the single works. On the other hand this assumption is decidedly denied by Shakespeare's most learned and most critical biographer, *Sidney Lee.* "The biographical facts," he says (*A Life of William Shakespeare.* New edition. 1915, p. 417), "give no support to the assumption of a prolonged personal experience of tragic suffering. Nor is this nebulous theory supported by the whole tendency of his literary work… To seek the key to Shakespeare's triumphant conquest of the peaks of tragedy in his personal experience, which must after all necessarily have been limited, is to underestimate his creative power and its magic force." — But the question is precisely whether high artistic creation is psychologically possible without experiences of life lying at its ground. And if this must be denied, the assumption that the poet built on such experiences will by no means lead to thinking less of his art. Rather one would have to admire that art could shape the earnest subjects in so perfect a way.

28. Is there an absolute tragic? Are there fates in which pain and downfall become the last word? If so, we stand here at a limit of the great humor. And if there is a limit, the humorist must himself acknowledge it, and it must increase his wistfulness and make his smile less bright, if there still remains any possibility of a smile at all.

In a letter to Zelter Goethe says: "I am not born to be a tragic poet, for my nature is harmonizing ('conciliant'). Therefore the purely tragic case cannot interest me, since it must properly in its ground be impossible to harmonize." In his conversations with Chancellor v. Müller he comes back to this thought. "Everything tragic rests on a contrast that cannot be evened out. As soon as evening out sets in, or is seen as possible, the tragic vanishes." "Tragic I call a situation from which no way out is possible, no reconciliation ('composition') conceivable." (Unterredungen mit Kanzler v. Müller. 6 June 1824 and 2 July 1830). He criticizes Hegel's conception of the tragic as resting on a conflict between two powers each justified in itself. Hegel's favorite example was "Antigone," whose main subject in his view was the conflict between family and state. Such collisions take place, after all, within one and the same ethical whole; family and state are both members of the life of mankind, and since this more comprehensive whole is maintained precisely *[101]* through the downfall of one-sided endeavors, tragedy leads to a clearer understanding of life. The properly tragic is thus for Hegel not the catastrophe but the conflict, and the conflict always has the necessary function of maintaining the mutual limitation of the different ethical powers.

Hegel's bright and energetic optimism would, if it could be held fast, widen the limits of the great humor as a view of life. But Goethe is unfortunately right against Hegel.

There can be, and there is, absolute tragedy. For Hegel the fate of single individuals is indifferent, so long as the great ideas constantly prove their power. But even if a person's worth rests on the cause he serves, should it then be indifferent whether he himself, whose soul is filled with this cause, persists or goes under? Tragic suffering cannot be indifferent, however great the weight one lays on the often (not always) fruitful conflict between different values that have not found their limitation. The ideas (the values) are, after all, represented in the world of experience by personal beings. And, as we have seen (§ 27), it is precisely the way in which the tragic hero in his very downfall reveals and maintains his exalted disposition that conditions the proper working of tragedy on our mind.

On the famous passage in Aristotle's Poetics, commented on countless times, where he finds the effect of tragedy to consist in its awakening terror and pity in such a way that these feelings are thereby "purged," there has been disagreement especially as to what is understood here by "purging." It is perhaps most correct, with Erwin Rhode (Psyche[2] II, p. 49), to think of an analogy to the way in which music can at once awaken strong feelings and — precisely through the awakening and the discharge — bring it about that they do not rule over the mind in a painful and inhibiting way. Of more recent music one could think here of Beethoven's Fifth Symphony, "the Fate Symphony," where one first hears fate's heavy blows on the gate and, by being permeated with the mood thus awakened, is prepared to be affected by the at once cheerful and wistful impression of the
[102] symphony's last part. But what Aristotle at any rate says nothing about is what character "terror and pity" take on when they have been "purged." A. W. Benn has therefore called him a poor psychologist.[68] But the point is perhaps that the Greeks did not have the understanding of the metamorphoses of the mind and the shifts of feeling that was won later. What Aristotle could not express in his psychological language may have been precisely what Benn himself maintains: that pity toward heroic characters passes over into admiration, and toward gentle and self-sacrificing characters into love. And terror must be assumed to undergo a corresponding change.[69] Terror and pity do not vanish,

[68] *Aristoteles' Theory of Tragic Emotion.* Mind. 1914, p. 89.

[69] Benn interprets Aristotle as meaning that pity passes over into terror, and that this is then calmed by the artistic mood (plot-interest) gaining the upper hand through one's knowing oneself to be in safety. I cannot find anything about this in the text. It is both terror and pity that are "purged."

but are "purged" by becoming elements in a more complex feeling.[70]

29. In the tragic, humor has one of its limits. The humorist does not bend himself together over the wound like the tragic hero. His wounds are not mortal and need not drive away the smile. The tragic hero can show greatness even in downfall, but pain and sorrow exclude the possibility of the smile.

The humorist knows that life has its tragedies as well as its comedies. His experience of life, both what is owed to his personal fate and what is owed to experiencing the fates of others, can be rich and comprehensive. And his striving aims, consciously and unconsciously, at letting the great contrasts have their justified influence on the timbre of the total mood. But he must admit that where the tragic is of such a nature that there is no strength or room for letting the bright elements of the mind have influence, there no organization or fusion is possible. The cosmic harmony in which the humorist consciously or unconsciously believes collapses where there is an absolutely tragic fate — *[103]* where suffering and downfall are one. Only the tragic hero, not the humorist as such, maintains the nobility of mankind in such a catastrophe.

The humorist is willing to grant the tragic hero the highest place. But he does not give way to anyone else either. And especially he does not give way to those who spend their lives talking of what tragic heroes have done and suffered without themselves having anything tragic in their existence. Moreover, the humorist protests against the tragic being declared, in defiance of experience, to express the innermost being of life. That is only romanticism. The tragic hero himself will have no time or sense for such assertions; he feels himself standing precisely out at the limit of all human relations and all human ability; all his energy, although it surpasses what the humorist as such commands, goes into standing where he stands. The highest pathos makes one silent, or at least sparing of words, however talkative those may be who know this pathos only at third or fourth hand.

The tragedy of life that lies beyond the great humor comes as an earthquake comes. It is perhaps announced, like this, by preceding tremors. But it does not depend on ourselves whether we experience anything of the kind. Perhaps by omitting an action

[70]Recently the "psychoanalysis" founded by *Freud* has maintained that certain forms of mental illness can be cured by a painful experience in which the real cause of the illness lay being drawn clearly and definitely forth into the patient's consciousness, which is thereby "purged." The method is accordingly called catharsis, the same expression Aristotle uses.

that our ideal of life demands we could avoid a tragic fate. But then the ethical weight lies on the omission of this action, and this point belongs to the discussion of the relation between action and humor that a later chapter will bring. Just as action marks the limit of humor from the active side, absolute tragedy marks this limit from the passive side. The humorist thinks he has honestly and fairly sought and followed the right way without having failed any task that could have brought about tragic conflicts. He admits that this way of his has led through mild regions, and that the tension his stage, like every earnest stage of life, has brought is to be regarded as harmony in comparison with tragic pain. He perhaps dares add that he would not draw back if a tragic fate could not be avoided without harming his soul. His admiration for the tragic heroes is grounded in
[104] understanding. Partly he can very well put himself into situations that for his own part do not go beyond the world of possibilities, partly he recognizes that tragedy reveals a limit to the harmony between value and reality. But he does not renounce being a hero because he is not tragic. He fights his fight to assert himself through holding fast his conviction of the coherence and worth of life despite all disharmonies in detail. This fight can lead him right up to the limit of the tragic. If this limit is to be crossed, the question becomes whether he can undergo the metamorphosis without which the tragic hero does not come to be.

In Gunnar Gunnarson's magnificent book "Borgslægtens Historie" it is said of a young man who wanted to give up everything to wander about as an ascetic and prophet (IV, p. 117): "It did not for a moment occur to him that he had already suffered a defeat — that this life he had resolved to lead had no root in his own soul, no presupposition in his earlier life. He did not know that suffering is a good of fate that is granted to few people in so full a measure that they become wholly able to look away from their own weal and woe and live and think only for others and feel satisfaction in it. He did not know that only in pain's elect does all self-love die."

The relation between the tragic on the one side and the harmonious-human stage of life that humor represents on the other cannot be better expressed. The suffering that becomes tragic is not arbitrarily produced or sought out. It comes when fate knocks at the gate, without this knocking (as in Beethoven) being the introduction to a symphony.

30. For Kierkegaard humor was a stage that has the religious stage above it. And all true religiousness was for him of a tragic character. In the person who is to be in a state

of religion, the representation of God must, in Kierkegaard's view, work transformingly on his whole conduct of life. No human relation can have value in itself; it has value only when it is consciously subordinated and transformed from the viewpoint of eternity and infinity that the representation of God leads one to adopt. From the contrast between the *[105]* infinite demand and human finitude springs a suffering that cannot be harmonized. In Christianity — mind you, original Christianity, primitive Christianity — the whole of life is led with a view to the beyond, or rather to the one place in time and space where the divine has appeared. There is, according to primitive Christianity, only one value, the one that was put into the world with the God-man. Everything else is forsaken by value or hostile to value. Primitive Christianity is a funeral march. For the true Christian life is suffering, a suffering called forth not only, as in all religiousness, by the absolute demand of the representation of God, but by there being value at only a single point in existence, while everything else lies in darkness.

I shall not go more closely here into whether Kierkegaard is right in this characterization of primitive Christianity. I shall only repeat what I have said in several places (in my book on Kierkegaard and in my Philosophy of Religion), that primitive Christianity was not a funeral march but a victory march, since the mind was wholly filled with the expectation of Christ's near return, the real founding of "the kingdom of heaven." Since, in contrast to this great, living expectation, everything else had to pale, all other interests and tasks vanish, suffering cannot, as Kierkegaard thought, have been ruling. Before the great images in which the expectation found expression, not even the pain of tearing oneself loose from earthly and human relations could assert itself. —

The tragedy that Christianity was, according to Kierkegaard, far surpassed for him everything that even the greatest tragedian could write. "O my friend," he says ("Sygdommen til Døden." Skrifter XI, p. 236 f.), "what have you really attempted in life? Strain your brain, tear aside every covering and bare the entrails of feeling in your breast, raze every fortification that separates you from the one you read about — and then read Shakespeare, and you will shudder at the collisions. But the properly religious collisions even Shakespeare seems to have shrunk back from. Perhaps too they can be expressed only in the language of the gods." —

When Kierkegaard calls the religious stage, as he conceives it, tragic, it is a tragedy that in his view it is man's duty to enter into. It is willed tragedy. It does not come over *[106]*

man, but man is to come to it. It is not owed to collisions that fall only to the lot of some, not of all. But it is the highest form of human spiritual life.

In the two pseudonyms Frater Taciturnus (Stadier paa Livets Vej) and Johannes Climacus (Uvidenskabelig Efterskrift) Kierkegaard presented representatives of what he understood by humor. They both stand hat in hand before the religious stage. This is consistent from Kierkegaard's own standpoint, according to which suffering in the end became the decisive measure of the height of spiritual life.[71] But it does not agree with the concept of humor as it has been developed in what precedes. According to this, a tragic relation is a fate that can bring about a serious trial, but not something it is everyone's duty to experience.

For humor all value is not contained at any single place in time and space. There is a constant possibility of discovering and experiencing new values in the world, at the same time as there is a clear consciousness that if the proposition of the persistence of value holds, it is at any rate not the empirical values that persist. If there are eternal values, they make themselves known through the laws for the arising and passing away of empirical values, could we find these laws. Eternity and time are for the humorist not absolute opposites, so that there would necessarily have to be a painful relation of tension between them. Eternity is not something awaited or lying far out in time. It is an ever present, it designates the great lawfulness that makes all development in time intelligible. We constantly presuppose it, whether we look back or go forward. Kierkegaard's proposition that we understand backward but live forward is not entirely right. For that great lawfulness is of significance for our striving forward no less than for our looking back; through the memory of the past what we can do in the present to prepare the future is determined. Humor does not see reality as a falling away from eternity, but sees precisely every reality as a single stretch of an eternal stream. Kierkegaard's humorists
[107] see, in romantic fashion, the world of memory as a world of dreams, over which one can forget the ever onflowing existence in time. But there is an intimate bond and a constant interaction between memory and life. The world of memory is constantly peopled from the experiences that the life of action brings, and the life of action is animated by what is preserved in memory. In the discovery of new values memory always works along.

The possibility of tragedy is not to determine the whole of life or the view of life.

[71] Cf. *Danske Filosofer*, p. 165–67.

When humor means faithfulness to life, because it gives the paltry and the obstructive its place as well as the great and the helpful, it also leads to going to meet the tragic fate if this is really a consequence of having been faithful to reality and its tasks. Here, then, the contrast between humor and the tragic falls away, and there appears the possibility of an energetically carried through, continuous transition from the one stage to the other. There is then no leap, or, if there is a leap, continuity is not broken when the leap really carries over to the other side. A leap does not, after all, without more ado mean a fall. The free man, whose thought busies itself not with death but with life, will nevertheless go to his death so as not to deny what alone makes life worth living and thinking about.

The humorist may well be dismayed, like Prospero when, absorbed in his visions, he had forgotten Caliban and his conspiracy. (How many have not fared like Prospero in the year 1914!) But behind the great humor there always lies faith in the possibility of the release of new values. If all the sources of value in the world were exhausted, there would no longer be any possibility of the total feeling we call humor — indeed, of any total feeling whatsoever. The same would be the case if existence should prove to be so tragicomic that there were bound (potential) values enough, but no possibility of releasing them. This the humorist could not take humorously. He would then have to admit that tragedy got the last word. Indeed, if it were even tragedy, with all the inwardness and loftiness it can call forth! But if the sources of value of existence ceased to flow, a progressive weakening and dulling of human spiritual life would set in, and the last act of the drama of human life would hardly bear the stamp of the sublime.

[108]

The great humor stands and falls with the presupposition that what passes away are only single values given in experience. Their passing away is the tragic element in the experiences from which the great humor proceeds. But this element does not become sole ruler as long as new sources of value are discovered. In the very magnanimity that can reveal itself when a value passes away, a new value appears. And after that life is taken up anew. As Kent, when he is declared an outlaw, "shapes his old course in a country new," so the fight for the values of existence is taken up after a defeat and carried on perhaps in new forms. The dying Hamlet with his last breath gives his voice in the election of the king to the young, bold Fortinbras, whose energy and daring will lead him to other fates than those that fell to the lot of the melancholy dreamer.

31. Whether Kierkegaard is right in setting the sharp contrast between humor and

religion depends of course on how one defines the concept of religion. If Kierkegaard is right in his definition, the humorist takes a dismissive attitude toward religion and refuses to acknowledge it as a higher stage of life. But it must always be acknowledged as a great merit of Kierkegaard that he so definitely and positively acknowledges and grounds the existence of an independent, high and noble human spiritual life outside (in his view prior to) the domain of positive religion. This acknowledgment was closely bound up with his life's cause, that of letting the Christian appear in its strict purity. One cannot exactly say that this side of his thought has been the object of much understanding since his death, either in the Church or outside the Church. In particular the level in this respect seems to have sunk within the Church, whose preachers have an increasing inclination to think that everything the words spirit and soul can mean comes under them. It was nevertheless their natural duty and task to draw attention to the independent and high spiritual life that has been lived and can be lived outside the Church, so as to avoid confusing and mixing up Christianity and humanity. But it is naturally easier to preach
[109] against "reason" and the evil will than to enter into stages of life that are built up on a wholly different basis from their own. And yet many will have had the experience that the more they have freed themselves from dogmatic presuppositions, and also from the antipathetic and polemical moods that the work of liberation easily breeds, the more they are convinced that there is an independent human spiritual life that has developed historically under influence from many sides, from religion and from science, but first and foremost from and in life itself, a human life that in turn can appear in very different types. One of these types is the special subject of this treatise.

As for the humorist, it will hardly matter much to him whether one wants to call him religious or not. He will perhaps take a humorous attitude toward the various attempts to say what religion "really" is. Yet he will (so I must of course think) have no reason for humor toward my attempt in the philosophy of religion, since the definition I have proposed is expressly set up partly as a hypothesis in the history of religion, partly as a psychological hypothesis. He will perhaps even feel a certain spiritual kinship with my conception of religion as *faith in the persistence of value*. For the great humor becomes possible only through a holding fast to the fact that value in existence does not vanish because single values given in experience vanish.

It is a fact of the history of religion that people's faith is determined by what they

have learned in their lives to ascribe value to. The gods stand as the powers that maintain these values, and heaven is the sum of the values one knows. One can of course in one's investigations of the historically given religions keep to the outward forms of cult and the dogmas without asking what psychological presuppositions they rest on. One can be a very learned man without being a psychologist. But it is at any rate worth an attempt whether one might not be able to penetrate to the psychological basis. It goes without saying that the further back we go to primitive forms of religion, the less information one will be able to get about the way in which the organized forms of cult came to be. Even so elementary a religion as the Central Australian is known only as a finished whole. And yet it must have had its history of development like everything else in the world, and every attempt to give an account of it leads back from sociology to psychology.[72] In *[110]* the religions we call the higher, the psychological basis comes plainly forward, since the divine beings in whom one believes are conceived as champions of truth and goodness. If there lies a fear at the ground of religion (a proposition that cannot be set up as general), it is a fear of losing what — at the given stage — gives life worth. The proposition of the persistence of value lies at the ground of all religion in a way similar to that in which, for example, the causal principle lies at the ground of practical common sense when it seeks means to attain its wishes, or when at striking events it involuntarily looks about for what may have gone before. And just as little as practical common sense needs to know the abstract causal principle or what lies in it, just as little does religious consciousness need to know the abstract proposition of the persistence of value, its consequences and the problems it poses.

Whether the need to hold fast the faith in the persistence of value will maintain itself when it is not supported by being clothed in the forms of cultic life and dogma, only experience can decide. It is a psychological task to investigate the conditions for the persistence of such a need, just as it is, for example, a psychological task to investigate the conditions for the arising and persistence of the great humor.

It is the relation of tension between value and reality that conditions the most far-reaching human experiences and thereby in turn determines the persistence of total feelings. Insofar as the humorist takes an interest in the spiritual life of the past, he will

[72] See my paper *Sociologi og Religionsfilosofi.* (Critique of Durkheim's book "Les formes elementaires de la vie religieuse") in the periodical "Vor Tid." 1914–15.

be able to use the proposition of the persistence of value as a working hypothesis. With every dogma and every cult he will ask what values one has here felt, or feels, the need to maintain or see maintained. In the worship of Kurotrofos, Demeter, Isis and the Madonna he thus traces the need to maintain mother love as divine. In the series of different
[111] representations the Greeks formed of Zeus at different times he will trace an increasing tendency to regard justice as the highest quality. But not only for the understanding of the past, also in action in the present, that working hypothesis is needed. In all striving for an end it must be presupposed that existence contains the possibility of the release of values. Otherwise the hope that must bear all action falls away. In a world forsaken by all possibilities of value, action is impossible.

This consideration forms a natural transition to investigating the relation of the great humor to understanding and to action.

VI. Understanding and Humor

32. The background humor presupposes is conditioned in good part by the understanding *[112]* a person has of himself, of the conditions of his life and of the existence to whose laws he is subject. The understanding in question here can appear in a great many degrees and forms. But if it is to acquire significance, it must satisfy two demands.

It must be so comprehensive and so coherent that the person can have the representation of a great order of things in relation to which the disappointments, contradictions and sufferings that life brings can stand as something that nevertheless also belongs to existence and has its right to be, while at the same time it is unable to break the trust in the great connection within which the values of life unfold. The resistance one meets perhaps surprises for the moment, but is nevertheless fitted in as a member of the series of experiences and helps to determine the timbre of the total feeling. Luther, according to the legend, was disturbed by the devil during his work on the translation of the Bible; but when he had discovered whom he had before him, he only said: "Stay there as long as you like!" The devil had, after all, his place in his order of the world and could be taken humorously. Every view of life has its devil — rebel, tempter, accuser — whom it is a matter of putting in the place that belongs to him. There always remain scattered elements from the chaos out of which the development of character proceeds, and in the course of life new, unorganized and unfused elements can be added that can put both total feeling and understanding to the test. (Cf. § 26.)

The second demand the understanding must fulfill is that it must be able to assert itself in an immediate way and with gathered force. It must appear as a practical intuition, *[113]* as a certainty that is the fruit of the person's experience and reflection. There need be no express consciousness of the sources from which this intuition stems. If attempts are made to give reasons for the intuition, it will as a rule turn out that these reasons

were found or constructed afterwards and have nothing to do with the causes a purely objective investigation discovers. But however this may be, the understanding, if it is to be the background of humor, must have the character of concentration, must stand as a firm coast against which experiences break without being able to break it.

Contributions to the understanding in question here can be made from very different sides. It may be owed now more to the head, now more to the heart. It may be science that for the most part forms the intellectual background, or it may be a religious circle of representations, speculations or poetic visions and images, or perhaps merely the involuntary survey of things of sound common sense. The decisive thing is that a firm connection of thought has formed in one way or another. Spinoza rightly says that feelings firmly tied to a coherent train of thought (affectus secundum ordinem ad intellectum ordinati et concatenati) are harder to dissolve than vague and incoherent feelings. Yet it is of significance that the work of reaching a firm connection of thought can always be taken up anew. If the devil cannot be understood within the connection we have so far found, his unexpected appearance can perhaps give occasion to see that we have worked with too narrow a horizon.

The intellectual background is only a single condition of humor. This is seen from the fact that even where this background is the same in several different individuals, it is not said that the great humor develops in all of them. In the treatise's last two chapters I shall go more closely into this question. Here I shall only remark that there will nevertheless be a certain kinship between the intellectual background and the basis (superiority, loftiness of mind, wistfulness, longing, sympathy; see ch. IV) that the great humor presupposes.
[114] Both this basis and that background lead, each in its own way, the mind beyond the narrow horizon within which life so often moves. (Cf. § 13 c and § 23).

33. However different the worlds of thought that form the intellectual background of the great humor may be, they must all be closely connected with the way in which, at a given time and in a given place, one distinguishes between imagination and reality. The measure by which this distinction is made, that is, the criterion of reality, is always the starting point for the development of the world of thought. And at every standpoint this criterion consists in the firm connection one thinks one can find among the observations at one's disposal — in the possibility of a total connection into which the single experiences can be fitted. It never consists in anything altogether single and unique; even if a single

event or a single observation should have made such an impression, awakened such a feeling, that everything else loses its significance in relation to it, there will still always be an endeavor to find a relation between that single experience and all the others. These will be interpreted by it when it cannot be interpreted by them. The mystics of the Church interpreted their ecstatic experiences by their relation to the connection maintained by the Church's dogmatics;[73] where ecstatic states occur in psychologically experienced people in modern times, on the other hand, a definite contrast will be maintained between what is experienced in such states and the dogmatic representations in which current religious life rests.[74] The relation between experience and interpretation is altogether different at the different stages of development, as Auguste Comte showed in his doctrine of the different stages in the development of knowledge. Scientific interpretation consists in letting one experience illuminate the other, until they all at last prove to stand in a great inner connection, so that one can perhaps even derive the following experiences from the preceding ones.

Already the task set to every person, that of finding his bearings in the world, of *[115]* distinguishing between what is observation, what is memory and what is fantasy, will lead him to see himself as a member of a great connection. What he calls reality then becomes the whole that he consciously or unconsciously forms from the observations and memories at his disposal. That a reality exists for him he shows through the actions he performs; they presuppose, after all, that he thinks himself standing before something other and more than his own representations and fantasies. Here the old simple mark holds: Show me thy faith by thy works! — How large the whole is that makes up reality for the single person, and how firmly it is joined, can be very different. That is why the human pictures of reality are so different. But the law by which they are formed is always the same, from the animistic conception of nature of savages to the law-bound cosmos of modern science. In the endeavor to work together as many observations and memories as closely as possible, the great concept of truth makes itself known, which under different forms and in countless degrees lies at the ground at all stages of human spiritual life.

The humorist is a realist. His elevation above the single has the great connection of

[73] Cf. my *Religionsfilosofi* § 62.

[74] *Th. Flournoy: Une mystique moderne.* (Archives de Psychologie XV. Genève 1915), p. 99 ff.; 122 f.; 134 f.

reality as its background. On this it rests that humor (especially Shakespeare's humor) can be called faithfulness to reality. Faithfulness rests on the presupposition that the one or the thing I am faithful to remains one with itself under all changes, develops in continuity with itself. No single observation is enough here. There must be formed, involuntarily or with full consciousness, a representation, a conception, that can correspond to all the different observations in which the object of faithfulness comes forward, such a representation as I have called in my Psychology a typical individual representation. Faithfulness presupposes that this representation will continue to hold, that the law by which the object has so far developed will be the expression of its development further on. And faithfulness itself then consists in a continuity in our own conduct corresponding to the continuity in the object's being. It is neither for the object nor for faithfulness itself
[116] unchangeableness that is presupposed; the presupposition is only that the changes take place in the same direction and according to the same law.[75]

Faithfulness to reality will then show itself in our trusting the laws that have so far proved to hold for our experiences, and being willing to take them as they are, with the goods and evils, the tasks and labors, the means and hindrances they bring with them.

One might object to the close relation maintained here between humor and what stands as reality that Falstaff must surely be called a humorist, but that he lives, after all, on a great lie. To this I would answer that Falstaff's comic effect on us rests precisely on his appearing, within the reality he constructs for himself, a reality in which everything takes on the opposite meaning from what it has in the "real" world — on his appearing within this world with faithfulness and consistency. He explains his fatness by sorrow and adversity blowing a man up; he reduces the concept of honor ad absurdum because honor cannot set an arm or a leg on again; and like the old toper he is, he defends his drinking by saying that young people must live too! With full earnest the whole system from which he passes his judgments is built up. The world order he constructs lets precisely individuals like him stand as justified. His humor is faithfulness to the picture of reality he has formed and which he holds fast undauntedly against his friends' criticism and the intervention of outer circumstances.

When Falstaff not only appears himself as a humorist but is also taken humorously by us, it is because his picture gets its place and its significance through the effect of contrast

[75] Cf. *Psykologi.* V B, 9; VI C, 6. — *Personlighetsprincipen i Filosofin,* p. 18–27.

within the whole picture of the earnest time and its struggles that Shakespeare unrolls in "Henry IV." He must be seen in this whole connection to be able to put us in a humorous mood. Sidney Lee thinks that when Falstaff works humorously, it is because the contrast between his old age and his wanton way of life brings in the melancholy element that cannot be dispensed with in humor. (Life of Shakespeare p. 245.) But such a moral consideration would quite surely make the humorous effect impossible, as would happen *[117]* with Mephistopheles in Goethe's "Faust." One must take God's standpoint in the Prologue and say that there must, after all, be such fellows too.[76] It is by virtue of this principle that Falstaff makes his humorous effect. That is why it jars and cuts when Prince Henry, as soon as he has become king, casts off his old crony with harsh words. As Bradley aptly says in his essay "The Rejection of Falstaff" (Oxford Lectures p. 259): "Shakespeare had here created so wonderful a being and set him so firmly on his intellectual throne that the attempt to dethrone him again could not succeed." Shakespeare was not faithful here to the picture of real life he had created, to the reality that offered not only characters like the care-ridden king, the impetuous Hotspur and the heroic Prince Henry, but also had a place for old Jack, his wit and his merits.

34. Our picture of the world can and must be changed in many respects with advancing experience, and even if we trust that the changes follow the law we have so far traced, the concept of reality is nevertheless an ideal concept, and the concept of truth — as the greatest possible connection among the greatest possible number of observations — contains a summons to ever continued research.[77] An absolutely firm background is a possible assumption only as long as uncritical security and dogmatic confidence rule. The *[118]* world of experience cannot be concluded in time and space; the causal series cannot be carried through completely; events often appear that come so suddenly and surprisingly, and are so different from earlier experiences, that it becomes a great task to find the

[76]Just as God regards Mephistopheles humorously, so too the reverse. Mephistopheles' humor toward God ("Von Zeit zu Zeit seh' ich den Alten gern") is conditioned by his seeing God as an element in his own, Mephistophelian world order; from this he could on his side have said of God: "Es muss auch solche Käuze geben!" — Such mutual humor can also occur on a smaller scale. An old schoolfellow of mine, who had become an ardent politician, once said to me, when we had been talking about my scientific interests, that, to be honest, he looked humorously on everything of that kind and valued it only by its significance in the political market. With the bonhomie he always kept, he added that he could well understand if I, from my standpoint, also took his political striving humorously. I believe, however, that neither of these quite came off.

[77]Cf. *Psykologi* V D. — *Den menneskelige Tanke*, p. 257–262; 289 f.

connection anew. But the great humor presupposes, after all, not only an understanding of single experiences each by itself, but also the possibility of all experiences being able to enter as elements into a picture of the whole. And thereby an infinite task is set. And when can it be completely solved? Moreover, the single and individual is itself a little world whose inner connection must be unraveled. And if it stands as a torso or as a monstrosity, one must find what caused the destruction or checked the growth.

There can further, when the concept of value is applied, appear a glaring contrast between the general order of things, which calmly fulfills itself, and the fate of individual beings, a contrast that can work now tragicomically, now comitragically. Even before the modern doctrine of evolution with its idea of the struggle for existence appeared, Tennyson wrote his famous lines on nature (In Memoriam 56):

> So careful of the type she seems,
> So careless of single life.

Here it is aptly expressed how difficult it is to apply concepts of value to a unified picture of existence.

First, the series of values cannot be concluded. This already follows from the constant possibility of shifting: what at first has value as a mere means can acquire independent value as an end, and what at first stood as an end, perhaps as a last end that bounded the horizon of wishes, can acquire significance as a means to still more remote ends. Where then could we find an absolute fundamental value on which a concluding valuation could be built? And is it given that, even if we found a last measure, all single values would be commensurable with it?

Second, value and reality do not, after all, coincide. The concept of value springs up
[119] within the psychical world, but this seems to be only a vanishingly small part of existence in relation to the material world with its enormous unfolding of masses and forces. The world of values then stands, it seems, in a lonely place in existence, like the broom bush in Leopardi's poem (La Ginestra) that grows on a single spot in the desert of lava. In his bitter mood the poet holds this picture up before all those "who have grown used to praising life": "let them come here and see whether the weal and woe of living beings really lies near nature's heart!"

All these difficulties do not, however, necessarily make the intellectual background of the great humor vanish. The consequence is only what properly lies in the nature

of the case, that no intellectual background for human life of feeling can be set up once and for all. A drama need not, if one does not maintain the demand for "unity of place," be played before the same backdrop through all the acts; the backdrop can change according to the course of the action. As long as there is a connection among the changing scenes, unity is maintained. A fixing of the intellectual presuppositions once and for all would even make the great humor impossible. For the great humor turns not only against the single experiences and lets them fade before the background. It turns also against the background itself as subject to the law of change. Every background that would lay claim to absolute validity would call forth the humorist's smile. Modern epistemology too assumes nothing absolutely first or last, either as regards the forms of thought or its principles or its results. We seek to build trains of thought that we can carry through over against all present and coming observations. Where the applicability of such trains of thought proves to have a limit, we investigate whether the limit might not be a consequence of the train of thought we had begun being itself only a member of a more comprehensive train of thought. Light vanishes in the evening and comes again in the morning; but this vanishing and arising means no leap in nature; we need only pass from the train of thought formed only by observations from the earth's standpoint over to the train of thought that can be built up when one proceeds from the earth's rotation and its position relative to the sun. Galileo already said: "Think the earth away, *[120]* and there is no sunrise and no sunset, no horizon, no meridian, no day and no night!" What seems to be a limit for thought is thus only a sign that thought has ended its work too early. — This holds for the series of concepts of value just as well as for the series of grounds and causes.[78]

Understanding is a spiritual work that must always be taken up anew. The great humor would build on sand if it overlooked this. The relation between understanding and humor falls in a way under the relation between action and humor, which we investigate in the next chapter. The humorist must take the claim to have reached an absolute background as the expression of thought having grown tired and confusing its resting place with an absolute conclusion. He knows that with advancing experience two things can happen: the results we have won so far can fall away — or the problems that have

[78]Cf. *Den nyere Filosofis Historie* I, p. 176. — *Den menneskelige Tanke.* p. 196. (Critique of Renouvier's and Dühring's setting up of "the law of determinate number").

so far stood can fall away. Two of our older Danish thinkers each seized one of these possibilities here. Holberg thought that when we found no more problems in the world, it was because our experience was limited; with widened experience one would see how illusory many of our solutions were. J. S. Sneedorff thought, on the contrary, that with widened experience many of our present problems would fall away, because they are owed only to our narrow horizon.[79] They are both right, and the great humor can use both views. It jests both with the absolute solutions and with the absolute riddles. And this jest is grounded precisely in the great earnest with which the great humor embraces the work of thought. Innermost it rests on a faith in truth as that which demands ever new work to widen experience and to think through the experience won.

Just as the contrast between earnest and jest, sorrow and joy, tragic and comic, greatness and paltriness, reason and absurdity is dissolved in humor as a total feeling,
[121] so it is too with the contrast between understanding and ignorance. The humorist's standpoint is aptly stated in the expression docta ignorantia, as this was set up in the early Renaissance by Nicolaus Cusanus.[80] The humorist's stage is conditioned intellectually by the relation of contrast between the rich fullness of existence and the full understanding available at any given time. Neither of these opposed terms can fall away without the whole stage being changed. If one throws out the rational shaping because it cannot hold everything, one ends in mysticism, which in turn quickly falls back into dogmatics.[81]

35. In a similar way the humorist stands before the fact that people, even the most acutely thinking people, differ so greatly from one another in their view of the world. History shows that different sciences have at different times laid claim to being the only or the highest science. Thus for Hobbes physics was all in all, for Moleschott chemistry, for Hegel logic, for Bergson vitalistic biology, while for Leibniz and Lotze a concluding view of the world could be reached only through the application of psychological analogies to existence as a whole. The very conflicts that arise among the different attempts to interpret existence from one of its single sides the humorist takes up into his view of the world as a testimony to how we human beings are placed, once and for all, before

[79] *Danske Filosofer*, p. 5 and 18.

[80] *Den nyere Filosofis Historie* I, p. 81.

[81] When Nicolaus Cusanus had written his remarkable book *De docta ignorantia* (1440), an interesting discussion arose as to whether one needed to keep up the insight into the conditions of knowledge once one had seen that knowledge was limited. Some thought that the consequence must be pure mysticism. (*Autour de la docte ignorance.* Par *Vansteenberghe.* Münster 1915.)

existence. He can find in this, with Sibbern, an example of all development, that of thought too, proceeding sporadically. He sympathizes with every thorough and honest striving to make a general viewpoint prevail, all the while he holds fast the greatness and infinity of the task. This contrast conditions, as already said, an essential side of his total feeling.

I once tried, for my own part, to describe a form of this total feeling. Since I cannot *[122]* give a better description, and since the one I gave at the time is moreover the text I have sought to develop more fully in the present treatise, I set it down here (after "Den menneskelige Tanke" p. 377 f.).

"There is a standpoint on which, through life's mixture of tragedy and comedy, of victory and defeat, a fundamental mood has been won that has at once the character of earnest — by virtue of the great that has been experienced and the pain it has often cost — and of irony toward every attempt to express in images what in its fullness and through its contrasts bursts every form one tries to fix. The view of life or feeling of life that thus arises holds fast the conviction of a great unity in existence, as regards values as well as all other subjects and elements, and can therefore turn jestingly against the events of life, because they are powerless against that certainty, as well as against the attempts to say the unsayable. The jest nevertheless takes on the character of wistfulness, because a contradiction is constantly felt in the great being so often tied to the paltry, and in not succeeding in saying a concluding word about the core of life and the conditions of life. Behind the irony and the wistfulness there will lie a great resignation, now more practical, now more contemplative — now bitter, now cheerful." —

I have for my own part learned to regard the great humor as one of the ideal human types of life, and it is the one I most sympathize with. But there can, after all, be both an unhappy and a happy love. (Cf. § 26 and § 32). And both unhappy and happy love of something can lead to understanding.

That the great humor, as it has been described here, should in and of itself be the highest stage of life cannot, as said earlier, be maintained. The great practical striving on the one side, tragic suffering on the other, can both be higher stages of life than humor. As we shall see later (ch. IX), the joy of knowledge too can develop into a total feeling and become the central thing in the soul, and it will not be the least minds in whom this happens. Something corresponding can also happen with the artistic need. Here, then, as

with practical striving, it is a great task that takes the mind captive and draws all energy
[123] to itself. But the great tasks and the tragic fates do not fall to everyone's lot. Even one who has worked in earnest, and who has had his sorrow, can still be clear that his striving was as fluff compared with that of those who were placed in the great strife, and that his sorrow was as play compared with that of those to whose lot the deepest sufferings fell.

VII. Action and Humor

36. Only purely theoretically can a distinction be made between feeling and will. Every *[124]* feeling of pleasure or pain is connected with a need, an involuntary movement in one direction or another. When the need is joined with the ability to reach a suitable result, we call this connection of need and ability instinct. The need becomes a drive as soon as there is joined with the feeling of pleasure or pain a representation of what can preserve and increase the feeling of pleasure or avert and lessen the feeling of pain. The active side of a state of feeling is not something that comes in only after the feeling has arisen, but is tied to it from the first. The question from the first is not how need or drive can arise from feeling, but how they can be checked so that the feeling can lose its active character, at least so that it does not lead to immediate action. Only in the later development of the life of feeling does a contrast perhaps arise between resting and active feelings.

What holds of all feeling holds also of a feeling like humor. The need and drive that make themselves known in it will be able to go in two directions. There will stir a need or drive to immerse oneself in the great, to maintain it, to fight for it; but there will also stir a striving to secure even the least its place in the world, perhaps even to hold one's hand over stupidity and wickedness, if they do belong and ought to belong — by virtue of the principle felix culpa, or because evil itself is thoroughly removed only by the way of free development.

There lies, as we have also seen (§ 8, end), an ethics in germ in every total feeling, and this comes from there lying a willing (the word taken in the widest sense) behind every *[125]* total feeling, a willing that leads to valuation and action. The earnest in humor rests, like all earnest, on a value, an end, standing as guiding and determining over against the single moods and the single actions.

Many psychologists trust to such a degree the schematic survey of the qualities

("elements") of mental states that a provisional analysis can furnish that they regard the concrete, actually given and very complicated mental states only as mechanical connections of such elements. Just as, on a frequent popular conception, the elements in nature exist first, perhaps "in the beginning," and then the various compound substances arise later, so one would build up the mental world from schematically set up mental elements. One confuses real coming-to-be with the presentation in a textbook, where one begins with the elements. It cannot be denied that in the mental domain sensations, representations and feelings, in their abstract and isolated form, are the simplest we can think of. Ordinary usage has already made the analysis that leads to setting them up. A childish psychology now operates with these abstractions. But they have been torn out of the connection with need and striving in which they originally occurred. It is only a special development, a differentiation owed to definite conditions, that leads to a certain isolation of the different sides or qualities of the mental life. Just as pleasure or pain are from the first tied to need and drive, our sensations are from the first conditions for the release of reflex and instinctive actions, and our representations from the first closely tied to expectation and drive. Even scientific research begins as a striving to find means to definite ends; only later can the thoughts thereby called forth acquire immediate interest. It is not action that is a special case of sensation, representation and feeling. It is, conversely, these that, in the isolated character psychological analysis gives them, rest on a checking of the involuntary urge to action. Even after differentiation has set in, all
[126] elements of cognition and feeling keep a relation to action. They keep the stamp of being transitional members within a striving in a certain direction, or of being called forth by such a striving.

Genetic psychology, which seeks to follow the mental life in its actual unfolding, corrects in a useful way the misunderstandings that can arise from confusing the elements found by analysis of the differentiated mental life with the forms of the beginning mental life. What at a later stage we can conceive as separated and as to a certain degree independent of need and striving we have no right without more ado to read into all the stages of the mental life. A psychological antinomy asserts itself here, owed to the fact that reflection comes into play only after the mental life has long been in luxuriant unfolding; therefore it has difficulty understanding its own past and believes that the differences it can now find have been present at all stages of the mental life whose late

fruit it is itself.[82] — One could very well present the whole psychology of sensation, representation and feeling as chapters within the psychology of the will. Even logic one could find a place for there, namely in the chapter on deliberation.

37. When we now return to humor, it must be admitted that it can pass over into a purely contemplative state, an aestheticizing, in which the mind revels in thoughts and images while the personal basis (see ch. IV), especially the element of sympathy, is blurred. It can then happen that one arbitrarily tumbles the objects about and tentatively places them in different combinations so as to enjoy one's own power and one's own whim. Or one looks at reality as something distant, as through a reversed opera glass. Or one merely delights in the play of forms and colors, indifferent to the real existences that lie behind. Thus the young man in Ibsen's "Paa Vidderne" ("On the Heights") looks from the mountain waste at what goes on down in the valley; the real subjects of the picture do not concern him, although it is his own mother's house that is burning and his own *[127]* sweetheart who is riding to church as another man's bride:

> All this together I stood and saw
> from up on the heights of life;
> a higher light lay over the sight —
> but see, none can understand that now
> who sits down below in the swarm.

Something of this kind Goethe probably had in mind when he called humor heartlessness, and when he also thought that humor has no law or hold in itself and therefore easily degenerates into arbitrariness. (Letter to Zelter. 30 Oct. 1808.)[83] He is thinking of many Romantics' capricious play with everything between heaven and earth, which left no time for earnest artistic working out. And yet, he says, "the highest, indeed the only operation of nature and of art is shaping (die Gestaltung), and within form again individualization (die Spezifikation), which leads to every thing becoming and remaining something peculiar and significant." — Rather one ought surely to say that when humor

[82] See my *Psykologi* ch. IV and *Den menneskelige Tanke,* p. 10–12. — The significance of the genetic viewpoint over against the purely analytic has recently been stressed emphatically by *Edward Thorndike (Animal Intelligence.* 1911. — *Elements of Psychology* 1905). See above § 3.

[83] In *Kierkegaard's Papirer VI* p. 38 there is a piece headed: "Replik af en humoristisk Individualitet" ("Rejoinder of a humorous individuality"). What he depicts here is a blasé indifferentism that does not agree with the way in which he, at about the same time, characterized humor in "Uvidenskabelig Efterskrift."

does not lead artistically to the shaping of individual figures, it is either because the humorist is not an artist or because he is not in reality a humorist (in the sense in which Goethe himself takes the word when he speaks of Sterne). The great humor, as it has been described in what precedes, will, where there is artistic ability, lead precisely to busying oneself with interest with the single until it stands fully marked in its peculiarity, the peculiarity that precisely gives it worth and determines its place within the great whole. The great humor cannot be thought without a double interest, an interest both in the whole and in the single.

38. But does there not lie a danger at all in a total feeling like humor, in which so
[128] many different, in part mutually opposed elements are united? Will not such a union of contrasts easily lead to a leveling or evening out that weakens — to a middle way being taken, so that the fruitful energy the contrasts can release precisely in their extreme form falls away? — This remark is owed to a young friend with whom I have often discussed the subject of this treatise. I believe that the coming-to-be of every total feeling can bring a danger, in that its elements are joined so that they are no longer released each by itself. It is the timbre of the fusion or the law of the organization that now determines how one reacts to a new experience. There is, after all, in general a danger in every result attained, every concluded state, whether it bears more the stamp of feeling or of cognition. Instead of being regarded as a standpoint for new orientation and new work, such a state easily becomes a conclusion of life and activity. But in and of itself it does not lie in the concept of total feeling that it must be a definitive conclusion. It can very well mean only a station on the way, a practical reckoning that is necessary to be able to continue life so that the experiences of the past can benefit the future. But there is in addition a circumstance of general psychological interest that is of significance in this connection.

A total feeling has essentially the character of a disposition, not of an emotion. It is owed, after all, to a gathering together of a series of experiences that each by itself have called forth more or less deep-going emotions and have thereby left lasting traces in the mind. And it marks a firm direction that the life of feeling has now taken, even if oscillations or ripples can arise. And when movement in this direction is furthered or checked, emotions can constantly be released that are then often of a wholly different nature from the disposition (cf. § 2 and § 7). Love for a cause one has made one's own can give rise to combativeness where it must be defended. And the fact that this special

emotion has been released in the service of the cause can then in turn react on the total feeling toward the cause itself, change its timbre or bring a new element into the whole organization. Instead of the quiet occupation with the object of feeling there can now *[129]* appear a mood of armed watchfulness toward what may threaten. But it may also be that when the situation that called forth the emotion has ceased, the mind sinks to rest in its old bed.

In our conception of people there is a distinction to be made between the character as a whole and the particular way in which it shows itself in a definite situation. An older aesthetician (Hurd, quoted in Lessing's "Hamburgische Dramaturgie" No. 73) already remarked that even Shakespeare's most strongly drawn characters do not express their essential or ruling qualities in every utterance or action, but only when the situation gives a natural occasion for it. Yet I would rather turn the proposition round and say that when the situation gives occasion for it, actions or utterances can come forth that cannot directly be said to lie in the ruling qualities, although they are not incompatible with them. This bears witness to Shakespeare's deep understanding of human nature. Every character is like an orchestra that is interrupted by the solos only in single episodes. The disposition is an orchestra, the emotion a solo. One does the dramatic poets wrong if one overlooks this difference. Aristotle already (Poetics, ch. 15) commits such a wrong when he finds an inconsistency in Euripides' Iphigenia in her appearing as another person when she begs her father for her life than when she later goes willingly to her death. The explanation is, however, quite simple. It has, after all, dawned on her in the meantime that her sacrificial death is necessary for the sake of the Greek army, and that her refusal would expose the chivalrous Achilles to destruction.[84] A similar misunderstanding criticism I have also heard against Euripides' Medea, because she lamented in private, but appears with royal dignity before the women of the city. Most people do, after all, give way more to their emotions in private than when they appear before other people. This difference need not have anything to do with character at all, and it contains no contradiction. A similar criticism is directed against Sophocles' Antigone, who defies the king's prohibition against burying her brother and thereby shows strength and courage, but later, when *[130]* she is to suffer death, laments her early death. There is, however, no contradiction in her now, after having done what she regarded as her duty and thereby shown a bold

[84]See *Gertz'* translation of *Ifigeneia i Avlis*. The note to v. 1368.

defiance, appearing as the young Greek girl she in reality is. There is no contradiction in the orchestra sounding again after the solo motivated by a definite situation has ended.

Only experience shows that in the more harmonious times of the disposition it is not always easy to understand what one performed involuntarily in a sudden emotion, when need and ability were awakened at once. The moments of action present the greatest concentration the mental life commands; here is the most intimate gathering of all the powers of the mind in one single direction. In the moment of decision the concentration can rise to ecstasy. No wonder, then, that one later does not understand the zeal, the enthusiasm, or the hotness, or the strength one showed in such moments. One can in memory grow dizzy at what did not cause dizziness during the experience or the performance. In the moment of action emotions were to the fore that stood in contrast to the otherwise ruling disposition and for a while laid claim to all energy.

An eager mountaineer told Ludvig Feilberg (Samlede Skrifter p. 736) of a dangerous descent from a high, icy slope. "When I afterwards," he added, "thought back on the time when, pushing myself carefully downward on my backside, I tried to get near enough to the edge of the abyss to be able to look down, a feeling of terror came over me. It was really remarkable, for in the moment itself there was no question of any terror… One had other things to do." — The anthropologist G. H. Schneider reports a similar trait from his own experience. On a botanical excursion in Crete he was attacked by some armed shepherds and could save himself only by a breakneck flight down a steep slope. "From block to block I sprang, or rather plunged, often in dangerous leaps, in mortal terror down the mountain, and so reached the nearest village… Later I could only be astonished at my unerring sureness in the most dangerous different leaps from
[131] stone to stone, following quickly on one another, and yet there could be no question of deliberation." (G. H. Schneider: Der thierische Wille, p. 203.) — A delightful and at the same time touching example occurs in Goldschmidt's "Min Onkels Tømmerplads" ("My Uncle's Timber Yard"). The old merchant was in suspense and fear for one of his ships, whose good captain he was especially fond of. Suddenly the shop door opens and the captain walks in. "Uncle looked up — the next moment he had vaulted over the counter and was round the neck of the newcomer." When the emotion had subsided, the old man was seen measuring with a thoughtful look the height and breadth of the counter he had so unawares vaulted over.

One cannot, then, infer from the apparent calm of the total feeling the absence of energy in momentary situations. When the strength of a feeling is spoken of, one must remember that it can express itself in two ways, in the form of inwardness in the disposition and in the form of vehemence in the emotion, and that these two ways can stand in interaction with each other.

If from the world of memory it can be hard to understand the energy with which one acted in the past, it is often still harder, from the present state, to think oneself into the state a future action demands. Here the distance between the greatness of the task and what one believes oneself able to accomplish can stand as so great that it cannot be evened out; every possibility of approximately solving it pales. Amiel's journals (Journal intime) have here their constant, again and again varied theme. "The ideal," he says (I, p. 22; 102), "poisons every imperfect possession for me… For me it is all or nothing. Irony, on account of a comparison with the glimpsed or dreamed ideal, takes neither itself nor reality seriously." It was Amiel's misfortune that he could not become a humorist, could not come to see the small — also the small he himself could accomplish — not only in its contrast to the great but also in its connection with it. Hence his want of will, his distrust of himself; he could not take himself seriously; at most he could feel pity for himself.[85] Humor joins the greatness of the ideal and the paltriness of action, irony at *[132]* one's own limitation and admiration for the perfect. It maintains the positive significance of the widow's mite. It makes strenuous work possible, all the while it gives room for the thought that, when the highest measure is applied, we are nevertheless unprofitable servants. Irony can here enter the service of humor, in that in the moment of action one takes oneself seriously, although one knows very well that even the greatest work is only jest when the ideal is set high enough; — behind this jest there lies an earnest that is precisely the one that maintains the ideal measure. (Cf. § 18).

The disposition in which humor consists is present, scattered and indirect, in work when this is done without self-importance, without sentimentality, without oppressive melancholy, without garrulous dwelling. The presupposition is that even if the ideal that stood before us is not fully realized, and even if in the course of life much that is valuable vanishes, the spring of value nevertheless constantly flows in secret, and it is only a

[85] Je n'aime que le sérieux, et je ne puis prendre au sérieux mes circonstances ni moi-même… je me prends perpétuellement en pitié au nom de tout ce qui est beau et admirable. *Journal intime.* Genève 1908. I. p. 239.

matter of digging deep enough to make it bubble forth. In the very mind that confidently sets an imperfect action into the world of changes and illusions there is greater worth than in the soft dreamer's spirited reflections and fantasies. Just as the tragic hero shows his loftiness precisely in his downfall, so he who is not deterred by the imperfection in everything finite from giving what he can shows that there is loftiness in his mind.

39. In his profound work "Sygdommen til Døden" (Skrifter XI), which bears witness to penetrating psychological experience, the finest of all he produced,[86] Kierkegaard has depicted the relations of contrast we have been occupied with in this chapter. I name his expressions for the most important contrasts and the relation of humor to them.

"The despair of infinitude, which lacks finitude" arises when one will not put up
[133] with the limitation to which all realization of something great is subject. "The despair of possibility, which lacks necessity" arises when one is caught in empty wishes and hopes, or else in fear and melancholy. From these forms of despair the great humor frees. And the same holds against the two opposite forms — "finitude's lack of infinitude" and "necessity's lack of possibility." For humor points out toward wider horizons and thereby toward more possibilities than the narrow view, for which all sounds so easily seem to be closed, can discover.

However profoundly Kierkegaard depicted those contrasts in their extreme forms, he would nevertheless definitely have denied that humor could ever remedy them. In his youthful work on the concept of irony (XIII p. 379) he calls Solger's standpoint, which essentially coincides with what I call the great humor, a kind of contemplative devotion and thinks that it leads only to living in an unreal reality, and that it stresses only the negative side of the great and does not reach up to a higher reality, which in his view is reached only by adopting theological presuppositions. And in his main philosophical work ("Videnskabelig Efterskrift") (VI. p. 525) he regards humor, which in "Stadier paa Livets Vej" (VI. p. 393) he had nevertheless designated as an expression of strength of spirit, as a revoking, a withdrawing from existence, a backward perspective, a standing still, a life in the world of memory.

This does not agree well, however, with the "stage" he designates as humor lying later in the series than the ethical "stage." According to Kierkegaard a following stage is not to deny the preceding one but to show its superiority by having taken up into itself

[86] On this work see *Danske Filosofer*. p. 163.

everything true and justified in it. Humor would not be a higher stage than the ethical if it denied this. It would then itself fall under an ethical judgment, instead of precisely showing richer conditions for the ethical, as the great humor described in what precedes does. But the secret is that all the "stages" that lay between the stage of enjoyment (the "aesthetic") and the strictly religious lost more and more of their significance for Kierkegaard. "Humor" too was squeezed in and crushed to death between the gospel of enjoyment and the gospel of suffering, and Kierkegaard really took back what he had *[134]* described as a high, purely human way of taking life. He made fine contributions to the psychology of the great humor, but in the end he could not let it come into its own as a type of life grown up on the ground of experience of life.

VIII. Historical Conditions for Humor

40. The psychical process by which a total feeling comes to be cannot go on under all circumstances. Every total feeling is conditioned by social and historical circumstances, takes on a historical character, and it becomes the object of a special investigation whether the conditions for its arising are present at a certain given time. It is one of the questions in psychology where it must use the historical (sociological, comparative) method. Neither self-observation, experiment nor analysis can be decisive here. It goes with humor here as it goes with other total feelings, for example national feeling, the feeling of duty, religious feeling, the feeling for natural beauty, etc. One sometimes hears the opinion that it is harmful to science to admit that such feelings in fact exist, because a certain validity is thereby admitted for what is their object, or for the representations to which they are tied. But in the acknowledgment that a feeling exists there lies absolutely nothing as regards the validity or the worth of its object. And if it proves to be tied to definite historical conditions, it is clear that if these conditions fall away, the time of the feeling will also be over. According to the view of the religious problem I developed in my Philosophy of Religion (and later in the concluding section of "Den menneskelige Tanke"), the decisive question in the philosophy of religion is precisely whether there will always be a possibility of religious need and feeling after the objective, scientific validity of religious representations has been given up. The psychological-historical method here takes the place of the speculative or metaphysical. And this method must also be used as regards humor. *[135]*

Single feelings of joy or sorrow, of the exalted or the ludicrous, of the tragic or the comic may be possible without the peculiar complication becoming possible by which a *[136]*

total feeling like humor develops from the interplay of these feelings. This has at any rate, as we have seen (§ 10), first been observed and described in modern times, especially in the last centuries. One has, of course, no right to infer from this without more ado that it did not exist before. There is a difference between the condition for the existence of a mental state and the condition for its being observed and described. But for that very reason we have no right either to assert that what we can now observe or see described has also been possible at earlier stages of development. There are, for example, differences and distinctions that we easily make after development has reached a certain stage, but which cannot without more ado be applied to earlier stages. And something corresponding holds for total states, which rest on an interplay of manifold elements and conditions that are not always present.

Psychologists and aestheticians are fairly agreed that humor is a modern phenomenon. Cervantes and Shakespeare are often named as the first writers in whose works this total feeling is traced as the fundamental mood. Antiquity's conception of characters and fates was simpler; one kept to great and pure lines, and very composite personalities and events are not presented. The ancients certainly had a lively feeling of the law of limitation to which everything human, indeed everything in the world, is subject. By virtue of a "divine envy," which corresponds to what modern Romanticism has called "world irony," great fortune and sudden downfall are closely bound together. To that extent there was here a possibility of a total feeling into which opposed moods could enter as elements. But the Greeks seem to have stopped at the successive relation between these contrasts of light and dark, good fortune and ill fortune, without the opposed terms coming to assert themselves at once and thereby being able to enter as elements into a total feeling (cf. § 6).

Plato speaks in the dialogue "Philebus" of several mixed feelings, without the way in which they have arisen being stated more closely. Not only as feelings at a drama, but also
[137] in "the whole tragedy and comedy of life" do we experience such mixed feelings (p. 50 B). Tragedy and comedy stood for Plato (in one period of the history of his thought) in close connection. But unfortunately all that is said in the famous ending of the "Symposium" is that it is the business of the same man to write comedy and tragedy. In Plato one might perhaps presuppose the great humor when one sees how he, precisely in the "Symposium," sets the contrasts of life together and through jest and irony lets the greatest thoughts

unfold. But it did not come to full development as a total feeling, partly no doubt because of the pessimism that marked his last years, partly, and perhaps especially, because he was most taken up with developing his thoughts in their systematic form. To this last point we shall return in the next chapter.

That Plato did not lack an eye for how a total state can develop through the alternation of different feelings is seen, as discussed above (§ 2), from his description of how firmness of character ("courage") comes to be. But for the total feeling we call humor he had no eye. He did not stand in the living relation to life that his great master did. His psychology was not able to present the total state that lay behind the latter's life work, and which is precisely the greatest example of the great humor. This does not conflict with the proposition that while irony is an ancient feeling, humor is a modern feeling. For Socrates stands precisely at a breakthrough where the ancient points beyond itself, and it is precisely thereby that he can stand as the representative not merely of a single time but of all human striving in general. I return to this point too in the next chapter, but remark the following for the present.

Hegel and Kierkegaard showed that irony was the natural form for the breakthrough in antiquity when personality for the first time sets itself in contrast to the given, traditional order of things and strives to become a little world for itself. For the present it is only a matter of maintaining the right to be oneself, to think one's own thoughts, to take life in one's own way. But as long as a new comprehensive world of thought and a new social order cannot yet be developed, it is natural that the single person apparently goes along *[138]* with the traditional and tries to take the standpoint of others, although what is given in the existing thoughts and arrangements cannot in earnest express his real standpoint. He fights for a formal right; such a right is what the principle of personality expresses (see § 16); — but a real content is lacking for the present. Often, then, jest will poke its head out behind the earnest in a teasing way. What one overlooks when one regards Socrates merely as an ironist is that the jest that lies behind the apparent earnest can itself in turn be the expression of a deeper-lying earnest (see § 18). The new thoughts and arrangements that could replace the given culture could for the present express themselves only in a purely subjective way, through the personality's return to itself and through its liberation from what had been shaped so far. Everything objective begins as subjective, in the form of subjectivity. Therefore a man like Socrates is not only the

great ironist but (without knowing it) the great herald. The jest that lies behind the outward earnest is to that extent not only the jest of release (§ 13), but stands in the service of an earnest that cannot yet be shaped in a positive way. Irony becomes an expression of humor. The more the subjective basis of irony is deepened, the more it becomes humor. In a certain sense humor can be said to be more subjective than irony, because it presupposes a deeper layer in the personality than irony in itself needs to. Thus Schopenhauer declared that irony is objective, humor subjective, and he finds in this the explanation of the masterpiece of irony having appeared in antiquity, while humor is a modern feeling. ("Welt als Wille und Vorstellung." II. ch. 8). But if it is the task of the principle of personality to penetrate both the life of thought — by laying weight on all knowledge and all conviction being won by one's own work — and social life — by maintaining the freedom of the single person everywhere it does not infringe the freedom of others — then there is heralded in the great humor an objectivity of higher rank than the one irony seeks to free itself from. The new world that lay as a germ in Socrates' principle of personality needed millennia to unfold, and it is still fighting for its life.

[139] 41. Total feelings are not only more composite but also more individually nuanced than single feelings. For the single feelings that enter as elements into a total feeling can stand in the most different relations to one another within this new whole, and significant differences in the timbre of the total feeling in different individuals are thereby conditioned. Differences between individuals as regards the life of feeling rest rather on such different timbres than on any single feeling being wholly lacking in any person. Conversely, of course, the very possibility of a total feeling arising will be conditioned in high degree by the original individual peculiarities.

The different temperaments will not, as regards humor, offer equally good soil for its arising. There is, as I believe,[87] reason to distinguish eight main temperaments, which are determined partly by the speed and strength with which one is affected and reacts, partly by the predominance of the feeling of pleasure or of pain. Two of these temperaments will furnish good soil for humor, namely the dark, strong and slow (the "melancholic") and the dark, weak and slow (which has no current name), since they from the first, each in its way, let the dark sides of life come to play a prominent part. The bright temperaments, in

[87] See my *Psykologi* VII C, 1. — Cf. also *Alfr. Lehmann: Hauptgesetze des menschl. Gefühlslebens.* p. 390.

both their strong and weak, quick and slow forms, will not so easily let the great shadows appear in the picture of the landscape of life that forms involuntarily in consciousness. And the other dark temperaments, both the strong and quick (the "choleric") and the weak and quick (which is anonymous), will not easily make possible such a lingering state as humor presupposes; "quickness" means, after all, an inclination to pass over into action or into other states. — Together with temperament there work the experiences that are had and the reflection that is exercised.

Of course the dark temperaments named can make humor impossible when they do not let experiences come fully into their own. In humor, after all, earnest must be able to have jest as its form of expression, and must be able to be united with mildness and understanding of what life brings, even if it does not without more ado fit the ruling *[140]* fundamental mood. The bright sides of life must also have their effect.

Of the two opposed moods of life, optimism and pessimism, optimism nevertheless seems on the whole to be a greater hindrance to the arising of the great humor than pessimism. Optimism has an inclination to move on the surface, both as regards thought and feeling. It arranges things for itself in the easiest possible way and does not take the theoretical and practical problems as thoroughly as the great humor presupposes. But pessimism too can make humor impossible, especially by its disregard of experience.

In his characterization of George Eliot Leslie Stephen remarks, what every reader of her works will confirm, that she really appears as a humorist only in her first books (Adam Bede, The Mill on the Floss, Silas Marner). Later her increasingly melancholy mood made the bright sides of life be pushed back in her depictions. But the reason lay also, and in good part, in her having built in her earlier works on her own experiences and memories, while later she fell into a direct constructing of persons and events. — Here the interaction between temperament and experience comes out plainly. —

More important than temperament, however, is perhaps the difference mentioned earlier between the once-born and the twice-born (see § 2) — between natures that develop in a continuous way and natures whose development leads through breaks and leaps. The twice-born will experience the opposed sides of life more strongly, because their experiences are successive, not simultaneous. All else being equal, successive contrasts work more strongly than simultaneous ones that come as parts of the same experience. The twice-born have the possibility of experiencing stronger contrasts than the once-born

as a rule experience. It can even be very hard for such twice-born, whose life is split into periods between which even the bond of memory breaks, to reach fusion or organization of the highly opposed feelings that successively rule the mind. But if it nevertheless
[141] happens that the connection succeeds, the twice-born will become humorists in the highest style. In the once-born the contrasts do not so easily penetrate into the innermost mental life; their development has the character of expansion, of self-unfolding. Yet experiences can give even the character most harmonious in itself such an insight into the depths of life, into its involved being, that it gets the conditions for a total feeling like the great humor. If Shakespeare, as much may suggest, belonged to the once-born, he may have got the conditions for his humor in this way.

That humor is especially a modern feeling is connected with its marked individual character, which in turn is a consequence of its composite character, which offers the possibility of a host of different timbres. Ethical and religious feeling are also total feelings, but they have a support, a support common to all the individuals of a social group, in the norms of society and in the forms of cult, so that individual nuances do not so easily come forth, or at any rate are not so easily discovered — and if they are discovered, often stand as something to be pushed out. Religious cult has for millennia been an important basis for total feelings. Through it the single individuals are led into alternating moods of fear and hope, sorrow and joy, suffering and glory, which are determined point by point by objective, vivid images and traditions. "Good Friday was a bitter day, but fair was Easter morning." This motto fits many forms of Oriental and Greek cult as well as the greatest festival of the Christian Church. The individual life of mood here moves in prescribed rhythms. Humor, on the other hand, is a result of life that can be reached only in a way peculiar to each single individual, since it depends on the individual's relation to the experiences that fall to its lot, and perhaps fall to no one else's lot. In the ethical and religious domain too individualization comes more and more forward in modern times, with the consequence of a more complicated character of ethical and religious problems.

It is not quite right, what Jean Paul says (Vorschule der Aesthetik. § 76), that there is an earnest for all, but a humor only for a few. For earnest too is more and more individualized. And the greatest collisions take place where earnest people do not understand one another.
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[142] Humor thus presupposes a complication, a subjectivization and an individualization

of the life of feeling that belong essentially to modern times, although Socrates stands as the great pioneer of this whole development. Like all great minds he is at once a great beginner and a symptom of what was beginning, and of what was later to be developed through manifold historical and social changes. On one significant change in the intellectual domain we must still dwell a little.

42. Greek spiritual life developed under a limited horizon, as regards both the knowledge of nature and historical experience; the contrast between the great connection of existence and the limited human ideals and human fates could not assert itself in earnest. Existence stood as a closed whole that could be conceived as the home of everything need and thought could shape. The Middle Ages preserved the limited picture of the world. Greek thoughts were used, more or less forcedly, in the intellectual shaping of the dogmas. And after the living, ecstatic expectation of primitive Christian times had given way to more patient thoughts, it became the task to fit the life of feeling under the frame formed by antiquity's picture of the world and the dogmatically shaped doctrine of faith together. Within this frame love and enthusiasm, fear and jubilation could unfold securely and richly. Sometimes, from the need of the life of feeling, the foundation could be laid for a reshaping of cult and through it for the shaping of new dogmas, as happened, for example, with the worship of the Madonna. But on the whole the ecclesiastical authorities saw to it that the dogmatic limits were not overstepped, not even by the boldest flights of mysticism. A total feeling grounded on firsthand experience of life had no conditions for developing.

Here the Renaissance brought a change, partly by its discovery of natural man, partly by its widening of the picture of the world. Here came new spiritual conditions of life. Human life in its purely natural unfolding was seen against the background of an unsurveyable order of the world. This contrast led partly to a bold self-assertion as the *[143]*
basis of all personal development, partly to stressing, as a quality of character and a principle, the high mind that shows itself in life with all its interests and tasks being seen as a vanishing episode within an unsurveyable order of things. — The word magnanimity (magnanimitas or sublimitas) was a watchword in the literature of the Renaissance. The quality it designates stood as a natural unfolding of the free strength with which one was now minded to take hold of life and its tasks. In various forms this concept

appeared in the moral philosophers of the earlier Renaissance,[88] and gained especially far-reaching influence on the following period through Telesio's ethics, according to which magnanimity stands as the highest form of self-assertion.[89] In Bruno, Descartes and Spinoza there then unites with the purely psychological analysis of magnanimity the influence on the mind of the new picture of the world in its unsurveyability. What in a nature like Pascal awakened terror, mankind's vanishing place in the universe, awakened in the great thinkers of the Renaissance precisely a feeling of nobility and dignity.

It was not only the greater extension in time and space that affected the mind. The widening of the picture of the world was followed by an ever more thorough understanding of the lawfulness in existence. The picture of the world showed more and more an inner connection among everything in the world, the least as the highest, through general laws.[90] The grain of dust and the globe move according to the same laws. Nothing stands isolated and accidental. Even the most insignificant has its definite place in existence, and this by virtue of the same law that assigns the great its prominent and conspicuous place.

In the same direction as the conception of nature there soon worked also the historical understanding that developed in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. Within human life, which was an episode in the life of the world, the life of the single people, the single
[144] generation and the single individual came in turn to stand as episodes. Thereby a nearer background was formed, which had to work as a determining factor in the single person's reckoning with his experiences of life. Here too the great and the paltry stood in inner connection for the understanding eye, and from this viewpoint too the task was set of uniting sympathy with the small and the sense of and reverence for the great.

A last intellectual condition was brought about by critical philosophy (epistemology). It showed how all our science develops from the need to distinguish between imagination and reality, and that this distinction can be carried through only by the use of the laws of human thought itself. The picture of the world and the concept of reality are at any given time the work of human thought. And neither that picture nor this concept can ever be concluded as long as the spring of experience trickles and as long as there is life

[88] *Fiorentino: Il Risorgimento Filosofico nel Quatrocento.* Cap. IV. — *A. Herrlin: Renæssancens Etik.* (Printed as manuscript.)

[89] *Den nyere Filosofis Historie.* I. p. 96.

[90] *Den nyere Filosofis Historie.* Second book.

in thought. Reality is an ideal after which we must constantly strive, and which makes every attempt at absolute conclusion illusory. (Cf. "Den menneskelige Tanke." IV B). But this must become of decisive significance for the total feeling that forms as the result of experiences. The struggles and victories of thought, and the conditions and limits that prove to be set for it, are facts of great significance in this reckoning. (Cf. §§ 34–35). —

If all the intellectual presuppositions indicated here can become of significance for the formation of a total feeling like humor, it is understood that it — quite apart from its complex, subjective and individual character — could develop in its whole fullness only late and slowly, and that it must be able to appear in very different forms.

The intellectual conditions are not in themselves enough. (Cf. § 23). They will, as the following chapter will show, acquire different significance according to the different individual circumstances under which they appear.

IX. Humor and Philosophy

43. The great humor, as I have tried to describe it, is a view of life, or at any rate a mood of *[145]* life. It can draw nourishment from everything a person experiences, suffers and enjoys, does and feels. Therefore a person's philosophy, if he has one, will also exert its influence here. And there are, after all, as we have seen, intellectual conditions that can assert themselves in the arising of this mood of life. But they are only contributing conditions. And philosophy in and of itself will never be the only cause here. Philosophy can lead to settling our spiritual accounts, clarifying the presuppositions that science tacitly builds on and that life tacitly relies on. Just as little as philosophy can take the place of all other science, just as little can it take the place of life. Philosophy must wish that the other sciences unfold richly and vigorously, for thereby new tasks are constantly set in epistemological respect; there is new work to be done in throwing light, by way of analysis, on the nature and presuppositions of human knowledge. Philosophy must also wish that life be led energetically and fully, for then there are new tasks for the one who wants to investigate the basis on which people's conduct of life builds. Life and its phenomena are subjects for philosophy; only indirectly and partly can they also be effects of philosophy. Philosophy is, as Sibbern so finely and rightly maintained, only one element in the whole spiritual life, and it exerts its influence in conflict with other powers in the world of thought and in the world of life.[91] Personal experience of life and its yield *[146]* do not without more ado coincide with what philosophical thinking has found by its own path. There is still work to be done to bring harmony between the two influences. It is not only in the development of the race that the spiritual powers clash. This clash goes on within every wakeful personality, and in different ways in different individuals.

[91] *F. C. Sibbern: Om Filosofiens Begreb.* 1843. (p. 82–86: "Filosofien som Led og Moment i den hele aandelige Leven"). Cf. for my own part *Den menneskelige Tanke* (1910). p. 380 and my paper *Aandelig Kultur* (Mindre Arbejder III).

Here is a rich domain for psychological research, as yet very little cultivated. It is the relation between the work of knowledge and the in part wholly involuntary work that is done within the life of feeling and of will. The question is whether what goes on in the two fields of work rests on the same presuppositions — whether the presuppositions on which the one field rests can be derived from the presuppositions of the other — or whether there is perhaps strife between the two groups of presuppositions.

Here we shall now investigate this point by the historical path, as regards the total feeling we have been occupied with here. We shall investigate whether we find in great philosophers that their course of thought and content of thought have been able to furnish a background for humor as a total feeling. It will appear that philosophers have on the whole been most taken up with shaping the intellectual background, whereas the basis the great humor presupposes has been able to unfold most vigorously where the intellectual background became one with practical experience of life. The history of philosophy has one great humorist to show, and he is a man who belongs to life quite as much as to science. In Socrates life and thought became one as in no other philosopher, and his mood of life cannot be better named than by the word humor, in the sense in which it has been used in this treatise. Other philosophers are predominantly absorbed in the work of thought and acquire only indirect significance for the history of the great humor. Here it is seen precisely that philosophy is only one element in the whole connection of life, and that its significance within this connection is conditioned by interaction with many other elements. There is a division of labor that reaches right into the innermost regions of the life of the spirit, and that makes a perfect interplay of all the elements of the inner life so difficult and so rare. This explains why philosophy
[147] has only one great figure to set beside the great poet who has given the most moving pictures of the contrasts of life, and who has had the deepest understanding of how one must feel who lives through these contrasts and is shaken through by them. Socrates and Shakespeare are the two greatest humorists. The one concentrated his life on a single task; the other had the rich fullness of life as his basis.

This of course is not to say that philosophers on the whole have lacked a total feeling. But their total feeling takes on essentially the character of the joy of knowledge, of intellectual enthusiasm at finding points of view in thought for existence. Their total feeling is thus different from the one we are investigating in this treatise. But this

difference is so characteristic that it may serve to illuminate our subject to dwell on it more closely.

44. In my first year as a student I was present at a doctoral disputation where Sibbern maintained with great emphasis the incorrectness of Kierkegaard's conception of Socrates as an ironist. In contrast to it he laid down that Socrates was a humorist. The two things, according to Sibbern, excluded each other. And against Kierkegaard Sibbern was undoubtedly right in this. Kierkegaard himself, after all, especially in "Uvidenskabelig Efterskrift," corrected the view he had put forward in his treatise "Om Begrebet Ironi med særligt Hensyn til Sokrates." (See above § 16 and § 18). This correction is connected with the more detailed investigation, mentioned earlier, of the relation between irony and humor in "Uvidenskabelig Efterskrift." When Socrates is determined here as an ethicist with irony as his incognito, but out toward the limit of the religious, this means, according to Kierkegaard's own doctrine of the "stages," that he was a humorist, for irony lies before the ethical in the series of "stages," and the limit between the ethical and the religious is precisely the place where humor, according to Kierkegaard, has its place in the series. (Skrifter VII p. 73 and 437). Already in "Stadier paa Livets Vej" (VI p. 342) it is said that Socrates' earnest was hidden in jest. But earnest hidden in jest is humor. — In his "Papirer" (ed. by Heiberg and Kuhr, VI p. 118) Kierkegaard corrects with special emphasis the view of the dissertation, which he explains by the influence of Hegel. — He *[148]* could have added: and of theology.

But it was only against Kierkegaard's view (in the dissertation) that Sibbern was right in his assertion that irony and humor exclude each other. Irony can, as we have seen (§ 18), very well be a form of humor. And a historical investigation leads precisely to the result that this is the most apt designation of Socrates' standpoint.

Socratic irony was essentially a method, the well-known analytic method. This consists in going along with an assumption and going back from it to its presuppositions, which can then either agree or conflict with other presuppositions or assumptions held by the one who maintains that assumption. Thus Socrates goes along with apparent earnest with the assumption that the one he is talking with really understands what he claims to know. By drawing all the consequences of this assumption he then often comes to lay bare the ignorance or self-contradiction of the participant in the conversation who was at first so confident. It looks as if it were a sport Socrates was practicing here,

and undoubtedly he had satisfaction in practicing the activity of thought his method demanded. But for him it was not a matter of jest and play. The ironic treatment was to incite to new, earnest and independent work of thought, and this was what Socrates really wanted. There lay sympathy, "erotics," behind the irony. The jest was steeped in the most earnest interest in people. This shows itself especially in some statements in Plato's "Apology" and "Symposium," which according to recent investigations[92] are to be regarded as biographical of Socrates. In the "Apology" (p. 29 C) Socrates says: As long as I am able, I will not cease to strive for truth ("to philosophize"), and whoever it is I meet, I will say to him: are you not ashamed to strive to get as much money, as much reputation and honor as possible, while you do not care for insight and truth and for your soul becoming as good as possible? And Alcibiades testifies (in the "Symposium"
[149] p. 215–216) how captivated and enthralled he was in conversation with Socrates. His heart pounded, his tears streamed, and he felt the greatest dissatisfaction with himself. Socrates was the only person before whom he felt ashamed. And when Socrates opened himself to him in earnest, he had discovered through the outer, satyr-like shell a divine interior.

If these utterances have a historical basis, irony was an outer form for a great and glorious content, which was not, to be sure, expressed in definite and positive form, but at whose ground lay a high concept of truth, of human dignity and of the significance of truth for human dignity. There was an ideal background, what we can now call the principle of personality, in relation to which Socrates' whole conduct among people must be seen. His jest and his sport of thought always had earnest as their basis. It is not right, with Lipps,[93] to apply to Socrates, in connection with Aristophanes' "Clouds," the saying that he laughs best who laughs last. For at the last Socrates did not laugh, and no humorist does. Socrates regarded everything else as slight in relation to a self-examination that could bear life. It was a matter of becoming clear about one's real need and one's real ability, so that one should not get onto paths that did not agree with one's personality. Socrates is the prophet of the great striving for truth and of the great care of the self, both in inseparable union. Science and life can both with equal right appeal to him. Already in antiquity the expression was used of him that he was the first whose thinking concerned

[92] *Heinrich Maier: Sokrates.* Sein Werk und seine geschichtliche Stellung, Tübingen 1913. p. 106 ff; 137 ff.
[93] *Komik und Humor.* p. 238.

the conduct of life itself.[94] He had high thoughts of what it was to be a human being, especially to be a Greek, most especially to be an Athenian. And in relation to this he found the usual goods to be of slight worth. In his own clear thought man was to find the good that conditioned all other goods, and without which these are in reality not indubitable and secure goods.[95]

Through the Socratic connection of irony and humor one best understands Socrates' *[150]* relation to religion. He went along with the representations of popular belief and found in them an expression of his trust that his life's work was not in vain, without, for the rest, laying weight on shaping or grounding this faith more closely. He kept only to this: that "no evil can befall a good man, either in life or in death" ("Apology" p. 41). This faith sprang from his faith in the validity of ethical striving. From the reasons with which he (in Plato's "Phaedrus") rejects rationalistic reinterpretations of myths, one can probably form a representation of how he stood toward the representations of popular belief. He does not reject such reinterpretations out of reverence for the gods, but partly because, if he began on such things, so many monsters would stream in and demand reinterpretation that it would become unmanageable, partly (and this is the main thing) because he still has enough to do to find his way in himself and decide whether harmony or chaotic passion is the essential thing in his nature. Here we have jest and earnest, irony and humor at once. Before the great, earnest task of self-knowledge he jested with all theologizing. Plato's "Euthyphro," where the dependence of ethics on belief in the gods is disputed, can be taken as testimony that it was not only toward rationalistic theology that he, in trust in "the images of the gods within him" (to use Alcibiades' expression), took an ironic attitude.

Toward the belief in immortality he took, if one can believe Plato's "Apology," a particularly humorous attitude. He leaves it undecided there whether death is a sleep or whether it is a passage to another life, to be led in the company of gods. It is plainly enough the first possibility that lay nearest to him.[96] But a dogmatic decision and a great

[94] *Diogenes fra Laërte.* II, 20 (πρῶτος περὶ βίου διελέχθη).

[95] Even in *Xenophon,* who otherwise gives so sober and superficial a picture of Socrates, this thought comes forward with philosophical sureness in *Memorabilia* IV, 6 (the conversation with Euthydemus). But *Heinrich Maier* (*Sokrates.* p. 57–62) has indeed shown that the whole part of the Memorabilia to which this conversation belongs is owed to borrowing from or imitation of Platonic dialogues.

[96] Cf. *Heinrich Maier: Sokrates.* p. 435 f. — In contrast to this *Burnet (Greek Philosophy from Thales to Platon.* London 1914. p. 182) thinks that the "Apology" must be interpreted in agreement with the "Phaedo,"

[151] weight on such a decision would not agree with the great significance he ascribes to clear knowledge, nor with the central position the ethical viewpoint holds for him in relation to the religious. The double possibility he discusses is not the expression of doubt and unrest in the mind, but of an inner sureness as regards the essential task of life. Especially humorous is the statement that if there were another life, it would be glorious for him to continue his activity there and apply his method to the Homeric heroes, to see whether it should be with them as with so many of his dear countrymen, that they thought themselves wise without being so! —

It seems, then, to be fully justified when Socrates has been conceived in several places in what precedes as a representative of the great humor. His irony stood in its service.

45. The one point on which Socrates had concentrated himself radiated out, for his great disciple, into a great world of thought. Plato found in the thoughts that make things intelligible to us the true reality, and over against them the phenomena of experience and the circumstances of life stood as fleeting images. He demanded of the thinker and the statesman a strict scientific education, which was to lead, through mathematics as an intermediate link, to insight into the ultimate grounds of knowledge and thereby, in his view, also of existence.[97] And when the high stage has been reached, the mind will be purified of all lowness and pettiness. "Do you think," he says (Republic VI p. 486), "that he who has a high mind and has gained a survey of all time and all being can regard human life as something great?" — Plato does demand that the thinker, after he has reached the summit of knowledge, shall descend among men and perform an office in the service of the state. But it comes as an outer necessity. It is a matter of preventing the bad from coming to rule. Therefore the good, those who are least willing to busy themselves with affairs of state, must take the helm. There is thus no direct relation between ideal
[152] existence and life in the practical world. And although Plato, rich human being and great poet as he was, had a lively apprehension of the contrasts of life, and life stood for him as comedy and tragedy at once (see § 40), he nevertheless forgets in the world of ideas both the tragic and the comic of existence. Change and contrasts rule only in the sensuous world; but in the world of ideas unchangeableness and unity rule. Neither tragic lament nor comic laughter is needed in the world of thought. And excessive laughter or lament

whose line of thought he regards as Socratic (p. 193 f). I cannot find agreement between the "Apology" and the "Phaedo."

[97] On *Plato's* significance in the history of thought see *Den menneskelige Tanke.* p. 117–121; 123; 140.

is evil, because the mind is thereby set in so strong a movement in a single direction that its firmness and unity are weakened. Plato does not apply to comedy and tragedy, either of life or of art, what he so insistently maintains of music, that a mood can be awakened that can persist even if no reasons can be given for the thoughts or the deeds it gives rise to ("Republic" III p. 401). There is here a definite contrast between his hint at the end of the "Symposium" that it must belong to the same man to write comedy and tragedy, and his standpoint in the "Republic." In this latter work he expressly withdraws the possibility of uniting comedy and tragedy. ("Republic" III p. 295 B).[98]

A fusion or organization like the one lying in the concept of total feeling Plato regarded as impossible when the greatest contrasts of life came to obtain their full, passionate expression. Intellectual and ethical interest was in the end so strong in him that his rich human experience could not deposit its full effect in his mind, at any rate not an effect that his thought could acknowledge and express. For him, as for ancient thought in general, the unchangeable and the changeable stood, once and for all, as the two greatest, irreconcilable contrasts, between which a choice had in the end to be made. And for *[153]* Plato there was no doubt where true value lay.

His total feeling became intellectual enthusiasm, the joy of knowledge, awakened by the work of thought in reaching the eternal ideas and thereby being raised above the stream of change.

Nevertheless Plato acquires great significance for the development of the total feeling we have been occupied with, through his great thought of existence as a great order of things in relation to which the events of human life stood as vanishing. An intellectual background was thereby given that made possible a humor of another timbre than the Socratic. But Plato was so taken up with working out this background, and so enthusiastic about it, that there was no time or strength left to let the psychical connection between this background and the experiences in the world of experience come fully into its own. There was lacking, moreover, the positive relation between unchangeableness and changeableness that only modern times were to bring.

[98] *Hans Ræder (Platons philosophische Entwickelung.* Leipzig 1905 p. 208) finds no contradiction between the two dialogues on this point, since the unity of comedy and tragedy in the "Symposium" is to be set up as an ideal, while in the "Republic" this unity is conceived as in fact impossible. But it is in reality two ideals that are set against each other: against the poetic ideal of the "Symposium" the "Republic" sets the ethical ideal of a personality built on self-limitation and inner harmony, which cannot give room for the great contrast between the tragic and the comic.

When nearly all energy flows to a single side of the mental life, there is naturally all the less energy left over for the other sides. From this it is understood that those who are most taken up with working out and working through the intellectual background of life do not themselves come to stand as representatives of the great humor. We stand here at a new limit for humor as a view of life or mood of life, different from the limits that the tragic on the one side and action on the other set. The limit that intellectual work can set does not come from outside. The great humor need not presuppose a dogmatic background, concluded once and for all, that would exclude continued intellectual work. On the contrary, the great humor will, as we have seen (§§ 34–35), draw in the knowledge actually won and take it "humorously," because there will always be the possibility of new riddles and new solutions. Behind every background there appears the possibility of a still more comprehensive background. The constant re-arising of problems in new forms stands as a comic, perhaps comitragic, phenomenon, and a smile can be called
[154] forth at the busy work of knowledge. But this mood will not so easily arise in those who stand in the midst of the purgatory of problems and feel their smart. —

That Socrates is the only humorist in the grand style among the philosophers rests on the fact that in him intellectual work became one with practical-pedagogical work among people. Through irony as a method he sought to lead single persons to bethink themselves of the great background a person can find in his own interior, whether this background can be shaped in clear thoughts or not. Jest, irony, was here a way to earnest.

The other great humorist in the history of the human spirit was led by his experiences to produce a world of images within which sorrow and joy, dark and light could stand as elements in a total experience, a world of images that lets both the small and the great come into its own, without the great crushing the small and without the small dragging the great down into the low.

Both the philosophical and the poetic humorist stood, each in his way, in a living relation to life, however rich and exalted their inner world was.

46. In accordance with the historical view indicated earlier (ch. VIII), according to which we can expect the basis and background for the great humor only in modern times, we now go straight from Plato to the Renaissance. In the Middle Ages it will rather be in popular belief and popular custom that one will find humor, thus in the representation of the stupid devil. An expression of a full reckoning with the experiences of life it could

not become under the presuppositions of the Middle Ages.

Bruno and Spinoza laid the foundation, in broad strokes, of the view of the world peculiar to modern times, gave the first pictures of the whole on the basis of what the new astronomy and the new physics had brought to light.

I have already (§ 9) discussed Bruno's description and understanding of total feelings. His philosophical and his poetic gifts worked together on this point, as on so many other points in his thinking. But the total feeling he knew was not humor, but courage of life and magnanimity, the feeling that is in general characteristic of the Renaissance (see § 42). It can become a basis for humor (see § 20), but need not become so. *[155]*

What Bruno contributed to the intellectual background of modern life of feeling was two things: the widening of the physical picture of the world into the unsurveyable, and the assertion that if divine forces are to be assumed in the world, they must be sought in the interior of the elements and of souls, not in some place in space. Bruno's whole strength of spirit was taken up by the work on these great thoughts. And the courage with which he held out in the tension and toil this work caused lay at the ground of his description of the heroic mind or magnanimity. But the constant yearning of thought laid claim to all the powers of the mind, and intellectual feeling entered into no connection with an understanding sympathy toward the finite and limited in human life and in nature.

For Spinoza it was not the infinity of existence but its lawfulness that stood in the front rank. He urges as the most important means to spiritual freedom that our feelings be tied to valid thoughts in which we can wholly find rest. (Ethica V, 4 Schol). The surge of the life of feeling is to be stilled by our feeling ourselves one with the world substance, with what persists under all changes, as we see the connection of our mind with the whole of nature (De emendatione intellectus). Then the small and the changing are lost from sight, and the joy of knowledge becomes the ruling mood. Spinoza certainly did not lack interest in the single and particular, especially in the domain of the mental life. He wrote, after all, not only the first and second books of the "Ethics," which treat of the world substance and of human knowledge, but also its third and fourth books, which investigate human feelings and passions. But the two lines of thought — the one that seeks the fundamental relations of existence and of thought, and the one that explores the details of experience — do not come to unite in one and the same series of

experiences, so that they both come to determine the total feeling. The high point of life for Spinoza was the beholding (intuition) that with one glance surveyed and saw through the great connection into which everything fits. In his admiration for the infinite power
[156] and fullness of nature, which is able to produce not only what in our eyes is perfect but also what in our eyes is imperfect (Ethica I, end) — a remark he set in sharp contrast to people's superstitious fear or narrow-minded offense — in this admiration he was raised above the comedy and tragedy of life, and these contrasts did not come to determine in a positive way his disposition toward life.

It would be wrong to conclude from this that Spinoza in his personal life was untouched by the feelings whose interplay conditions the great humor. Both fellow feeling and the feeling of laughter played a part in him.

The misfortunes of others went nearer his heart, his first biographers report (Lucas, Colerus), than his own, and it was to him an ugly comfort that one could find for one's own sufferings in others suffering as we do. Only the purely passive pity that leads to blind and thoughtless intervention did he reject. According to Spinoza's "revaluation of all values," only those feelings are good in and of themselves that are the expression of an active bearing and of the use of one's own strength and reflection. Only joy, not sorrow, can therefore be good in itself. Yet in people who are not guided by clear reflection, sorrow and sorrowful moods too (pity, fear and remorse, for example) can be of value.

But he did not see the possibility that a feeling that in and of itself has no unconditional value can enter as an element into a total feeling, which thereby comes to stand as the fruit of many-sided experience of life and makes the mind well armed to meet what life may still bring.

A healthy and fresh laugh Spinoza counted among the good things in life, with a strong stress on his contrast to ascetic and pietistic thinking (Eth. IV, 45 Schol.). He made a distinction only between involuntary laughter (risus) and the laughter of scorn (irrisio). As soon as laughter gets a definite object, it becomes for Spinoza an expression of scorn and stands in contrast to the understanding that is for him the highest. It is this view that lies at the ground of his famous statement that he endeavors neither to laugh at, mourn nor be indignant at human actions, but to understand them (Tractatus
[157] politicus. I, 4). He applied this principle not only in a treatise on politics but also toward the events of his time. The confusion of the time, he writes in a letter (Ep. 30) during

a war between Holland and England, awakens neither his laughter nor his tears, but leads him to investigate and observe human nature; man is, after all, like everything else, a part of nature, whose connection with the other parts and with the whole of nature we do not know. The joy of knowledge gathered all his interest; it was his total feeling. But the great humor rests precisely on a presupposition that Spinoza did not hold, namely that understanding and the feeling of laughter do not exclude each other. Laughter can become the expression not of distance, scorn or contempt, but of a feeling of unity. Understanding itself can bring laughter or a smile with it. —

For the men of the Renaissance it was first and foremost a matter of self-assertion. It was the contrast to the Middle Ages' faith in authority and asceticism that asserted itself in them. They were wholly taken up with the work of building up a new world of thought as a frame for life. Through this work Bruno came to "the heroic affect" and Spinoza to "the intellectual love." These were their total feelings, whereas the peculiar synthesis that humor presupposes did not come about.

47. While the Renaissance laid weight on self-assertion and the forms of feeling and will that could develop from it, the English psychologists and moral philosophers of the eighteenth century — the series Shaftesbury, Hutcheson, Hume and Adam Smith — were led to stress the social and sympathetic feelings. This became of significance for the total feeling we have investigated here, since it can arise from a sympathy that brings about a psychological connection between the personality and its object and makes it possible for the object, however paltry, to be seen in its worth and significance. It does not follow from this, however, that the philosophers named were themselves humorists.

Shaftesbury was an enthusiastic worshipper of beauty. His concern was to combat fanaticism and superstition, which would set narrow limits to the free unfolding of life. In this fight he regards the comic as a good and legitimate ally. This is the fundamental *[158]* thought of his little work "Essay on the Freedom of Wit and Humour" (1709). (The word "Humour" is taken here in the older, Jonsonian sense of the word). "I for my part," he says, "do not fear sceptical wit. No cause in which I am in the least degree interested can be harmed by a tasteful wit." In this line of thought there lies a germ of the great humor, for which it is once and for all so that even the most valuable has a side from which it is subject to limitation and finitude, so that one can smile, if not laugh, at it. But for Shaftesbury it was here only a matter of a means, a device, that is not inwardly

connected with a whole mood of life.

Hutcheson's main interest is ethical, and Smith's ethical and economic. Their psychological interest was derived and subordinate. In Hume, on the other hand, one might expect to find humor. He has a clear eye for the contradictions in the world and for the disproportion between what human feeling demands and what reality shows. But the experiences he had in this respect seem not to have led to any total feeling. On the contrary, he gives up striving for a unified expression of the experiences of life. Such a striving rests, in his opinion, on an overvaluing of the significance of life. On the other hand there are — so Hume concludes his reflections (in the essay "The Sceptic") — natures for whom thinking about life is the most entertaining way of employing life!

48. English literature in the eighteenth century moved, especially as regards the novel, in a direction that offers an interesting parallel to the philosophical movement. Weight was laid on the life of feeling, on sympathy, on the good heart, and the outward events of life were followed with a mild eye and a friendly smile. We have to do here with the series of writers that Thackeray (The English Humourists of the Eighteenth Century. 1853) put together under the name of the English humorists. Thackeray's definition of humor is
[159] that it is a combination of wit and sympathy (wit and love).[99] In this special meaning it does not seem to fit all the men Thackeray discusses: Swift, Addison, Steele, Pope, Fielding. Of Swift I have earlier (§ 15) tried to show that he is a satirist, not a humorist. The one of the writers named whom the definition mentioned best fits is Sterne, although Thackeray would rather call him sentimental. Goethe, who otherwise did not care for "humorists," made an exception for Sterne (see above § 25). In his "Sentimental Journey" ("a journey to learn to know the human heart") Sterne says that his journey is owed to "the heart's need of nature, and of the feelings that spring from nature and make us love one another and the world more than before." With this the basis is given. It leads to depicting human characters and fates, now in earnest, now in jest, now with tears, now with laughter, with a sense for the small things and for life in the small circles. What Shakespeare in his giant works had been able to present, the great richness and strong

[99]Thackeray hopes that he himself too can be counted among the humorists by this definition, although in the "Times" he has been called a dull misanthrope who sees no good anywhere. — Thackeray himself, Dickens before him and George Eliot after him form a series of English humorists whose characterization in relation to the writers of the same direction in the 18th century would offer great interest. For my purpose the characterization of Carlyle (see § 51) will be more to the point.

contrasts of life, on the basis of deep experience of life and faithful love of real life, was now carried by lesser minds out into wide circles, down into the world of small things, which the master had given a place in his world only episodically. There was often a lack here of the artistic ability to let the details take shape sharply and individually. The naive, overflowing feeling often played with its subjects in a capricious way, and instead of being the deep but hidden basis, the good heart liked to push forward and speak along directly, so that heartiness became sentimentality. Add to this the smooth optimism of the time, which made the life of feeling superficial. One passed lightly over the disharmonies. The sense for the infinite and mysterious, which had been so strongly developed in Shakespeare and Milton, had vanished in the poets of this time.[100]

Nevertheless it was of significance that the spiritual and literary current arose that posterity has called humor, although it was not the great humor here. It was the sign of *[160]* a psychology more open to the manifoldness of life. And in the course of the century the sense for Shakespeare's greatness awoke again, especially through a great actor's rendering of his characters,[101] and thereby the sense for great humor could be awakened again.

49. The Renaissance had made a great intellectual background possible, and poetry had, now in the grand style, now in small dimensions, awakened the sense for the manifoldness and peculiarity of experiences. At the end of the eighteenth century there came in addition an attempt to settle the relation between the work of thought and the other sides of the mental life. From the great picture of the world and the great view of the world that the natural science and philosophy of the Renaissance had made possible, Immanuel Kant descended to the power in the human spirit to which it is owed that it can form images and intuitions at all, shape thoughts and set up ideals. He uncovered what he called "the hidden art in man's interior," the involuntary gathering activity that expresses itself in all sensing and thinking. And when it was asked whether validity could be ascribed to the results of this activity, his answer was that this validity rested on whether they were necessary for being able to distinguish between experience and imagination, between reality and dream. Thereby the ground was taken away from all speculative systems that sought beyond every possible experience. Theology and

[100] *L. Stephen: English Thought in the 18. Century.* II. p. 371.

[101] On the significance of Garrick's acting for a Shakespearean renaissance see *L. Stephens: English Literature and Society in the 18. Century.* p. 83 and elsewhere.

spiritualistic psychology became impossible as sciences. Not without inner struggle had Kant reached this result. For he had, as he himself said, the fate of being in love with metaphysics — and now he saw that it was impossible. Into this divided mood his first investigations had already brought him. It was through humor that he got beyond the dividedness. In "Träume eines Geistersehers, erläutert durch Träume der Metaphysik" (1766) a humorous mood reigns. Before the high and strict concept of truth he had now caught sight of, speculative systems stood for him in a comic light, although it had been
[161] his own inmost wish to be able to produce such a system. Later too, after the working out of his famous main work, he can look at his work with humor. In one of his notes he jests about the pedantic character that the "Kritik der reinen Vernunft" undeniably in part presents; he consoles himself that pedantry must drive out pedantry. His Socratic character, which made him prefer thorough and independent knowledge to speculation as well as to the mere heaping up of information, and set philosophizing above having a philosophy, gave him a firm background for regarding fruitless but often all the more confident attempts of thought.

In Kant's life of feeling the sublime played the greatest part — the infinity of the universe outwardly and the inner infinity appearing in conscience were, according to a famous statement of his, two things that filled his mind with ever new reverence. But as the man of firm, rational rules he fixed his life and his thought more and more in definite forms, which it was painful and at last impossible for him to think of as otherwise. The humor that could stir in him in his younger years in the intellectual domain did not come to give its stamp to his whole personality and mood of life.

50. It is within German Romanticism that the concept of the great humor is first expressly formed. As everywhere, the thing here too goes before the concept. We have pointed to two great figures as representatives of what the concept contains — the one in antiquity, the other at the entrance to modern times.

The English humorists of the eighteenth century do not, as already remarked, represent the great humor. Their horizon was too limited, and their optimism did not let the contrasts of life have their full influence. One moved on an even, bourgeois level, and since feeling had no contrast and resistance to overcome, it became sentimentality, especially in imitators. According to Jean Paul (Vorschule § 32) Sterne got a whole host of imitators in Germany who in reality were nothing but "Ausplauderer lustiger

Selbstbehaglichkait." A great idea was lacking as background. Such an idea German Romanticism commanded.

Not as if the German Romantics had themselves created this background. As I have *[162]* already remarked in "Den nyere Filosofis Historie" (in the introduction to the eighth book), they built essentially on the great German renaissance in the last part of the eighteenth century (Lessing and Kant, Herder and Hamann, Schiller and Goethe), on the widening of the spiritual horizon it had brought, and on the representation of the originality and manifoldness of spiritual life it had awakened. Of special significance besides was that one came to know different directions of spirit and thought, the life of faith and mood of many ages, and acquired a sense for and a need to enter into manifold ways of seeing and standpoints, and to look with irony on each single form of spirit when it wanted to be the only valid one. In Fr. Schlegel we have already found this trait (see § 16). With a mixture of irony and admiration one looked back on the faith of earlier times, on their art and their thinking. One had a deep conviction that what thus constantly sought new forms and burst the old ones was stirring now too in all whose senses and minds were opened. And it was not something that stirred only in human minds. What was the highest for thought and need must also be the innermost in existence, although no single part of our experience can express it completely. Only a higher beholding or a speculative thought opened access to it. Each single experience, each representation taken from a special field of observation, could acquire only symbolic significance.

The philosophy of Romanticism is an impatient idealism. One strove unrestrainedly, through a kind of magic, to penetrate to "what holds the world together in its inmost," and one had no sense for work in detail, from special starting points and by special methods. Such things stood, like the tasks and interests of plain bourgeois life, as a jest in relation to the ideal world that revealed itself in so many forms. — Romanticism worked liberatingly by pointing beyond the narrow forms in which life, art, religion and thought so easily stiffen. And it could thereby make great humor possible. But romantic humor suffered from a great imperfection. For the small circumstances of life and the small steps of thought may certainly stand as vanishing and insignificant in relation *[163]* to the ideal and infinite we can divine; but it is nevertheless through faithfulness in small things that great things are carried through. Romanticism conceived every limited striving, every one-sided direction, merely as something negative, as something that

claimed to be infinite without being so, something that set a limit to the comprehensive view. Therefore the Medusa head of irony was turned against them. There was here the possibility of an irony like the one wrongly found in Fr. Schlegel (see § 16), and like the one Kierkegaard described in his treatise on the concept of irony and later in his characterization of "the aesthetic stage." But there was also the possibility of a connection of irony and enthusiasm that leads, and led, to the great humor.

Novalis already maintained that Fr. Schlegel was really a humorist. But the theorist of romantic humor was Solger, who also struck the strings of the great humor. In him the humor of the eighteenth century, which is the combination of wit and sympathy, is united with Romanticism's idea of the single as pointing beyond itself to a great whole. In his view of life and his conception of art he unites irony and enthusiasm. Through irony the single is consumed in its isolation; through enthusiasm it is seen as a member of the whole. In his "Erwin" it is the great longing (§ 21) that forms the basis; his posthumous writings seem to show that in his last years he took a more mystical direction. He is a Romantic by his longing for a form of spiritual life in which the difference between art, religion and philosophy has vanished. Philosophy is to prepare the way for such a high point by showing, through free knowledge, the eternal and infinite as contained in the laws that hold for finite things. Art is to show, through images, the finite as shone through by the infinite. And religion is an immediate living in the eternal and infinite. At the high point none of these three forms of spiritual life holds; the difference between them falls away. The highest state is enthusiasm; but it gives rise to irony toward reality and its phenomena.

It is a personal standpoint of life that Solger has depicted here. His abstract expressions
[164] have caused Kierkegaard to depict his standpoint as purely formal and negative and to regard him merely as an imperfect forerunner of Hegel. But while for Hegel all spiritual forms of life were imperfect forms of philosophical speculations, Solger maintained that the highest form of life must be one to which philosophy, art and religion each made its contribution.

The deficiency of romantic humor, a deficiency that comes out more in Solger's forerunner Jean Paul than in Solger himself, consists in there coming no positive relation between the small and the great. Predominant weight is laid on the impossibility of a perfect presentation of the highest. The great humor reaches its full unfolding only

when the small and the limited are seen as necessary forms for the great and infinite and thereby acquire positive significance. Romantic humor could lead, and did lead, to disregard for empirical science and for practical endeavors of reform. In Carlyle we shall see this plainly. The realistic element in the great humor, which springs from its faithfulness to reality, does not come into its own in Romanticism. Neither the tragic (ch. V) nor understanding (ch. VI) nor action (ch. VII) — the three domains over against which humor is to show itself at once in its positive significance and in its necessary limitation — are acknowledged in their independence. —

The great humor did not reach its full development in German spiritual life. German humor keeps a more or less romantic-speculative character. English humor is more earthbound, but on the firm ground of reality Shakespeare's world of mighty figures in dramatic interaction grew up, a world in which the most intimate and at the same time the most plastically shaped humor appears. — It is characteristic that the French language uses the English form (humour) to express humor in the sense in which we take it here. The fusion or organization the great humor presupposes seems not to have natural conditions on French soil. It is at any rate more characteristic of the French nature to swing between very different moods that can unfold in a certain independence of one another. This explains the surprises the French often offer the world. Thus a French *[165]* philosopher maintains that no psychological miracle has taken place with his people for a thorough observer, but that one could already earlier have traced the excellent qualities it has shown in the present war.[102] — It is perhaps bold to conclude that psychical chemistry, a close connection and coherence of different psychical tendencies, should come more naturally to Anglo-Saxons and Germans than to the French. But there is at any rate here a task for closer investigation, when racial psychology has once outgrown its infancy.

51. Carlyle is the most significant personality who represents romantic humor. The basis for him was the great earnest of life, to which his heavy mind opened his sense, and which the Calvinist faith he had grown up in had impressed on his way of thinking. Later he lived himself into the world of thought of German poets and philosophers. Especially (as he himself declared in his later days) Goethe's "Wilhelm Meister" influenced him, and

[102] Nous avions pu discerner, sous une frivolité apparente, un esprit sérieux et capable d'application, sous des dehors frondeurs, la résolution de se soumettre librement à une discipline raisonnable, et sous la "blague" superficielle, le sentiment et le respect de l'ideal. *Terraillon:* Allocution prononcée à la Distribution des prix. Collège de Saint-Claude. 1915, p. 9.

here again the idea of the three kinds of reverence urged in the "Wanderjahre": reverence for the great, what is above us — for the equal, what is beside us — for the small, what stands beneath us. Reverence forms the basis of Carlyle's life of feeling and of his view of life. What he appropriated of German philosophy was especially the great contrast between the inner core of life and the outer husk. Kant's contrast between "the thing in itself" and "the phenomenon" he used, not, like Kant himself, to stake out the domain of science and settle down there, but to express that scientific research leads to nothing, since it does not lead to everything. All experience became for him a symbolism that was related to the thing as clothes to the body. His philosophy was "the philosophy of clothes," with the main weight on clothes not making the man. (Sartor Resartus. 1836). This
[166] conditions his relation to the teachings of science as well as to the dogmas of religion, and to all practical endeavors. All these things he counts among the clothes, or among the patches put on the clothes. He stands toward such endeavors with a mixture of mockery and pity. When Carlyle so often says "poor" of a person, it is partly sympathy, partly contempt that is expressed by this word. In a drastic way he depicts what in his eyes is the senselessness of working for truth and justice in the world. And yet his heart was warm. And he loved healthy, spontaneous laughter, could laugh heartily himself, and thought that the person who had once laughed from a full heart could not be altogether bad (see § 13). But his laughter went strangely alongside the often bitter jest or broke through as an effect of contrast to it. Carlyle is a humorist by his sense for the contrast between kernel and shell and by his understanding that the shells change and must change. But his idealism is, like that of Romanticism in general, of the impatient kind that demanded all or nothing, and so by this apparently courageous demand in reality shut itself up in the world of fantasy and mood. There was lacking a positive bond between the main thought and its special theoretical and practical applications, which he therefore would not acknowledge as applications either. His unruly temperament made him scorn what by virtue of his own principle he must have acknowledged as a necessary, though imperfect, expression of reality. A secret doubt expressed itself in him here.

It has rightly been stressed that it is the complicated circumstances of modern life that confuse and depress him. His thought always moved about the simple, broad facts of life. When from his solitude in the Scottish Highlands he was transported to Edinburgh and London, civilized life met him with all its manifoldness of research and striving. Like

Rousseau[103] he stood uncomprehending and rejecting before the culture of his time. But while Rousseau did learn to understand that there is a natural culture, Carlyle never got *[167]* beyond the sharp contrast that he expressed in the most violent way in single moments, under the influence of his morbid and vehement mind. And yet he had in his humor, and in the thoughts that formed its background, the conditions for getting beyond this contrast.

Romantic humor did not reach full fusion or organization — Carlyle is the greatest example of this. The contrasts that could not enter into full inner connection then asserted themselves in successive contrast. It is reported of Carlyle that when he had in his rough way torn down everything in the world, he could suddenly stop and, through a powerfully breaking-out laugh, return to more level regions. His own prophetic tirades must then have come to stand in a comic light for himself.[104]

52. According to the psychological characterization of the great humor given in what precedes, it has a decidedly realistic character and has therefore been called faithfulness to reality. When it is, as it seems, rarely found in eminent philosophers, the reason must, as said above, be sought especially in its being the intellectual interest about which everything gathers for them, and which therefore comes to determine the ruling total feeling. Often the reason may lie in an impatient idealism that leads to stressing the contrast to experience more than the connection with it. James Sully (Essay on Laughter. p. 397. 401), who has also made the observation that philosophers are rarely humorists, finds the reason in the philosopher's being removed by his studies too far from the stage *[168]* of real life. I would, however, lay the main weight on the contrast between the life of thought and the other sides of the mental life. In every man of science a greater or lesser contrast can appear here. And even if the philosopher has special occasion to investigate the relation between thought and personality, it easily becomes this very investigation

[103]It was, by Carlyle's own account, Rousseau's "Confessions" that first awakened him to deeper reflection. (According to what he told Emerson, who in turn told George Eliot. See *George Eliot's Life,* as related in her letters and journals. New edition. p. 104). This was not known to me when I wrote my characterization of Carlyle in "Den nyere Filosofis Historie" (ninth book) and in "Mindre Arbejder" III p. 125.

[104]Henry James the elder (the father of William James and of the novelist Henry James) describes a delightful scene from Carlyle's tea table. An American was disputing with Carlyle about politics. Carlyle became more and more violent in his replies, and Mrs. Carlyle therefore trod on the guest's foot to get him to stop the dangerous topic. But the American cried out loud: "Why don't you tread on your husband's toes, Mrs. Carlyle? He is surely worse than I am!" The whole company burst into hearty laughter, and Carlyle led it. (*Henry James: Some personal recollections of Carlyle.* Literary Remains. Boston 1897. p. 454).

that lays claim to all his interest and energy. The life of thought too has its fate, brings its experiences, which can become determining for the final mood toward life. Even if real life intervenes with a strong hand, it can nevertheless be the work of thought, and this work's fortune or misfortune, that becomes the decisive thing. However important the background of thought and science for life may be, its significance for a total feeling like humor is only indirect. And, as we have seen (§ 21), a thorough experience of life won by a purely practical path can have the same significance.

A distinction has been made in what precedes between background and basis. The basis, which lies especially in the life of feeling and will, is more important than the intellectual background. It proves, accordingly, that from a scholar's general way of thinking one cannot infer the character of his total feeling toward life. To draw such an inference requires knowledge of the whole concrete basis of the personality. Unfortunately this is so hard to know, and one must as a rule build here on a hypothesis proceeding from the total feeling that has actually formed, and to which the background has also made its contribution.

Perhaps great and strong total feelings can form more readily in artists than in thinkers. There is a closer relation between image and feeling than between thought and feeling. The feeling at what is experienced finds expression involuntarily in images, which present or symbolize vividly what is experienced in its whole peculiarity, while for thought the single experience easily comes to stand as one example among several. The artist thereby stands in a closer relation to life in its concrete, individual forms. That is presumably why Schiller writes in a letter to Goethe that the poet is the only true human
[169] being, while the best philosopher is only a caricature in comparison with him.[105] Yet the artist too can make life a mere object of contemplation (cf. § 37), so that the world of fantasy becomes for him the only world. Schiller himself advised a friend to stay in "the bright and quiet world of ideas" and for the present let "poor, unworthy and immature mankind" look after itself.

Where energy is used predominantly for life in thought or fantasy, energy will be lacking for the fusion or organization of the feelings the course of life can awaken. In the regions beneath the world of thought and images manifold feelings may then often tumble about chaotically. Hypochondria or levity, phlegm or irascibility, pettiness or

[105]Cf. my memorial address on Schiller in *Mindre Arbejder.* Third series. p. 179 f.

magnanimity, bitterness or sentimentality, sensuality or ideality — these and many more tendencies can form a sublunary world that one who knows only the works of thought or fantasy stemming from the ethereal world above does not suspect. It is not always the case that the life of thought or fantasy, besides being the domain where energy is first and foremost put in, can also form the background for the development of a total feeling in the grand style. Only when this happens are we at the high points of human life.

It is not, for the rest, only in thinkers and poets that this contrast can be found between a world in which they live their most energetic life and a sublunary world of a wholly different structure. In practical natures too, men of action, there can be a corresponding contrast, namely between the part of their life that is absorbed in work, public activity or business, and the sides of their mental life that are not taken up by this activity. —

One might (cf. § 38) also look at the matter from the opposite side and find it doubtful whether the life of feeling could be joined into complete totality, since thereby the one-sidedness that earnest work and energetic action demand would become impossible.

Gustav Fröding, in a little essay from the year 1890, maintained in a fine way the significance and right of humor over against the one-sided part that, in his opinion, the *[170]* striving for truth and moral yearning played in the literature of the time. He thought there was more humor in the old days than now, although so much is preached about love nowadays. "Man är så kärleksful i ord och gärning, att man alldeles glömmer att vara det i själ och sinne, hvilket ändå är det, som verker försonande människor mellan." "Humor är hundarne, som slicka såren på den lidande Lazarus, och vänligare än den kristliga kärleken aktar den icke för rof at skänka den rike mannen den vattendroppe, efter hvilkan hans tunga trådde." — But when Fröding in the year 1910 reprinted his essay (in which he had mainly depicted humor on the basis of sympathy), he had lost faith in the right of the great humor and thought he had overvalued it. In his opinion it ought not to rule alone.

Nor have I in what precedes been blind to the misgivings it can awaken, as I have brought forward the dangers of every concluding total feeling. But through the investigation of the relation of humor to understanding, to the tragic and to action, I have tried to show that from humor's own nature there follow certain limitations that need by no means come from outside.

It was a brilliant idea of Kierkegaard's to conceive the great humor as the high point

of what can be reached by a purely human path, in contrast to the religious standpoints that presuppose a relation to something lying beyond the reach of human experience and knowledge. The mere fact that there can form such a total feeling, which holds the opposed elements of life without excluding the possibility that these elements, if necessary, can be released anew in their particularity — the mere fact is already of decisive significance. Therein appears a typical example of a human view of life.

53. Finally we shall consider the relation of humor to a realistic way of thinking, by which I understand a way of thinking that finds the criterion of truth and reality in the firm, lawful connection in everything that appears as an object of observation.

Humor is, as has been said several times in what precedes, a realistic feeling, and to
[171] that extent it might seem to be wholly natural at a markedly realistic standpoint. But it appears here too that the way of thinking is only a condition, not necessarily decisive for the arising of a total feeling. The background is not enough; it depends especially on the basis. While the idealist's danger is that he easily becomes absorbed in pure ideas without coming into close relation to the concrete realities of life, the realist's danger will be that he is weighed down by the "realities" of life and does not come to make his understanding of them a mere background for his life of feeling. The background then comes to check the unfolding of the basis. If for the idealist life fades into an ethereal world, for the realist it is easily stifled in the dense fogs of "reality." Such, once and for all, is man's lot, according to Goethe's famous words (Grenzen der Menschheit): if we rise high, we can find no foothold, and if we stand firm on the earth, we do not reach high!

If realism is to become the background for a free and fresh development of the life of feeling, the realist must look critically at his own realism. The same condition holds for the idealist. Kant, who in his "Träume eines Geistersehers" had turned critically and humorously against a dogmatic idealism, prepared the way in his "Kritik der reinen Vernunft" for a critical realism.

When the realist asks himself in earnest what reality (realness) really is, he will notice that when we are in doubt whether something is real or not, we go, in daily life as well as in science, the way of gathering as many observations as possible about the subject concerned and seeking to find as close a connection as possible among these observations. One experiments not only in science but also in daily life. The criterion of reality summons to ever new work — both to find or produce new observations and to

find a closer connection among the observations found. The concept of reality stands as an ideal we can approach, but which always makes new demands. Armed with this ideal the great humor pushes all dogmatic realism aside. No given reality satisfies the concept of reality. (Cf. § 34).

Within such a view of existence as this at once experimental and ideal concept of reality makes possible, one can unite interest in and understanding of the single in its *[172]* peculiarity and its worth with a view toward a greater whole. However vanishing the single may seem, its worth nevertheless never becomes zero. And the greater whole itself, of which it is a member, proves in turn to be vanishing over against more comprehensive wholes. It may perhaps be foreseen that its time too will one day be over, as Shakespeare's Prospero divines it, and as modern scientists have often assumed as regards our world system. One need not be an optimist at all to be a humorist; on the contrary, optimism (cf. § 48) will exclude humor by preventing a sufficiently thorough penetration into all sides of life. The humorist will not belong among those who rejoice over how gloriously far we have brought things; such joy will rather awaken his irony. He knows that the struggle between the human and the animal is long; it goes, like a modern war, from trench to trench. But as long as there is still fighting, hope and trust are both possible and necessary. For Charles Darwin this slowness of development was not the greatest stumbling block. What stood for him as a difficulty was that when development had advanced through enormous periods of time, everything should then dissolve again into a chaos. He writes to Hooker (9 Feb. 1865): "I quite agree how humiliating man's slow progress is; but everyone has his own hobbyhorse as regards fear (his own pet horror), and the slow progress, indeed even personal annihilation, sinks in my eyes into an insignificance compared with the representation, or rather the certainty, that the sun will one day grow cold and we all freeze to death. To think of a progress through millions of years, with every continent swarming with good and enlightened men, and everything ending thus, without there probably coming any new beginning before our planetary system has again become red-hot gas! Sic transit gloria mundi — with a nemesis (with a vengeance)." — Darwin did not, however, give up his faith that development in the world had the upper hand over dissolution. He found, like Kant, the fixed point in the feeling of duty. "Man can do his duty." From the possibility of realizing something valuable there

[173] shone at last the light in which it became possible for him to live and strive.[106]

Should it be that the spring of values were one day exhausted, because everything in the end came into absolute equilibrium, then, as already said (§ 30), the humorist will not be able to take this humorously. Then he admits that the tragic gets the last word. Indeed, he would wish that it could get the last word. For it will unfortunately go so that the extinction of psychical life will be preceded by a period of weakening and dullness in which there will not even be talk of tragic suffering. The tragic presupposes strength. But the humorist works as long as he can to find new values, and he takes a critical attitude toward all theories, speculations and perspectives that dogmatize without sufficient ground about "the last things." Physics at bottom knows no more about them than theology. Just as little as there is reason for, perhaps not even possibility of, thinking of a conclusion of time and space, just as little can proof ever be given that all possibilities are exhausted, "all sounds closed." By virtue of the unsurveyability of the intellectual background existence can always come to stand as new.

54. From realism one does not come with necessity to humor. But critical realism can perhaps furnish a background for humor better than most idealistic directions.

A necessary component of such a critical realism is the acknowledgment of the fact that every personality, to a greater or lesser degree and with greater or lesser consciousness, forms and must form its own view of life, which cannot without more ado be derived from the positive or negative dogmas to which individuals profess allegiance. Precisely from a realistic standpoint it must be demanded that everyone build his view of life on his own experiences and with the help of the knowledge he has won by the work of his own thought. Only so does it build on the ground of reality, on what is really
[174] reality for the single person. A view of life is worth something only when it is really the expression of how life stirs at the definite place in existence the single person occupies. The demand for personal truth is realistic, although it was first put forward by an idealist.

Experience shows more and more how meaningless dogmatic declarations can be in relation to the realities of the inner life. From what is confessed, sung and proclaimed one can draw no sure conclusion if one does not gain access by another path to the inner life that lies behind. Behind theology or anti-theology the realist, and the humorist with

[106] See my paper on *Darwin og Filosofien* in the Festschrift "Darwin and Modern Science" published in Cambridge, in Danish in "Mindre Arbejder," Third series. (p. 225–228).

him, seeks psychology. He knows that in the inner world of the mind great things can go on in all quietness, and the noisy disputes about the index and the headings of the book of life only draw a smile from him. The principle of personality works not only dissolvingly against every kind of dogmatism and every kind of superficial community; it also expresses the inexhaustibility of the inner life.[107] There opens here an inner world that belongs to the intellectual background of the life of feeling. In each single personality this inner world can find expression only in a more or less one-sided way. It goes with the art of life as with the visual arts, which, as Julius Lange so energetically maintained, must be one-sided because "no single work of art can communicate the many-sided conception of the human figure."[108]

By acknowledging this view the great humor acknowledges at the same time its own limitation. Even if it should have ever so great a significance as a characteristic total feeling in which everything human can come into its own, it will nevertheless never be able to proclaim itself as the only right way of taking life. It takes a humorous attitude here toward itself. On the ground of reality it sees human life unfold from the most different starting points and under the most different conditions of conflict, and it understands that all development proceeds sporadically. Therefore it does not wonder that total feelings come to be of different character. It is not strange that not all are humorists. And even if they were, they would be so each in his own way. Harmony *[175]* and community are great goods, but must not be bought with the sacrifice of originality and genuineness in single persons. The sporadic character of development makes the world of spirit at once great and small, tragic and comic — and this contains (cf. § 35) an occasion for the arising of the total feeling we have been occupied with here.

[107] See *Religionsfilosofi*[2]. p. 284–286.
[108] See *Religionsfilosofi*[2]. p. 256.

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